This Burden Came To Me

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/27901582.

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General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Scorpia (She-Ra), Angella & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
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Part 2 of 'Cause There's Magic In My Bones (Magicatra AU)

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by catrasredemption (dimensionhoppingrose)

Summary

-Magicatra AU, Season Three, Four (sequel to This Is My Kingdom Come)-

Catra's search for answers becomes even more complicated by the appearance of Shadow Weaver in Bright Moon - the person who holds the key to Catra's past.

Adora, exiled to the Crimson Waste after Shadow Weaver betrays her, finds herself on her own journey to stay alive.

Uneasy alliances are formed, friendships are tested, and mistakes are made, which will follow everyone for a long, long time.

-Season Three Complete-
-Season Four Complete-

Notes

Who's ready? I'm ready! Let's goooooooooooooooo

See the end of the work for more notes

Answers, Questions

She stares up at the giant mural, clutching an old and well-loved teddy bear to her chest. The adults are talking behind her — every now and again she'll hear words like "impossible" and "too young" and "must be another", and her ears will twitch, but she isn't paying attention…

Someone is watching her.

Catra slowly wakes up without opening her eyes, sensing the other presence in the room with her. *Smelling* it. It's familiar. Why does it smell so familiar? Why does she taste something bitter in the back of her throat? Something sharp and cold and electrifying and—

Oh.

She's up in the time it takes to blink, her fist slamming into Shadow Weaver's mask with a satisfying *crack*. The sorceress has certainly seen better days, she thinks as she stands over the heap of red robes, before grabbing her and slamming her into the wall. Her mask is cracked, the red gem that had been in the middle of her forehead gone. Catra has a million questions. She can only vocalize one.

"What the *fuck* do you want?"

"She was watching you sleep? That's so *creepy*."

"Yeah, that's kind of her M.O."

Catra, Glimmer, and Bow are at the end of the hall, watching Castaspella and Angella talk outside of Shadow Weaver's "prison" room. Angella is talking about guards, about tripling the patrol around the perimeter, trying to figure out how she got in…

"She used magic to get here," Catra mutters. She's sitting against the wall, one leg drawn up to her chest. "Adding more guards onto a patrol isn't going to help."

"What do you think she *wants*?" Glimmer asks. "Is she trying to like, infiltrate the castle or something?"

"Shadow Weaver's out of commission."

Catra shakes her head. "No. Adora made it sound like Shadow Weaver isn't really part of the picture anymore. Also, the bitch has never done any of her own dirty work. That's what her precious force captains are for."

"And you don't think maybe Adora lied?" Bow asks slowly.

"Adora can't lie to save her life." *Or mine, for that matter.* "And Shadow Weaver wasn't looking too great. Not to mention she let me get the drop on her out of a dead sleep. *Something* is going on. I don't think it has anything to do with the Horde, though."

Shadow Weaver only cares about herself, after all. She wouldn't be here, putting herself in danger, if she had any other way of going about things.

Catra pushes herself up, starting down the hall toward the two women. Castaspella stops talking, eyeing her warily, and Angella turns.

She speaks before Catra can even open her mouth. "No."

"*What*?" Catra demands. "You can't be serious."

"You're not talking to her, Catra."

"She *tortured* me! I think I can handle a conversation!"

"Do you want to give her a chance to torture you again?" Castaspella asks quietly. Catra grimaces, hesitating.

"Let us handle this."Angella takes advantage of the silence. "It' s okay for you to step away from this."

"What if I dont *want* to step away from this?I've earned a chance to look her in the eye and demand answers, havent I?"

"Maybe theyre right,"Glimmer speaks up. "Y ou do get kind of… emotional when it comes to her."

Catra holds Angella's gaze without blinking. The queen hesitates for a moment before nodding. "One chance, Catra."

She smiles grimly. "That' s all I need, your majesty ."

The guard opens the door, allowing Catra to step in, flanked by Angella and Castaspella.

"Catra."Shadow W eaver's twisted smile is audible in her voice. "How nice of you to visit."

"I thought I owed you some good hospitality considering how well you and Adora treated me after the Princess Prom."Catra crosses the room in several long strides, crouching so she's eye to eye with the woman. "Speaking of Adora, she the one who put that crack in your face?Unfortunate for your mask, but still better than what it' s hiding."

Shadow Weaver chuckles humorlessly. "Using wit to cover your fears. You truly havent changed."

Catra smirks back. "But *you* have. Did your favorite good girl finally figure out your bullshit and turn on you?"

"Y our bad habits were bound to wear off on her eventually."

"Oh no,"Catra says, holding up a hand. "Nuh uh, you dont get to blame Adora's mistakes on me this time. *I've* been gone for a year. Youre the only one who' s been around to fuck with her. So what was

the tipping point? What *finally* drove her over the edge after like nineteen years of your crap?"

No answer. Catra has to struggle to keep from being too smug. She doesn't need to know *why* Adora turned on Shadow Weaver. She just needs to know she's right. And the silence confirms everything. "About time she finally got some common sense."

"Are you enjoying yourself?"

A smile quirks at Catra's lips. "A little, yeah. It's about damn time the universe threw me a bone, and you as our prisoner is pretty great."

"Don't flatter yourself," Shadow Weaver says coldly. "I came here of my own will. You didn't capture me."

"And yet you're still in our—" She looks around, grimacing. "I guess *prison* is a bit generous."

She hears Angella sigh faintly at the slight dig. Shadow Weaver's eyes narrow. "I wouldn't be here at all if you could manage to be a more competent hero."

That gets a reaction. Catra's ears twitch, her jaw clenching. "And what the hell is *that* supposed to mean?"

"You're *She-Ra*, aren't you?" Shadow Weaver's voice is filled with contempt. "It's *your* job to stop the Horde and save Etheria. And yet, Adora's made more progress as a force captain than you can with magic on your side." Catra's fingers curl into fists. "You couldn't even rally the princesses properly. One of them turned to the Horde to—"

"Shut *up*!" Catra growls, immediately straightening up to stand over Shadow Weaver.

"And there's the anger. Have your little friends ever seen one of your temper tantrums?"

Angella grabs Catra's shoulder, gently pulling her back before she can take a swing at the sorceress. "A break, perhaps," she suggests, taking Catra by the arm and leading her out of the room. Castaspella glares at Shadow Weaver before closing the door. "It may be best to leave the questioning to us," the queen says, already knowing the answer.

"Let me hit her a few times, I'm sure I'll get *somewhere*," Catra says darkly.

"*You* need to stand back," Angella says firmly. "Go back to bed. Get a few more hours of sleep."

"And *what*, go for a walk when I wake up?" Catra shoots back. "I can't *sleep* knowing she's here! And we still don't know what she wants! She wouldn't just turn herself over, she's planning *something*!"

"And *we* will find out what. *You* will find something else to occupy your time."

"But"—

"That is an order, Catra." Her ears go flat against her head, her gaze reproachful. She respects Angella, but she's not about to let this go. "I will be posting guards at either end of the hall, and at the doors. All three of you are banned from this corridor."

Glimmer knows that voice. "Come on, Catra." She takes her friend's hand, tugging lightly. "Mom and Aunt Casta can handle this."

Catra lets herself be pulled away, her breathing very deliberately slow, until she knows they're out of earshot; then she yanks her hand back and slams her fist into the wall. "Hey, don't break yourself," Bow protests.

"I need a punching bag or something," Catra says, kicking the wall half-heartedly. "Show her a fucking *temper tantrum*"…

Adora gasps, shooting up. It takes her blurry vision a moment to focus, to take in her settings. Green walls with marks carved into them. Cuffs around her hands.

The prison block.

She sighs, slumping against the wall, taking a few deep breaths to calm herself. *Okay. This is a mess. But I can fix it*.

Could she? Of course she could. She could fix anything. She…

She is so utterly and entirely *screwed*.

Adora stares at the ceiling for a long moment, turning everything over in her head. She had done everything right, hadn't she? She'd brought Hordak the things he wanted, she had gone up against the Rebellion and sure, she hadn't *won*, but she had made it further than Shadow Weaver ever did. She had proved her worth.

And of course, it all went wrong. Of *course* it did. Because she'd let Shadow Weaver get in her head. Again.

When is she going to stop doing that?

"Adora!"

She jumps, surprised, as Scorpia's voice echoes through the cell block. Not one for stealth missions, clearly. "Adora, where ~~oh~~!" She stops in front of Adora's cell. "There you are. Thank goodness. We need to get you out of here."

"Wait, what? Why? How did you even get in here?"

"Oh, it was super stealthy," Scorpia assures her. She highly doubts that. "Hordak's called an assembly. To witness your punishment." She frowns, hitting a button again. "Wow, these buttons are really small."

"Okay , okay, slow down," Adora says quickly . She's not getting involved in any more jailbreaks. Not even her own. "It's a bit late to say let's not do anything stupid, but"—

"Getting you out of here isn't stupid," Scorpia insists. "Look, when Hordak calls assemblies, it's bad, okay? He wants an audience to see him kill you."

Adora slumps against the wall, sighing. "Maybe he'll make it quick."

"Don't say that!" Scorpia's voice echoes through the prison block. Adora frowns at her.

"What do you care?"

The look Scorpia gives her is almost scandalized. "You're my *friend*. I want to protect you."

Adora softens for the slightest moment. She thinks Catra would like Scorpia, minus incessant hugging. Then she remembers how she ended up here.

"Forget it, Scorpia. This isn't worth it."

"What do you mean?"

"I *mean* breaking out isn't going to work. Where would I even go?" Her entire life has always been the Horde.

"We'll figure it out"—

"There *is* no we. There's me. Just me." Just Adora. Alone. Again.

"That's not"—

Adora raises her voice to yell, "Guards!" while looking Scorpia square in the eye. They stare at each other for a long moment before Scorpia reluctantly backs away and hurries off, leaving Adora behind.

"This isn't working, and she's getting worse"—

"Getting worse how?"

Castaspella and Angella jump, whirling to see Catra standing behind them, arms folded. Bow and Glimmer appear behind her a moment later.

"*How* is she faster than your teleporting?" Angella asks in disbelief.

"I scaled the castle," Catra replies flatly. "Worse *how*?"

"I told you to let us take care of it"—

"And Castaspella just said it isn't working," Catra cuts in. Angella takes a deep breath. Catra knows a 'you're testing my patience' expression when she sees one. "I know something's wrong with her. Did she say what, at least?"

"No," Castaspella says quietly. "But the worse it gets, the less I believe we'll be able to treat it."

"Why wouldn't she just say what's wrong?" Bow asks, frowning. "I mean, she probably came here for help, didn't she?"

"She's a vindictive bitch and would die just to spite a person," Catra says.

"Not quite how I would have put it," Angella says, "but that is the basic gist of it, I believe. She wants to talk to you."

"Oh, perfect then, let's go." Angella rests a hand on Catra's shoulder to stop her. "*What*?"

"You can't keep your temper in check in with her."

Catra grits her teeth. "I highly doubt she expects me to play nice."

"That's not the point."

"We're trying to protect you," Glimmer speaks up. "Why can't you let us do that?"

"Because that doesn't *matter* right now! She's *here*, and we need to get answers out of her before she—" Catra stops, blinking a few times. "Oh."

"What?" Angella asks sharply. Catra's expression darkens.

"Just give me one more chance." Pleading eyes met Angella's. "*Please*?"

She won't rest until she gets what she wants, and they all know it. "One more chance," Angella finally gives in. Catra takes a step passed her, into the room.

"You're dying."

Shadow Weaver looks up at her former ward, who's glaring at her with pure contempt. "That's why you're here, isn't it? You want She-Ra to heal you."

The sorceress chuckles. Catra watches in disgusts as shadows practically drip off her frazzled form. "You could have been so much more. Instead you're a walking pile of wasted potential"—

"Wow, you're the *worst* at asking for a favor."

"I would never ask *you* for a favor. I'm looking for a fair trade."

Catra scoffs. "*Really*. You think you have something that's equal to me saving your life after the shit you put me through?"

"I have information. About the Horde, and Hordak's plans. And about *you*."

Catra's ears twitch, her shoulders falling just slightly. She can feel the others behind her, watching her. "What do you know?"

"That's a bit of a broad question, isn't it? I know a lot of things—"

"If you want help, then tell me the truth," Catra snaps, fists clenching. "I'm not playing your fucking mind games anymore."

Shadow Weaver coughs even as she laughs. "You won't let me die. You need me if you want answers."

"You *really* want to put your life on the line of how much I hate you versus how much I want to know things? I can find answers anywhere if I look hard enough. *You* can only find one person to help you."

They glare at each other for a long moment. "That's the problem, though, isn't it?" Shadow Weaver finally says. "There's nowhere else to find the one answer you really want."

"Oh yeah? Do tell, what do you think I *really* want to know?"

"Where you come from, of course." Catra's entire facade falls. "You want to know how I got the mask, don't you? How *you* ended up in the Fright Zone?"

Catra's fists clench to keep her fingers from trembling. "Tell me."

"Heal me first."

"Bullshit," Catra snaps. "You'll get what you want, and then turn on us."

"In case it's slipped your notice, I'm *powerless*. I have nothing to gain by lying to or tricking you," Shadow Weaver says. "Hordak has cast me aside. Adora betrayed me. I have nowhere else to go."

"Save me your sob story."

"It's not a story, it's simply a fact. Just as it's a fact that if you let me die, you'll never know the truth about yourself. Are you willing to risk that information for your own, stubborn pride?"

There's a blur of red and gold, then a clattering noise as Catra slams Shadow Weaver into a wall, and her mask falls to the stone floor. Several horrified gasps echo behind Catra as she looks her abuser dead in the eye. One hand is clenched around the front of Shadow Weaver's robes, the other pulled back, claws extended, ready to slice her neck open. Shadow Weaver laughs and coughs breathlessly.

"Will you put me out of my misery yourself, then?"

A very tense moment of silence follows. Glimmer is pretty sure she can teleport across the room and pull Catra away before she kills Shadow Weaver. But she's not one-hundred percent certain.

Catra jerks Shadow Weaver away from the wall and turns, shoving her back into the blue column of the magical prison. She wordlessy kicks the mask back to the sorceress, then taps the keychain on her belt, summoning the sword.

"Teach me how to heal you, and tell me the truth," she says through gritted teeth. "That's the deal."

"Catra," Angella starts to protest.

"I don't think this is the best idea"—

"That's the deal," Shadow Weaver agrees dryly. Catra keeps her eyes locked on her even as she raises the sword.

"For the honor of Grayskull."

Hesitant silence falls as Catra transforms, now hovering almost intimidatingly over Shadow Weaver. "Catra," Bow speaks up. "Are you sure this is okay?"

She doesn't take her gaze away from Shadow Weaver as she lowers the sword. "Teach me how to heal you."

Shadow Weaver looks up at her, face hidden under her mask once more. "You must channel your energy through the Runestone *without* losing your temper or growing angry. Your emotions have always been your downfall, Catra."

Catra closes her eyes to block out the sight of the woman, blowing out a breath and focusing on the energy thrumming through the sword. "Healing requires calm. Peace. Center yourself."

Calm. Catra takes a deep breath, remembering some of the meditation techniques Perfuma has taught her. Center herself. Focus on something that makes her happy. She thinks about the feeling of being crushed in loving hugs, of Angella's warm hands on her shoulders as she kisses her forehead, even the echoes of children laughing as they chase each other up and down the dark halls of the Fright Zone, creating fun in a world where none was meant to exist…

She's calm. She starts to glow. She opens her eyes, watching the energy swirl around her, and raises the sword, pressing the tip to Shadow Weaver's chest. There's a wild moment of panic where they're all concerned she's just going to run the sorceress through…

But then the golden light extends to Shadow Weaver, enveloping her. Catra is disgusted with herself as soon as she knows the woman is healed;she pulls back and de-transforms, kneeling so she's eye to eye with Shadow Weaver. The person who raised her. The person who relentlessly abused her.

"Tell. Me. The. Truth."

Shadow Weaver is silent for a long moment. "The First Ones tried to write the magicats out of the history, you know. They never wanted anyone to know about their contributions, or that there was a second part of She-Ra. It took years of studying and research to finally find the truth about the magicats, about the mask. The Sword of

Protection had been lost to time, but the mask…surely that would be under close guard. It would be easy to obtain, if I could find Half Moon.

"And I did."

Catra is struggling to keep herself from snapping. "The magicats were ahead of me. They knew danger was coming. The mask had already chosen someone to bond with, ensuring that they would someday be led to the sword. The mask on its own promised great power, however, if I could only get my hands on it. And so I led my one and only attack on the kingdom, using the chaos to find the mask. And the little girl it had chosen. I'm sure you can guess who it was."

The air has gone still. Catra's eyes are wide, horrified. "I took you and the mask, and I left the kingdom to be massacred by the rest of the army I had brought along. The magicats were strong, but they had lived in peace for too long. They never stood a chance."

The shadows got them.

"You killed them," Catra whispers weakly. "You… You slaughtered an entire kingdom just to get something that would never work for you."

"And I couldn't even get rid of you, once Adora had decided you were her new friend. A useless mask, and a disobedient child." Shadow Weaver chuckles. "I believe that's what one would call karmic retaliation. I tried to destroy the mask, but I should have known better. It found its way back to you. You had no idea what it was, though. And I'll admit, it was rather enjoyable to watch you walk around wearing it, clueless as to what its true nature."

Catra's expression is frozen, her claws digging into her skin hard enough to draw blood. "Where?" she whispered. "Where was Half Moon?"

"Somewhere in the Crimson W aste. Im sure the mask can lead the way, if you truly feel the need to find it."

A long moment of silence follows. Catra finally pushes herself up, walking passed the pillar of blue energy, passed her friends, and out the door.

The Horde had wiped out Half Moon.

She is actually, truly, completely the last magicat on Etheria. In the universe.

Everyone else is gone.

Glimmer and Bow call after her. Their voices echo in her ears.

The shadows got them.

They never stood a chance.

Queen C'yra. She was a lovely woman. Only ever wanted what was best for Etheria.

C'yra says we leave tonight.

"Catra."

Glimmer gently catches her arm, pulling her back. It's only then she realizes she's crying. "W e *have* to go to the Crimson Waste." Her voice breaks as she speaks. "Half Moon is there, whatever is up with Mara is there, the universe is practically pushing us toward it."

"It' s dangerous"—

Catra's temper flares. "Then Ill go alone!" she snaps, cutting Bow off. "Y ou guys have no idea what it's like to just stumble around every day surrounded by people who look *nothing* like you and never understanding why they put you down, or call you a freak or a weirdo or ~~or~~"—

She clenches her fists, scrubbing furiously at her eyes. "I *have* to do this. I have to know."

Bow and Glimmer exchange looks, and nod. "Then we're with you," Glimmer says, smiling.

"Best Friend Squad sticks together," Bow adds. Catra resists the urge to roll her eyes.

"I hate that stupid name."

That, of course, gets her wrapped in two pairs of arms as Bow and Glimmer hug her tight.

Wow, he really does want audience, Adora thinks as she takes in the small crowd on either side of her dead man walk. Scorpia is standing in the front of one group with Bonnie, Kyle, Rogelio. She spares them only a glance before looking up at Hordak, who's regarding her with an almost bored expression.

"I want you all to watch and learn," he says, standing, as Adora comes to a stop in front of the steps to his throne. "There is nothing I do not know." He starts down the stairs. "Nothing I am not willing to do to punish those who betray my touch. Your former Force Captain has proven to be compromised, ineffective, and worthless." That last part is said with a sneer as he stops in front of her, leaning in so they're face to face. They exchange lessons before Hordak continues on with his show.

"For the rest of you, take a lesson. This is what happens to failures."

"If I'm a failure, then what are *you*?"

Everyone gasps, whirling to look at Adora, who's still resolutely staring ahead at nothing. "You've been fighting this war, leading the Horde, for twenty years, and what have you accomplished? Taken a few villages? Killed a few important people? If were as great as

you're always saying you are, you would have already *won*. But you *didn't*, because you *can't*. That's why you put up with Shadow Weaver's crap until she got testy with you. That's why you need to put on this whole big *show* with me, isn't it? To prove you're still all-powerful so no one else sees through you."

Scorpia is making a high pitched noise in her throat, as if she wants to scream. Adora ignores her. Hordak lets out a half chuckle.

"Quite the speech, I'll commend you on that. But wasted. There's been a change of plans."

Adora whirls around, blinking. "What?"

"Adoraaaaaaaaa!" Hair wraps around Adora, pulling her into some approximation of a hug. "I saved your life!" Entrapta says happily before bouncing to stand with Hordak. "You're welcome!"

"Entrapta has interceded on your behalf." Hordak looks amused. He's won the upperhand here. "You should be thanking her. Instead of the many punishments I intended, you are being sent to retrieve First Ones tech for us in the Crimson Waste."

Adora's mouth drops open. "That place is a total dead zone," she protests, "Nothing"—

Nothing survives out there. Hordak chuckles as if he knows exactly how that sentence is going to end, and Adora understands.

Entrapta didn't save her. She just made Adora's death more painful.

The Crimson Waste

Chapter Summary

"If Shadow Weaver wanted to scare us ~~sc~~are me ~~sh~~ed do something bigger than show up dying on our doorstep. She doesn't leave the Fright Zone. She doesn't take unnecessary risks."

"You don't know that, Catra," Glimmer argues. "You said it yourself, it's been a year since you left. She's probably changed."

"Shadow Weaver is a self-serving bitch," Catra responds flatly. "She always has been, she always will be. She doesn't care about the Horde, or Etheria, really. But she happens to live on this planet so it's in her best interest to make sure it isn't destroyed. Otherwise, all she wants is power. If Hordak took away the runestone ~~a~~nd considering what Entrapta did, I'm willing to bet that's exactly what happened ~~th~~en there would be nothing to keep her there, and no reason to maintain her allegiance with the Horde."

"That's a lot of ifs we're trusting her on."

"I don't trust her. I think we should drop her in the middle of the Whispering Woods and see if she can survive in the wild without magic. But she has nothing to gain by lying, and everything to lose if Hordak destroys Etheria."

"There is no way Angella has approved this," Bow says, looking between Glimmer and Catra with a raised eyebrow. They exchange looks, and shrug.

"What she doesn't know won't hurt her. You got your tracker pad?"

Bow holds up with the coordinates already punched in. "Ready to go."

"Great!"

Glimmer grabs their shoulders, and in a sparkle of showers, they appear on the edge of the Crimson Waste. Bow keeps an arm around Catra's waist to keep her upright as she groans. "We're walking home," she informs Glimmer bitterly . Glimmer turns to answer, but stops, staring at Catra's face. Bow is staring as well. "What?" She reaches up, hand clasping her mask; she pulls it off to see it glowing. "Well... that's certainly a hint. What's the tracker pad got?"

Bow lets her go to check the tracker pad. "Static."

"Fantastic." Catra looks out across the waste land, then at her mask. "I guess this is the best lead we have right now , then?"

"Guess so." Glimmer sounds uncertain. They really haven't thought this through, Catra thinks.

"Well... let's get going then," Bow says brightly , ever the optimist. "Well just... walk in a straight line and keep an eye on the mask. What's the worst that could happen?"

Catra glares at him. "Did you *seriously* just say that?"

Bow grins weakly. Catra sighs, shaking her head and taking the lead into the wasteland. They walk in silence for a bit, Glimmer scanning the area around them while Catra stares at her mask, and Bow fiddles with his tracker pad.

"Um... maybe you guys should pay more attention?" Glimmer says, voice jumping up a few octaves, when she sees the remains of a Horde soldier.

"What?" Bow looks up, and stops. "Okay, yeah, that's a little… haunting, but this place doesn't seem too bad so far, does it?"

He looks to Catra for an answer—she's still walking, fingers wrapped around the edges of the mask. Bow and Glimmer exchange looks before the princess teleports them back to Catra's side.

"About what Shadow Weaver said…"

"Shadow Weaver lies," Catra says without hesitation. "Every single word out of her mouth that wasn't *useless mongrel* was always a lie. Why should I believe anything she says now?"

Bow rests a hand on her shoulder. "What if she's not lying?" he asks quietly.

Catra's determined expression twitches for a moment. "Then I need to see it for myself."

They're interrupted as the ground rocks beneath them. "What—"

"*Snake*!" Glimmer screeches. There's a three-headed snake barreling through the sand toward them.

"Uh—"

"Run!"

Sand is terrible, Catra decides in that moment. Sand is worse than snow. Her feet slip on the uneven surface, making it impossible for her to gain any traction and forcing her to run harder. This isn't going to work.

"You guys keep running!" she calls as she summons the sword and transforms it into a grappling hook. Her eyes are fixed on a tree branch ahead.

"What are you going to do?" Glimmer demands.

"Not die, probably ."

That's not reassuring, but Glimmer doesnt have time to argue. Catra throws the grappling hook, using her momentum to swing herself up onto the (thankfully) sturdy tree branch. Bow and Glimmer run under her;she qickly transforms the hook into a shield and dives of f the branch scratching one of the snake's heads before landing on the middle one. The uninjured head rears up to snap at her , and she jumps again, landing on that head with the shield face down, her feet landing on it. She surfs down the back side of snake (*that works, holy shit*), and skids across the sand. Back to a grappling hook, which she throws to hook onto the middle head.

The nekxfew moments are a blur of motion as the snake pulls Catra with it (she possibly didnt think this through), and she reorients herself to swing up to the snake's head. The head is thrashing, and she knows as soon as she lands that this isnt going to work;she screams as she's launched off the head, right into a ravine.

"*Do cats* always *land on their feet?" Adora asks doubtfully . Catra puffs up in indignation.*

"*Of course! Wanna see how far off the forge I can jump?*

"*Yeah!"*

Thirty feet. The answer had been thirty feet. This is definitely more than thirty feet.

Something whistles passed Catra;a net explodes in the ravine, catching onto the walls and cushioning her as she falls into it. One of Bow's trick arrows, she realizes dazedly.

"Y ou okay?

Catra looks up to see Bow and Glimmer standing at the edge of the ravine. "I've had better days,"she calls back as she jumps up. There

are easily enough footholds on the wall for her to climb back up to them. "But, weirdly , I've also had worse."

She sees a cloud of dust in the distance – the snake still rearing about. "Let's... maybe go in another direction," she suggests, pulling her mask off again and turning until she's pretty sure it's glowing the brightest. She takes a step forward. Bow grabs her before she walks right back off the ravine edge. "Oh. Thanks."

They walk parallel to the ravine, Catra's eyes flicking between their path and the glowing mask. "What do you think about what Shadow Weaver said?" Bow asks finally . "About the portal, I mean. It... lines up with that message from Mara, doesn't it?"

"*A portal?*" *Angella repeats, raising an eyebrow .*

"*Yes." Shadow Weaver draws out the word as if talking to a particularly slow child. "He intends to bring through the rest of the Horde's armies using this portal, and using them to conquer Etheria once and for all."*

Everyone behind Catra gasps. "Armies?" Angella repeats. "There's more of the Horde?

"*A force so large you can not comprehend it."*

"I don't know ," Catra says slowly . "She doesn't have anything to gain by lying about *that*."

"Unless this has all been a trick to scare us," Glimmer speaks up. They've already had this conversation three times, Catra thinks, sighing inwardly.

"If Shadow W eaver wanted to scare us – scare *me* – she'd do something bigger than show up dying on our doorstep. She doesn't leave the Fright Zone. She doesn't take unnecessary risks."

"You don't know that, Catra," Glimmer argues. "You said it yourself, it's been a *year* since you left. She's probably changed."

"Shadow Weaver is a self-serving bitch," Catra responds flatly. "She always has been, she *always* will be. She doesn't care about the Horde, or Etheria, really. But she happens to live on this planet so it's in her best interest to make sure it isn't destroyed. Otherwise, all she wants is power. If Hordak took away the runestone—and considering what Entrapta did, I'm willing to bet that's exactly what happened—then there would be nothing to keep her there, and no reason to maintain her allegiance with the Horde."

"That's a lot of ifs we're trusting her on."

"I don't *trust* her. *I* think we should drop her in the middle of the Whispering Woods and see if she can survive in the wild without magic. But she has nothing to gain by lying, and everything to lose if Hordak destroys Etheria."

"Shadow Weaver was basically Hordak's right hand man, wasn't she?" Bow asks, intervening before Glimmer could begin the cycle again. "Who do you think replaced her?"

"Adora." The response is instant. "It's basically what Shadow Weaver raised her for. To be the perfect soldier and leader. She just never considered the possibility that Adora would grow a spine."

That's possibly a little more aggressive than necessary. Bow and Glimmer exchange glances. "Do you...wanna talk about it?" Bow asks finally. Catra huffs, kicking at sand.

"There's nothing to talk about. Adora was the perfect child who could do no wrong and the standard no one to could live up to. And when I, inevitably, failed to be just as perfect, I was punished, then had to listen to Adora say shit like 'well you *are* kind of disrespectful'—"

She's interrupted by two pairs of arms wrapping tight around her. "Sorry," Bow says. "I shouldn't have brought it up."

"No, it's fine," Catra assures him. "I should probably talk about it or something. It's healthy or... whatever."

She manages to get an arm out and wrap it around both of them — sort of. Her fingers rest on Glimmer's shoulder. "Okay, okay. That's enough love for the day. Come on, we need to find..."

Her voice drifts off as they turn around, facing a cliff wall, and sees a symbol lighting up on it. It looks like her mask. The cliff shakes, a portion of it sliding away to reveal an entrance. The trio stares, mouth mouth hanging open.

"Well," Catra says after a moment. "That's probably a hint."

Rock bottom needs less sand.

"Starting to think people who don't wear shoes have the right idea," Adora mutters, stopping once again to empty the sand from her boots. "Then again." How many times had she pulled something sharp out of Catra's foot? "Maybe not."

"Aren't you *hot* in that jacket?" Scorpia asks, panting slightly as she tries to keep up. She's not built for traveling on foot. "I'm dying over here."

"Please don't, I can't carry your body back to the Fright Zone."

"Aaaawww, you'd want to bring my body home? That's so creepily sweet."

Adora presses the heel of her palm into her forehead, sighing. "Why are you *here*? Hordak didn't exile you."

"Technically he didn't exile you, either"—

"No, he sent me on a suicide mission, which *Entrapta* encouraged." Adora speaks through her teeth. "That's *so* much better."

She knows she shouldn't be mad at Entrapta. Or Scorpia, for that matter. This is all Hordak's fault, when it comes down to it. *One* mistake after an entire *life* of doing everything right (one stolen skiff excluded), and *this* is the punishment she gets?

Maybe Shadow Weaver just made it to easy for you. The voice in her head sounds suspiciously like Catra. *You're not Hordak's precious golden child the way you were hers*.

No. Adora shakes her head. That doesn't matter. She worked for everything she had. And now she's going to die in a wasteland because she had *one* moment of weakness. How is *she* the one being punished? Catra was the one who always mouthed off to everyone and showed up late for training if she bothered at all and *she* got to skip off and be happy with *princesses*—

Adora stops short, blinking rapidly. "...And really if we can just find shelter, we—oof!" Scorpia had kept talking and not paying attention; she walks into Adora and nearly knocks them both over. "Sorry! Are you okay?"

"Yeah." *No*. "I'm fine."

Where had *those* thoughts come from? She doesn't really feel this way—doesn't resent Catra, never has. Right?

"*There's nothing for me in the Fright Zone.*"

Or maybe Catra's known something all along that Adora's been too blind to see.

Adora scans the area around them, trying to distract herself from the conflicting thoughts. She's not expecting to find anything, and yet…

"Is...that a building?"

"What?" Scorpia looks in the same direction, tilting her head. "Huh. That's weird. I thought this place was deserted."

"Might as well check it out. Give me your badge."

"What?"

Adora is already unpinning her own. "We don't know what we're walking into, and I don't particularly want to advertise that we're with the Horde."

"Oh. Yeah, good thinking."

Both badges go in Adora's pocket, and they start off in the direction of the building. It's a bar, as it turns out. A surprisingly bustling bar. "Wow." Scorpia scans the bar, noticing eyes turning in their direction. "Looks pretty lifeful to me. Life...ed? Not lifeless. Lively!"

Adora makes for the counter, sitting down, gaze still drifting around. Scorpia's skittish as she follows. "Maybe this isn't the best place to take a break."

"Do *you* want to sit out in the sun?" Adora asks, raising an eyebrow. "Besides, no one's going to bother us. Just...look intimidating."

"Oh. Right, I can do that!"

She tries to put on a serious face. Even Hordak at his worst wouldn't have been afraid of it. Hopefully everyone here is dumber than Hordak.

Laughter echoes through the bar. "Do you think the snake got 'em?" A goat lady with purple fur was talking. There was a group gathered at a table in the corner, chuckling as they spoke.

"Probably. Nothing can outrun that thing."

"The cat seemed pretty fast," someone else points out. Adora immediately sits up straighter, frowning. *Cat*?

"Those other two were slowin' her down, though," another scoffs. "Serves 'em right for walkin' in like they own the place."...

Adora hops off the barstool, walking across the room and ignoring Scorpia's desperate whispering of her name.

"And even if they did live, they won't survive out there. Maybe they'll have something good on their bodies"—

"You said cat," Adora interrupts without shame, drawing looks from the group. The goat lady raises an eyebrow.

"Can I help you?"

"Sure can." Adora ignores the sarcasm. "Did the cat have a sparkly girl and a guy with a bow with her? Which way did they go?"

The woman makes a noise of disbelief, standing. "You're an outsider, aren't you?"

Adora raises an eyebrow. "Is there an answer to that question that'll get me what I want faster?"

That gets her shoved back. Scorpia winces. "Adora, maybe we should go"—

"Better listen to your friend."

"Or what?" Adora challenges, straightening up. People who were actually strong didn't need to put on a front like this. The lady's faking it, hoping Adora will get scared and run off.

"Or I'll"—

The threat remains unfinished as a large hand grabs her by the back of her shirt. The tough demeanor immediately fades. "W-We didn't mean to disturb"—

A large, white-haired lady with purple skin tosses the goat lady outside before she can finish, turning back to glare at Adora and Scorpia. "Listen up. There's only two rules in the Crimson Waste"—

"Hey , I know you!" Scorpia bursts out suddenly , making Adora jump. The woman looks up, meeting Scorpia's gaze, then grabs them both and shoves them toward the door, walking out into the desert with them. "Ow , okay, a little rough"—

"Shut it," the woman growls. "What're you doing here, Scorpia?"

"You two know each other?" Adora asks, looking between them.

"Yeah, this is Huntara. She used to work for the Horde."

"Don't say that so loud," Huntara hisses. "I happen to enjoy my privacy around here."

"How much privacy do you get if you're throwing people out of the bar on a daily basis?" Adora asks, raising an eyebrow . Huntara glares at her.

"Listen, Blondie"—

"It's Adora."

"You're lucky I dragged you out of there before things got ugly . Now answer the question. *What* are you doing here?"

"Oh, we're looking for"—

"Our friends!" Adora cuts Scorpia off quickly . Huntara *used* to work for the Horde. Which means she doesn't anymore. Either she was exiled, or she left. Either way , she probably won't react well to two force captains on her turf. And maybe she can help them. "They uh...jumped ship, ya know? Deserted. We want to join them."

Huntara raises an eyebrow, crossing her arms. Scorpia looks at her in bewilderment. "We might've seen your friends," Huntara says finally . "Way out on the eastern edges. Nothing out there but sand."

"They might know something we don't," Adora says slowly .

"They don't know something *I* don't."

"Um, Adora?" Scorpia tugs her arm, pulling her away from Huntara. "What're you doing?" she whispers, confused.

"Trying to get us help."

"To find Catra and her friends? That's not what Hordak sent us out here for."

"Why do you think *they're* in the middle of literal nowhere? They must be looking for First Ones' tech. Which saves us a *lot* of work."

"And what do you plan on doing when Huntara finds out you lied to her?"

"I dunno, I'll figure it," Adora huffs. "I am *not* dying in this place."

Scorpia looks at her for a minute, then sighs. "Okay. If you think this is a good idea..."

Adora smiles encouragingly (she hopes), and walks back to Huntara. "Sorry about that, Horde and all... never know who you can trust."

"Hmph," Huntara grunts, looking at Scorpia. "Never thought *you'd* be the one to get into that mindset."

"Yeah, well." Scorpia chuckles, shrugging. "The Horde's changed a lot since you left. Lotta weird things going on with magic and people deserting and... you know."

"Thankfully, I don't."

"Oh, right."

"Not to interrupt," Adora speaks up, trying not to sound too anxious or frustrated. "But... our friends?"

"Right. Cat girl, boy, and shiny one."

"Sounds like them. Are you *sure* there was nothing in the direction they were going?"

Huntara snorts. "Nothing but sand and snakes." She pauses, tilting her head. "Cat girl *did* have something though. Couldn't tell what it was, we were too far away. But it was glowing."

Adora immediately straightens up. The mask. "We *really* need to find them. If it isn't too much to ask"…

Huntara looks between her and Scorpia for a minute. Scorpia gives her a hopeful little smile. "Ugh," she finally groans. "*Fine*. You're lucky you have Scorpia with you."

It takes everything Adora has in her not to jump and cheer. "Sure am," she says simply, settling for a smile.

Maybe they can still turn this around.

"This is kinda"…

"Creepy," Glimmer finishes Bow's thought. "It's creepy."

"Angella *did* say she and Micah were teleported here," Catra says. She's leading the way with the still glowing mask as they walk down the winding stone staircase. They can see *something* in the darkness surrounding them, but the light doesn't go far enough to make out any details. "It's probably pretty far under"—

She's interrupted by steps suddenly disappearing—there's a gap between where they are and the next step that she completely missed.

"Catra!"

The ground isn't *too* far, at least. Catra lands hard on her left side, and she knows she's going to be feeling that for the next day or so,

but overall it could be worse. She picks herself up, groaning, and looks around. "Are you okay?" Glimmer asks as she and Bow appear next to her. "Why do you keep falling?"

"Not exactly what I'm trying to do, Sparkles," Catra mutters, squinting. She can make out shadows close by. "Come on."

They only go a few feet before she feels something change in the air, as if they've stepped over a threshold. Torches flicker to life on either side of them, and light slowly begins to spread out as more torches follow suit. Catra's mask finally stops glowing; she puts it back on, stunned.

"We found it." Her voice is weak. None of them say what they're all thinking—it's too dark, too quiet. This is a place that hadn't seen life for a very long time.

Still, Catra started forward, down the path which leads to a small village. They find the first bodies when they look into a hut.

"Oh," Glimmer whispers, hand over her mouth. Bow takes a step back, pulling Glimmer with him. He tries to pull Catra as well, but she's rooted in place. They're not even really bodies anymore — mostly skeletons, left to collect dust underground for the last seventeen years.

This isn't a kingdom anymore. It's a tomb.

Catra finally steps back, realizing she's crying. A shaking hand goes to her face, wiping the tears away.

"She murdered an entire kingdom for something that would never work for her." Catra isn't actually sure she'd said anything until Bow responds.

"I'm sorry, Catra."

He and Glimmer wrap her in a hug. She's not in any position to return it, but they don't seem to mind. "Let's get out of here," Glimmer suggests gently. "We still need to find whatever is sending that signal"—

"No, I still want to go to the palace," Catra says, looking toward the structure in the distance. It's stupid to think maybe there's something there that can tell her more about what happened with the First Ones—tell the magicats' side of the story. But she hasn't given up that hope yet. "I *know* it's asking a lot, but"—

"We know." Bow rests a hand on her shoulder, smiling. "We're still in. Right?"

"Right," Glimmer agrees. Catra wipes her eyes, giving them a weak smile in return.

"Thanks, guys."

The palace isn't far—Glimmer teleports them to the front steps. Catra takes a deep breath, bracing herself before walking up and pretending not to see the skeletons on either side of them. Bow and Glimmer keep their gazes firmly ahead as well. The palace entrance hall is blessedly skeleton free.

"If there's anything about history, it'd probably be in a library," Bow suggests. "Man, my fathers would lose their minds if they could see"…

"Yeah, let's have everyone come gape at the fucking graveyard." Catra doesn't mean to sound so bitter, she really doesn't. But she's not having a good day.

Bow blushes a bit. "That's not what I…sorry."

Catra shakes her head. "It's fine. I'm sorry. I shouldn't have snapped."

Bow catches her in a quick hug. She assumes she's forgiven.

They stop in front of a large staircase, looking around. "So, which way to the library, do you think?" Glimmer asks after a moment.

"You're asking me?" Catra raises an eyebrow. "I've never even been here."

"Technically you don't know that," Bow points out. He's not wrong, Catra supposes. Maybe she had been here, once. Maybe she had lived here. *Fuck*, what if she was a princess?

No, no. Don't get ahead of yourself. You're already a part-time princess, there's no way you can be a full-time one, too.

The thought is only partially comforting.

"Let's just go."

They started up the stairs, stopping to peek into the rooms every now and again. They find a few more bodies, some dressed in royal wear, some dressed in simpler, servant clothing. All are mostly skeletons. Catra barely looks before moving on. There's only so much her sanity could take.

"Do... Do you guys see that glowing?"

Glimmer and Catra look ahead, squinting when they see the blue light. "What do you think"…

Glimmer's voice drifts off as Catra surges ahead. "Uh, Catra? Catra, hang on, we don't know"—The princess huffs in frustration, grabbing Bow and teleporting to keep up with her. "Catra, I know you want answers, but we have to be *careful*"—

"Gimme some light," Catra asks without looking back. Glimmer sighs, raising her hand and bringing a ball of light to life, letting it hover over them and revealing what had previously been a shadowed, barely lit wall.

It’s a mural. A large mural with magicat writing surrounding it. The figure in the middle of it all holds a familiar sword, wears a familiar mask. déjà vu hits her so hard that it sets her off balance. She steps back, letting out a long breath.

“You okay?” Bow asks gently. Catra shakes her head slowly.

“I… I think I’ve seen this before.”

Her eyes fall to the glowing blue orb, settled on a pedestal. Something draws her forward, hand out.

“Uh, I don’t think that’s a good idea—” Glimmer starts to protest. But Catra’s fingers are already brushing the smooth surface. Her vision whites out.

She’s on the ground when she wakes up, but not in the palace anymore. She lifts her head, staring dazedly at her surroundings. Barren. Stone. It’s the place she went to when Adora zapped her during the Bright Moon battle.

“*Hello, child*.”

Catra’s gaze snaps around. It’s the same thing as before. The weird cat with the shimmering mane and bright blue eyes. There’s a melancholy tone its voice.

“Um… hi,” Catra says slowly, standing. “Good to see you again. I think. Where are we?”

“*Home*.”

“Home?” Realization is starting to set in. She doesn’t like it. “So this…”

The cat nods slowly. “*This is Kytis. The homeworld of the magicats*.”

Melog

Chapter Summary

"Should we be worried?"

Bow looks up at Glimmer, who's sitting with Catra's head in her lap, watching her sleep. Is it sleep? She'd just passed out after touching the glowing orb. Is she even okay?

"I'm not sure," Bow admits. "She doesn't look like she's in pain or anything, though, so that's good, right? Maybe it's just some... Magicat thing."

"Maybe." Glimmer eyes the orb with suspicion. She would have thought Catra knew better than to just go *touching* glowy magic things, but apparently not. So much for being the common sense of their little trio.

"I'm sure she's fine," Bow assures Glimmer again with a small smile. "She'll probably wake up any minute now with a whole story for us. Or a lot of ranting and swearing."

"Or both."

They laugh, momentarily reassured. Maybe Catra is finally getting answers. That would be nice, Glimmer thinks. She deserves some peace.

"So, um... do you have a name, or?..."

You can call me Melog.

Catra follows the odd alien cat, raising an eyebrow. "Melog," she replies slowly. "Got it. Some um... this is Krytis? Place has seen better days."

It has been abandoned for a long time. There was a mournful note in the cat's tone. *Your ancestors escaped, and while we were able to hold off the invading force… I was left alone here*.

"You've been alone since everyone left?" That sounds…lonely. "Why didn't the Magicats come back? I mean, you've been able to talk to me, so you must have been able to talk to them…right?"

I do not believe they had the capabilities at the time. And the planet is no longer habitable for them. The cat nods its head around the landscape.

"Yeah it does seem kind of…dead," Catra says slowly, then winces. "Is that insensitive?"

Melog seems to chuckle, amused. *It's okay. You're not wrong. The invading force took… everything.*

"What was it?" What has the ability to kill an entire planet? Does Catra want to know? Hordak is bad enough…

I believe you you have other things to worry about at this moment.

"I'm getting sassed by an alien cat," Catra grumbles, rolling her eyes. She swears Melog is *smiling*. "Do…Do you know anything about… the Magicats and the First Ones?"

I know parts of it. Catra does her best not to get her hopes up. *When your ancestors left, they took some of the planet's magic with them, using it in combination with Etheria's to create the head piece you wear, as well as maintaining contact with Kytis. I believe their intention was to come back someday, if only for me*. *They were happy on Etheria. The planet and its magic suited them well.*

"Then what"… *What happened?* What could have divided the two races so completely? What parts of the history had the First Ones kept? What had they gotten rid of?

Who's the villain in this story?

"Should we be worried?"

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A loud crash echoes through cavern. Bow and Glimmer snap around to look out the nearest window, then back at each other. "Be right back," Glimmer says, standing and disappearing in a shower of sparkles. She reappears at the bottom of the stairs, hand glowing, ready for a fight.

"Ow." A familiar voice is groaning. Glimmer raises her hand to light up the area, and stiffens when she sees who's waiting for them.

"*Adora*."

The blonde snaps around, distracted from Scorpia, who had apparently fallen through stairs. Her eyes narrow when she sees Glimmer, hand going for the staff on her belt. "Princess." Her voice is cold. Glimmer's eyes flick to the third person with them — a large, purple-skinned woman with white hair and a lot of battle scars — and she knows she can't do this alone. She backs up, preparing to teleport, but Adora is just a split-second faster; she dives at Glimmer, grabbing her right before she disappears. They tumble back into the hall together, landing in a pile of limbs.

"What the—?"

Adora is momentarily distracted by their surroundings, giving Glimmer a chance to kick her off and teleport back to Bow's side. He's already standing, arrow knocked into place, guarding Catra. Adora glares at them.

"What did you do?" she demands.

"*I* teleported," Glimmer shoots back. "*You* decided to grab onto me for the ride back. Now don't move. You're outnumbered."

Adora scoffs, standing. "I think I can take you two."

"Hang on," Bow whispers to Glimmer, eyes flicking down to Catra. If they fight here, she's going to get caught in the crossfire. Adora follows Bow's gaze, and her jaw tightens. Bow raises his voice. "This doesn't have to be a fight, Adora. We know you care about her. *We* care about her."

"You don't know *anything*," Adora snaps, extending her staff. It's going to be a fight, then. Bow looses the arrow, and Adora swings her staff, catching it by the arrow by the tip and breaking it. Green goo explodes, dripping from the staff for a moment before hardening. Adora tosses it aside, pulling out a stun baton instead.

"*Nope*," Glimmer snaps, teleporting behind Adora and grabbing her, bringing her back outside. She wants to get to the entrance, or even

back into the Crimson Waste, but her magic falters. No, no, no, no, *no*! Not now!

Instead, they end up in the middle of the village. Adora whirls, barely missing hitting Glimmer with the stun baton, and the princess teleports back to Bow, dropping to her knees. "Don't tell me you're running low already." Bow's voice cracks as he speaks.

"I wasn't exactly expecting to be ambushed in the middle of nowhere!" Glimmer protests. Bow groans.

"We need to get out of here. Do you think it's safe to move Catra?"

They look at their still unconscious friend. "I don't know. But staying here and waiting for Adora and Scorpia and their scary new friend is definitely not the better option."

"Scary new friend?" Bow repeats.

"Yeah, big purple lady who looks like she could step on us. We *definitely* need to go."

Bow nods, grimacing. "Right. Help me get Catra on my back."

It takes a bit of maneuvering and huffing, but finally they managed to get Catra up and onto Bow's back. It's inconvenient considering he's the one with a weapon, but at the moment, it's the best they can do. "How far do you think you can get us?" Bow asks. Glimmer bites her lip, trying to think.

"Not to the entrance... maybe as far as I got Adora? But then we'll have to fight her again"—

She's cut off by the echo of a loud, booming voice. The words aren't quite audible, but the tone is unmistakably angry.

"That doesn't sound good."

"What do you mean you *lied to me*?!"

Scorpia had, unsurprisingly, crumpled under Huntara's scrutiny when Adora was gone. She holds up her pincers, trying to smile and look as non-threatening as possible. "I wouldn't say we *lied*, per se—"

"Then what *would* you say you did?" Huntara growls, drawing her weapon. Hoo boy, this is *not good*.

"We just... Adora really is trying to help her friend. I think. She's been a bit confusing lately. But she doesn't want to hurt anyone!" Scorpia rushes the words out as fast as she can. "And you wouldn't help us if you knew we're still technically with the Horde even if this particular thing isn't about the Horde—"

"So you *lied to me.*" The words are spoken through gritted teeth.

"I... I guess when you put it like that, yeah, I kind of did," Scorpia admits, shoulders falling in shame. She had *known* this was a bad idea. Why had she gone along with it?

Because Adora wanted to, and you want to help Adora.

Is this actually helping her, though?

A swinging fist brings Scorpia back to reality. She yelps, ducking and backing away. "C'mon, Hunty—" Her voice is weak. "We don't need to fight over this—"

"I *trusted you*," Huntara snarls, advancing. "And you pulled this crap—"

An explosion of light blinds them for a moment, and Huntara staggers slightly. Adora's standing a few feet away, stun baton out and sparking from the attack. But Huntara doesn't go down. She turns to Adora, expression dark.

"Bad move, Blondie. You should know if you want to attack me, you make sure I go down on the first shot."

"Huntara, wait!"—

Adora ducks around the attack, wishing she had her staff. Stupid archer and his stupid green gunk arrows. "Adora, don't," Scorpia pleads as Adora prepares the stun baton again. "It's not going to work. Let's just"—

She's cut off as Huntara attacks again, and again, Adora dodges. Being shorter than Huntara, who's used to fighting people her own size, is a bit of an advantage, at least.

Scorpia jumps when she hears a groan behind her, and turns to see the princess, the archer, and Catra. The princess is on her knees, Catra on the archer's back. He groans when he sees Scorpia.

"You've *got* to be kidding me."

He grabs the princess and drags her away as Scorpia dives at them. "Hey! Hold still!" Maybe she can still salvage this whole thing. As long as Huntara doesn't kill Adora.

"Glimmer," Bow says urgently as he backs up, one hand trying to support Catra, the other keeping Glimmer upright. His eyes are locked on Scorpia. "I don't like to be pushy, but we *reeeeeeeeeeeeally* need to get out of here."

"Just need a minute"—

They do *not* have a minute. Scorpia is already charging at them again. If Catra could just wake up, they could get out of this—

A purple blur knocks Scorpia off track, throwing her into a nearby wall. The scary lady towers over the trio, glaring down at them. "Are you with the Horde, too?"

"No," Bow and Glimmer say quickly.

"We can get you out of here, if you want," Glimmer adds, drawing herself up and squaring her shoulders, ready for one more teleport.

Scorpia is recovering from the blow, and Adora's out of sight, hiding from the scary lady's wrath. She sizes them up, and nods.

"Let's go."

It's been thousands of years since the Magicats left Kytis.

Catra tries to bite down a groan. "I *know* this part already. The First Ones saved the Magicats, and they all went to Etheria together."

Melog chuckles, amused. *Impatient, I see*.

"I've been trying to find answers for a long time. I just...really need to know about this. Please."

Melog nods, purring thoughtfully as they try to decide where to start. They're walking along, Catra taking in the destroyed landscape. What the hell is capable of doing something like this?

The Magicats were good. I may be biased in saying so, but their intentions were always pure. They wanted to make the universe a better place. They wanted to work with their saviors in order to protect the universe from a greater evil.

"The evil that destroyed this place," Catra guesses. Melog nods again.

They wanted to ensure that what happened here never happened to anyone else. And while I believe the First Ones had similar goals … their intentions were not as pure. They were neither good nor evil — they simply experimented, trying to find the best results.

Catra's mind flashes to Entrapta — not good, not evil. Just dedicated to science. "Yeah, I guess I get that. Kind of. So the working together thing didn't work out because they couldn't agree on things?"

Partially. Melog makes a sad, mournful noise. *They worked together to create the mask and the sword, with the Runestone embedded in the hilt. But the First Ones wanted more. They didn't want to just fight the great evil. They wanted to destroy it*.

"That doesn't seem like a horrible idea to me," Catra says slowly.

You're not wrong, Melog agrees. *But the First Ones took it too far. They wanted to lure the great evil to Etheria, and use the planet as a weapon to destroy it. The sword, the mask, and the person who wielded them would be the key to that weapon*.

Catra blinks a few times, the implications taking a moment to fully settle in. "They wanted to use She-Ra to turn Etheria into a giant super weapon."

Yes. The Magicats did not agree with this, of course. Their leader was very vocal about her refusal to allow their magic to be manipulated and used in such a way that would bring harm to anyone — there were other people inhabiting the planet. They would all die if the First Ones went through with their plan. They wanted to protect every living being. The First Ones, however, saw them as a necessary sacrifice. Some must die in order for everyone to live.

"That's... That's sick," Catra says slowly, hands shaking. "Lives don't work like that, a *necessary sacrifice* is just... murder."

Melog smiles gently. *Your ancestors agreed. C'yra, the leader of the clan, made it clear to the First Ones that they would not allow their magic to be twisted and used in needless slaughter. They planned to take the sword and the mask and go into hiding, to ensure that the First Ones would have no way of following through on their plans. But in the end, they could only get away with the mask*.

"So they... they ran away and went into hiding so the First Ones couldn't destroy Etheria?" Melog nods. "And the First Ones made sure that everyone believed the Magicats had betrayed them so no

one would question their motives. But what about Mara? Where does she come into all this?

I'm afraid I don't know who that is.

"She was the She-Ra before me, a First One. Light Hope — Someone told me she was overwhelmed by the power of the sword because there was no mask to balance it out, and she trapped Etheria in an empty universe because she went insane. Kind of." Light Hope's story had been pretty vague.

I know nothing of what became of the sword after the Magicats abandoned the First Ones, Melog says slowly. *Etheria did indeed disappear from the greater universe a thousand years ago, though. My connection with them was fractured after that. I could still communicate with them, but not as easily*.

"Why? I mean, we're talking now. And you talked to me before."

The power of the mask allows me to break through at times, usually during moments when the wielder is experiencing high stress. Almost being killed by her best friend qualifies as high stress, Catra decides. *Ideally, however, the mask would need to be connected to the other source of Magicat magic in order to fully form a connection*.

The blue orb, Catra guesses. "So you have no idea what happened with Mara, or if Light Hope is right about Mara not having the mask driving her insane."

I do not, Melog says mournfully. *I'm sorry I can't put your mind at ease*.

Catra sighs, shoulders dropping. "What am I supposed to do, then? Hordak wants to open a portal. Should I just let him? What happens if we come back to the larger universe? I mean besides this *great evil* finding us."

I can't say. I do not know the circumstances of the first portal being opened.

Catra drops to her knees, staring off into the distance. "So that's it, then. There's just *nothing*. I have to go back there and do something, and I have no idea what I should do. I dont know why Mara brought Etheria to that place to begin with, or whatll happen if I let Hordak open a portal to bring us back. I mean, I guess besides the great evil." She pressed her face into her hands, sighing. A gentle head nudges her arm — Melog, trying to offer comfort.

It is not fair that you carry this burden alone, they say. *And I can not offer you advice without knowing more of the situation myself. But the mask chose you for a reason. Trust in that power, and believe in yourself*.

They have no idea how hard both of those things are for Catra. How is she supposed to do either of those things?

It's time for you to go back, Melog says. *Your friends are waiting*.

Catra looks up, scanning the area around them. "Hey, maybe if Hordak gets us back to the regular universe, we can come get you from this place."

The alien cat chuckles. *I would like that*.

They're no longer underground.

Catra blinks, staring at the blank, dark sky. She could hear and smell a fire crackling somewhere nearby, and the low sound of hushed voices. A face appears in her field of vision.

"Sparkles?"

"You're awake!" Glimmer scoops her up, hugging her tight. They're joined a moment later by Bow.

"Hey guys," she groans, patting each of their backs. Her eyes fall on a nearby lady, sitting in front of the fire, which casts eerie shadows across her face. "Um... pick up a new friend while I was out?"

"Oh, right." Glimmer pulls away. "Catra, this is Huntara. She um… accidentally led Scorpia and Adora to us and then saved us when she realized they lied to her about deserting the Horde."

"What the *fuck*," Catra burst out in disbelief. "What are they doing in the middle of literal nowhere?"

"We didn't really stop to ask."

"They *said* they were looking for their friends," Huntara grumbles, clearly still insulted about being lied to. "What was that place? I've lived here for years, and I've never known about an underground kingdom."

"It's not much of a kingdom anymore," Catra says, rubbing the back of her head. "Thanks for helping. I didn't expect to be unconscious for that long."

"You expected to be unconscious at *all*?" Glimmer demands.

"Okay, no," Catra admits. "But I was... you know what, it's a long story. Worry about it later. We still need to find that signal. I bet that's what Adora and Scorpia are *really* here for, and they figured we're here for it too. Which means they're following us."

"Oh, right." Bow looks hopefully to Huntara. "Do you know anything about any hidden First One tech around here?"

Huntara raises an eyebrow. "I ain't a tour guide, kid. I left the Horde for a reason. I'm not getting mixed up in whatever all of this is."

"I don't blame you," Catra says, running a hand through her hair. "I didn't exactly leave the Horde because I had some glorious epiphany about how evil they are. But it's... it's really important that we find

whatever's out here, if there's anything. It *sucks*, but we need it. Also, Sparkles over there is a princess. She can pay you whatever you want."

"*Catra*," Glimmer hisses. She knows damn well they can't promise that. Huntara eyes them for a moment, then chuckles.

"Catra, huh? I remember hearing Shadow W eaver bitch about you."

She scoffs. "Of *course*. Someone should've let me hit her harder ."

"I'll see how I feel in the morning," she informs them. "But I think I might know what you're looking for . Need a good night's sleep after dragging those two all the way to that weird kingdom."

Glimmer sighs, and Bow grins, looking back at Catra. She shrugs tiredly. "W ell, I've been asleep half the day , apparently, so you guys get some sleep. I'll stand watch."

"What happened when you touched that orb?" Glimmer asks, frowning slightly.

"Remember when Adora tased me, and I had that weird dream about the alien on another planet?" Glimmer and Bow nod. "I ended up back there. Their name is Melog."

"Oh." They blink, waiting for Catra to deliver a punchline. She doesn't. "W ell, okay then. Did they help at all?"

"Sort of." She' s not sure how to feel about what Melog had told her. It had answered a lot of questions...and opened up so many more. "I'll tell you in the morning. Just get some sleep."

"Okay . Okay okay okay okay okay, we're good, we're good, weeeeee're good!"

Scorpia huffs as she and Adora finally manage to climb out of that cavern, both gasping for air. "Hoo boy ," the larger woman gasps, rubbing the back of her head. "That was definitely something. Uh. What was that?"

"Not sure." Adora pushes herself up, looking around. "Looked like some kind of abandoned kingdom."

"There are a *lot* of those," Scorpia says, standing as well. "Okay , so we're stuck in the middle of the Crimson W aste with no way of getting out. What now?"

"Now we find Catra and her little entourage and hope they lead us to whatever First One tech they're looking for ," Adora says, choosing a direction to start walking in.

"Y eah, about that." Scorpia jogs to keep up with her . "W e don't even know where they went, and that princess could've teleported them anywhere"—

"She has limits," Adora interrupts. "Her magic only goes so far . I'm guessing she needs to be near her precious runestone." Her voice might be slightly bitter. "And they won't leave until they find what they're looking for . I doubt they went too far."

Scorpia sighs. "I *guess*.what about Huntara, though? She' s pretty mad, and we're outnumbered."

"W ell figure it out, Scorpia. Don't worry so much."

"It' s not that I don't believe you," Scorpia assures her quickly . "I just don't want us to get lost out here, ya know? W e saw a *lot* of bodies on our way here."

"I know . Trust me, I don't want to end up like them either . Standing here isn't going to save us either , though."

They can still turn around and go back, Scorpia thinks forlornly. But Adora is already stubbornly walking forward, ready to continue this death trip. Scorpia hurries to catch up, not wanting to be left behind with nothing but sand and the creepy, empty kingdom below them.

Catra is exhausted by the time the sun starts to rise. Bow is up early, of course. What a morning person. "You should get some rest before we take off," he suggests with a small smile.

"Nope. I'm good."

Bow watches her, eyebrow raised. "You didn't get any answers, did you?"

"I got a few," Catra protests half-heartedly. "Nothing about Mara and what happened with the portal, though."

"Do you feel better?"

No. No she doesn't. That's not fair. Answers were supposed to help, weren't they? What else could she do? "Do you think letting Hordak open the portal would really be such a bad thing?" she asks after a moment, looking at Bow.

"Um... did you forget the Horde armies?"

Actually, she did. Catra grimaces, looking away. "Besides that. I mean, if Etheria belongs in another universe, shouldn't we want to get back there?"

Bow hesitates. "I'm not sure. We don't know what else is waiting out in that universe. We could walk right into danger we're not ready for."

Catra remembers what Melog said about "the great evil." She should have pushed more on that. "I know, I know." She drags her hands through her hair, sighing. Bow moves to sit with her, resting a hand on her shoulder and giving her a gentle smile.

"I know you want to fix Mara's and the Magicats' mistakes. I get it, I really do."

"Do you?" The words are more irritated than Catra means for them to be. Bow wilts slightly.

"Okay, not really," he admits. "But we've got your back. You know that, right?"

Catra sighs, nodding. "Yeah. I know, thanks Bow."

He gathers her up in a hug, half pulling her into his lap. She sighs. This isn't surprising, really.

"Are you hot? I'm hot. I'm really, really, really… *hot*."

Scorpia sighs, fanning herself with a pincer. It doesn't do much good. "Maybe we could stop and find some sh-oof!"

She grunts as she walks into Adora. "Oops! Sorry, are you -w-what's wrong?"

Adora is staring up, squinting. "Ambush," she says simply. Scorpia looks up as well, seeing the shadowy figures surrounding them from various perches.

"Oh boy."

Choices

Chapter Summary

> Adora looks around, taking in the shadowy figures. "Great. Dont suppose you know any of them."
>
> "Prooooooooobably not."
>
> A large, red Reptilian man jumps down in front of them, grinning down at Adora. "Didnt anyone ever tell you not to wander around the Wastes alone, Blondie?" he sneers, looking her up and down. Adora huffs impatiently.
>
> "Can we not with the big damn bad guy thing? Im not in the mood."
>
> Scorpia winces, half stepping forward to step between them, but the Reptilian had already grabbed Adora by the jacket. "Y ou better learn some respect, girl. Dont you know who I am?"
>
> "No, and I really dont care, honestly . Are you going to let me walk away, or do I have to make this embarrassing for you?"

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Y ou were with the Horde, but you left because your friend thought you were brainwashed by princesses and was going to let Shadow Weaver mess with your memories?" Huntara snorts. "Not very bright, is she?"

"Bright enough to fool you, apparently ."

That gets Catra a scowl. Bow and Glimmer resist the urge to facepalm. Catra is apparently incapable of playing nice with

someone who can break her in half. They're walking through the desert with a destination in mind, according to their guide.

"I trusted Scorpia," Huntara huffs. "She used to be a good person. That friend of yours is a bad influence."

Catra's laugh echoes in the empty air. "Oh man, that's a switch. Golden child Adora is the bad influence now."

"That's funny?" Huntara asks doubtfully.

"It's funny if you know how messed up our childhood was." Catra's laughter dies into low chuckles, then sighs. "No, actually, it's really not funny, but if I don't laugh, what else am I gonna do? Sparkles and Arrow Boy keep saying punching my feelings out isn't healthy."

"Definitely never been in the Horde." Huntara laughs. Bow and Glimmer exchange looks. Maybe they should have found another Horde defector sooner. Apparently Catra responded better to that than she did anything else.

"What're you leading us to, anyway?"

"To be honest, I'm not entirely sure," Huntara admits. "Dust storm kicked up, and it was unearthed. Everyone got what they could out of it. Stands out like a sore thumb. Literally. And it talks."

"It *talks*?"

"Yup. I hear it sometimes. *She-Ra*."

Catra frowns, looking forward. She can something glinting in the distance. "I take it we're almost there."

"Good eye, kitty cat." Catra glares at Huntara, who grins back. "It says other things too. Etheria. Gone. It's like it's on a loop. Or it's just waiting for someone specific to find it. You're the first ones who've come looking since the whole palce was looted."

"Guess it's been waiting for us." *Or me*, Catra thinks bitterly. Stupid She-Ra. Stupid mask. Stupid sword.

"Whaddaya want it for, anyway?"

Catra doesn't answer. She's not sure, if she's honest. Does she think a crashed ship can answer her questions better than an alien on another planet in another universe? Maybe Mara left something behind—some justification for why she had trapped Etheria in this place. Some reason to just leave it here.

You keep forgetting the Horde, idiot.

I can deal with Hordak if I need to. No Hordak on Etheria, no reason to attack it, right?

The justification makes enough sense in her head that she lets it go.

She-Ra…

Catra stops, ears perking up. "Catra?" Glimmer questions, head tilted. They must still be too far away for regular ears.

"I can hear it." And just like that, her mind is racing. What if it has records? Or some kind of travel log? What if it really *does* have answers?

"Wait, don't get ahead!"—

Too late—Catra is already bolting through the sand on all fours, completely focused. "Fast kitty," she faintly hears Huntara say behind her.

Adora looks around, taking in the shadowy figures. "Great. Don't suppose you know any of them."

"Prooooooooobably not."

A large, red Reptilian man jumps down in front of them, grinning down at Adora. "Didn't anyone ever tell you not to wander around the Wastes alone, Blondie?" he sneers, looking her up and down. Adora huffs impatiently.

"Can we not with the big damn bad guy thing? I'm not in the mood."

Scorpia winces, half stepping forward to step between them, but the Reptilian had already grabbed Adora by the jacket. "You better learn some respect, girl. Don't you know who I am?"

"No, and I really don't care, honestly. Are you going to let me walk away, or do I have to make this embarrassing for you?"

The man growls, throwing Adora away. She hits the sand with a grunt, rolling into a crouch. "You'll pay for that," he snarls as he walks toward her. "Nobody crosses Tung Lashor."

Adora snorts before she can stop herself. "*Tung Lashor?* Are you serious? Look, I can appreciate an on point name, but *Tung Lashor*?"

He growls, pulling a whip off his belt and cracking it against the ground. Adora jumps, grabbing her stun baton and powering it up. She doesn't expect it to do any significant damage, but it's at least distracting for a moment. She pulls a knife from her sleeve, slicing through the whip. She hears Scorpia calling her name, but she doesn't interfere. Hopefully she's okay.

"You *little*—"

"Do you do anything besides look intimidating? Seriously, I just want to get through."

Tung Lashor slams his fists together, running toward Adora. She pulls her staff and vaults over him, whirling to kick him in the back. He turned back to her, and she jumped again, backing up.

“*You can’t just run at everything and hope you don’t die, dummy.*”

“*Oh yeah? Then what am I supposed to do?*

“*Literally anything else. Look around. Make a plan. Use your* brain *for once.*”

“*Rude*.”

Adora casts her eyes around as she jumps back, dodging another blow; her foot comes down and sinks just slightly. Quicksand. She looks back to Tung Lashor as he charges at her, moving only at the last second, and using her staff to trip him. He goes face first into the quicksand, and she backs up, satisfied.

Silence rings through the area as Adora turns to inspect Tung Lashor’s gang. “So,” she says loud enough for her voice to carry. “Does anyone know anything about First Ones’ tech in the area?”

“I always forget how fast she is,” Bow gasps as they finally catch up to the ship, which Catra had disappeared into nearly two minutes ago.

“Could’ve just let me teleport,” Glimmer shoots back. Even Huntara is winded, though not nearly as bad.

“Sounds like that teleporting’s made you soft,” she comments with a smirk. Glimmer pushes down her annoyance, grabbing Bow and heading for the entrance.

“Catra? Are you okay? Did you find—”

The question dies on her tongue when she sees the empty room they’re standing in. “Oh,” she says quietly, looking around. Catra is staring at the wall, motionless.

"I did mention the place was looted, didn't I?" Huntara asks, ducking in. "Big old thing like this, no security , it was just asking to be picked clean. Do you know how much this kind of stuff goes for in the Crimson Waste?"

Wham!

They all jump as Catra slams her fist into the wall. "*Damn it* !" Another punch. "Every *fucking time*"—

"Oooooooookay ." Bow grabs her wrist before she can land a third blow. "I know you're upset, but beating up the wall isn't going to help."

"You don't know that," Catra grumbles, pulling away . "This just..it.. doesn't make sense." She looks around helplessly . "The outside of this thing is *huge*. This can't be all there is."

"*She-Ra*." The others jump as they hear the voice for the first time.

"It's just like Alwyn," Glimmer half whimpers, curling in on herself. Catra looks at her, frowning. "*Just like Alwyn* …

"Alwyn was a communication hub that was activated when Entrapta messed with the runestones!" Bow reminds them excitedly . "What if the ship is the same?"

"The ship's communication system was activated and it's been broadcasting this entire time?" Catra guesses.

"Yes! Which means there *has* to be more here!"

Catra whips around, eyes scanning the wall. She taps the charm on her belt, summoning the sword, and it transforms into a shield, thrumming. "Do you think it's doing something"—

The room lights up in pink, illuminating a mural of She-Ra; a door creaks open, bats flying out. They all scream, ducking. "Yeah," Catra says after a moment, raising her head. "I think it did something."

"*She-Ra. Etheria. One*."

The voice sounds ethereal. Ghostly. "So we're going in, right?" Bow asks, looking around.

"Absolutely." Glimmer braces herself. "On three. One—"

Catra darts straight through the door. Huntara chuckles as she follows. "I like her way of doing things."

It's a control room. Catra looks around, her eyes picking out various buttons and levers on the panel, and a chair in the middle of the room. "Coooooooooool." Bow's eyes are wide as he steps in, voice awestruck. "This is *all* First One's technology. Can you believe it?"

His voice cracks. He walks to the chair, sitting down and touching something on the arm. A screen flickers to life in front of him. "Whoa." Glimmer jumps up next to the chair.

"This is the message from my tracker pad," Bow reports, leaning in to get a closer look. Catra notices a glimmer of pink in the corner and steps closer. The glitching energy takes shape after a moment, revealing a young woman with in a shirt and skirt, hair flowing behind her.

"Mara," Catra breathes.

"*I am Mara, She-Ra of Etheria, and I am gone,*" the hologram reports in a monotone voice. Catra reaches out slowly, not sure what she's expecting. But her hand goes through it. "*I am Mara, She-Ra of Etheria, and I am gone.*"

"Well that's unsettling," Huntara comments, raising an eyebrow. Catra frowns, looking around.

"There must be a password or something, I dunno. The Crystal Palace was the same way."

"*I am Mara, She-Ra of Etheria, and I am gone.*"

"Yeah, I heard you the first two times," Catra grumbles. "Um, god don't make me transform. I have the sword and I'm She-Ra, isn't that enough?"

"*I am Adora, She-Ra of Etheria, and I am gone.*"

"Administrator detected?"

"*I am Adora, She-Ra of Etheria, and I am gone.*"

"Ugh, what was that thing on the elemental in the library – Eternia."

"*I am Adora, She-Ra of Etheria, and I am gone.*"

"Is it the Magicat thing?" She yanks the mask off. "There, no more Magicat. I mean, except me, but I can't really make myself disappear."

"*I am Adora, She-Ra of Etheria, and I am gone.*"

"Seriously!?" Catra threw her hands up in disbelief. "What do you *want* from me?! I'm jumping through all your hoops and I'm putting all the pieces together and I *don't know what else you want from me*!" She kicks the console in frustration. "I left the *only* person who cared about me, the only *home* I know, just to follow this stupid destiny I apparently have, and all I've gotten over and over is more *questions*! And when I'm not getting questions, I'm just hitting dead ends! Light Hope? Nothing. Half Moon? Ha, the Magicats are all dead! *This stupid ship!?*"

She kicks the console again. "Hey," Bow says gently, resting a hand on Catra's shoulder. "We'll figure it out, don't worry. Let's—"

Something is flickering on the console. Catra looks, surprised, and sees an image of the sword hilt sticking out of a slot. "Hang on," she mutters, drawing the sword again and slipping it into the slot. The pink hologram flickers away, and another appears in the captain's

chair. Mara looks smaller, normal. But hurt. She's holding her side and wincing as she speaks.

"*I don't have much time. I barely made it out.*" Catra steps closer , wide-eyed. The hologram glitches, Mara's voice echoing. "*If you are seeing this, it means you wield the Sword. You are the new She-Ra. It means I failed. I was supposed to be the last. And I am so, so sorry*."

Catra looks back at the sword, eyes wide, then to Mara again. What did she mean? "*I don't know what they told you, but it wasn't all bad at first*." There' s so much pain in her voice. What had happened? "*We were the first ones to settle on Etheria and study the planet's magic. We saved — I thought we saved the Magicats. Did we just make things worse?*"

"Catra" —

She holds up a hand to silence Glimmer, not taking her eyes away from Mara. "*How could it go so wrong?*" She sounds so sad. Catra understands that. The hologram begins to glitch, speaking in broken statements. "*Light Hope use the - Can't — W eapon — the weapon — Weapon.*"

Catra perks up slightly at the mention of Light Hope. "Wait, what about Light Hope? Did she do something? Can she do something?" Not that Mara can answer. "Can we fix this thing?"

"I'm trying," Bow calls back. "But I think it was permanently damaged by the crash."

The hologram came back into focus, Mara struggling to speak. "*I opened a portal to a completely empty dimension and pulled Etheria in. I hid us from the rest of the universe to keep everyone safe. This is the one place they'll never find us. I saw what they would do. The deaths that would follow.*"

What does she mean? Is this about the First Ones' weapon Melog mentioned? *"I couldn't stop them before but I can now. Hiding is our only option. Maybe it's been a week. Maybe it's been thousands of years."* Helpless. Now she sounds helpless. *"I never wanted to be a hero."* Catra can relate to that, she thinks bitterly. She'd give anything to let someone else have this responsibility. *"I won't be remembered as one."* A pause. *"The Magicats took the mask, but the sword can still work on its own. I hope they can stop this if I can't. You have the sword now. It is the administrator key to our planet. With it, you can activate a portal. So I'm begging you. Don't do it. Leave us here. If you open a portal, death and destruction will follow. For the good of the universe, Etheria must stay in Despondos. If not, everyone will—"*

She's cut off by alarms, gasping and looking around. And then the hologram disappears. "What?" Catra steps forward, as if expecting the hologram to reappear and answer her questions. "Everyone will what? What did the First Ones do?"

What did Mara do?

"*The power was too much for her to handle without the aid of the mask. She was compromised. She gave in to fear and faulty reasoning. Her desperate actions led to devastation. Mara stranded us in the empty dimension of Despandos. She broke the She-Ra line. She nearly destroyed us.*"

Light Hope's words echo in Catra's head. *She was compromised*. Overwhelmed by a power not meant to be handled by her alone. But she had mentioned the Magicats and the mask. She knew about them.

Catra collapses onto the step, burying her face in her hands. What if this is all just a madwoman rambling? What if she's wrong?

What if she's right?

"*I hope they can stop this if I can't*."

Did she work with the Magicats? Melog said they ran to stop the First Ones from using a weapon…

"Hey ."

Glimmer rests a hand on Catra's shoulder, sitting on one side, while Bow settled on the other. "Dont stress, okay? Maybe there' s still something to find in Half Moon. We can go back and"—

Catra's ears twitch; she sits up straight, hissing, " *Shush*." Huntara looks up at the same, squinting through the gloom, then scowling.

"T ung lashor ." *What the fuck is a Tung lashor* , Catra wonders distantly. "Dont start with me, Ive had a long few days"—

"T ung lashor 's a bit wrapped up, actually." Catra bolts up at the sound of the voice, whirling to see Adora stepping out of the shadows, surrounded by various hybrids. "But his gang was kind enough to help us find our way here."

Catra laughs despite herself. It's not a humorous sound. She's too tired and too exasperated for any kind of humor . "Y ou went out and got a bunch of desert bandits to help you? Not bad, Adora. I didnt think you had it in you."

"W ell we had to do *something* after you ditched us in that kingdom," Adora shoots back.

"Hey , I was unconscious for that!" Catra protests. It' s not like she ever has any choice in her life.

"So you *wouldn't* have left us there?"

"I mean, you *have* tried to kill us a buncha times, so." Catra shrugs. "Besides, you got out. Get over it. Im still pissed of f about you stabbing me."

"That was *months* ago!" Adora throws her hands up. As if not forgiving stabbing and kidnapping is somehow unreasonable.

"Yeah, well I'm in a pretty bad mood right now, so I'm feeling a bit petty." Catra steps back, remembering the sword in the console. Adora draws a stun baton, and Catra ducks, nearly missing being hit by a blast of electricity. "You know, I'm really starting to hate that thing," she growls as she straightens up again. The sword is too far for her to get. But it's Adora. Does she really need it?

Well, it's Adora and Scorpia, she notes, seeing Adora's new shadow. Adora and Scorpia. And a bunch of Wasteland thugs who look eager for a fight. Glimmer must be running low on magic by now. She can see Bow's quiver is just a little sparse. Huntara looks ready to fight, and she's big, but they're surrounded.

"*Hordak wants to open a portal.*"

"*Mara stranded us in the empty dimension of Despandos.*"

"*If you open a portal, death and destruction will follow.*"

"*She was compromised.*"

"*The Magicats took the mask, but the sword can still work on its own. I hope they can stop this if I can't.*"

"*He intends to bring through the rest of the Horde's armies using this portal, and using them to conquer Etheria once and for all.*"

"*She gave in to fear and faulty reasoning. Her desperate actions led to devastation.*"

"*Etheria must stay in Despandos.*"

"Stop!"

Catra's voice echoes through the control room. She's not sure if she's yelling at herself, the others, or at the voices in her head. Maybe it doesn't matter. She meets Adora's gaze. "I'll go with you."

Adora blinks a few times, clearly stunned. She's not the only one. "*What*?" Glimmer demands, whirling to glare at Catra. She ignores the princess, turning and walking to the console. She pulls the sword out, transforming back to the little cat charm.

"What's the catch?" Adora asks slowly. Catra turns to her again.

"The catch is that we do this on my terms. You let Glimmer, Bow, and Huntara go. Ditch your little gang. I'm not going back as your prisoner. I want to talk to Hordak. I want to find out more about this portal of his, and if he can really get us out of Despandos."

"But Mara said"—

"Mara could be a loon driven completely up the wall by powers she couldn't control." Catra sounds a lot calmer than she feels. "I want answers. And it sounds like Hordak is the guy to get them from."

"But"—

"Go back to Bright Moon, Glimmer. I'll send you a message when I can." She narrows her eyes at Adora. "Not a prisoner. Right?"

"Not a prisoner," Adora agrees slowly. "I can't promise Hordak will listen, though. He's not exactly a chatty person."

"He wants First Ones' tech, doesn't he?" Catra holds up the charm. "I literally have the most powerful artifact in the palm of my hand. He'll listen."

"What about what Shadow Weaver said?" Glimmer demands. Something flashes in Adora's eyes.

"*You've* talked to Shadow Weaver?"

"She dropped into Bright Moon to sell out the Horde. And I'm not basing all my choices on what she says."

Glimmer and Bow exchange helpless glances. "Please," Glimmer begs. "Don't do this. You can't go back there."

"I'm not going back." Catra's voice is flat. "I'm trying to fix all the mistakes that got us here."

"That's not your responsibility!"

"Yes, it is!" Catra whirls to glare at Glimmer, although it's clear her heart isn't in it. "I'm... I'm She-Ra. This is why I exist. This has *always* been the reason I exist. I take blows for everyone else, and I take responsibility for everyone's mistakes, or it's pushed on me. Either way, this is what I have to do."

She turns back to Adora, walking to her old friend without any hesitation. "Ready when you are."

Adora looks back at Scorpia, then at her desert gang, then at Catra, and nods.

"Let's go."

Chapter End Notes

I know begging for reviews isn't really a good luck but... they really do keep me going, especially on this particular story. It's just really good to know people are interested and that this worth working on, you know?

Deal With The Devil

Chapter Summary

No preview, too many important things

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Hordak is a lot of things. Patient and forgiving is not one of them.

In all his time on this backwater planet, only one person has ever managed to invoke that side of Hordak, and she's currently sitting several feet away, going on excitedly about a new idea for the portal if Adora doesnt come through with First Ones' tech.

Adora. Hordak almost laughs at the thought. She's probably been picked clean by vultures already—

"Oh, hey Adora!"

Hordak whirls, stunned, to see the force captain walking into the lab like she owns the place. He grits his teeth, resisting the urge to storm over and backhand her. "I sent you to retrieve First Ones' tech," he hisses instead as soon as she close enough. The smile she gives in return is smug.

"And I did."

She's not alone, Hordak realizes then. The Magicat ~~-~~She-Ra ~~-is~~ standing a few feet behind her, arms folded, expression neutral. How had Shadow Weaver missed that kind of potential in her? The black garnet truly had been wasted.

"Catra?" Entrapta tilts her head curiously. "Are you going to let me experiment on the sword!?"

"*No*, I'm not letting you experiment on the sword!" Catra rolls her eyes, shaking her head.

"She wants to talk to you," Adora tells Hordak. Her voice is calm, measured. Hordak narrows his eyes.

"Oh, really?"

"Yeah, I'm sure you're not used to social calls," Catra says, stepping forward. "But I've got a deal for you."

Hordak takes stock of his situation. Entrapta may be brilliant, but she's no fighter. Adora will not fight for him if it comes down to it. And he doesn't know enough about Catra or She-Ra to confidently say he could take her – even if he'll never admit that out-loud. Not to mention all the delicate machinery that could be destroyed in the process.

"I'll entertain you for a moment, I suppose," he finally allows. Catra folds her arms, gaze unwavering. Oh, he can see why this one annoyed Shadow Weaver.

"I want to know about the portal. And the other universe – the one we're *supposed* to be in."

"You think you can come in here and demand"—

"Yeah, I do," Catra cuts off the growing fury. "I've got the best First Ones' tech that exists on all of Etheria. Unless you think you can do better than the sword."

She's not wrong, and that infuriates Hordak. The possibilities with the sword would be endless. "The mechanisms of the portal are far too advanced for you"—

"What would happen if you opened a portal right now?" Catra cuts in again. "If it worked, and nothing went cosmically wrong, would you just... bring Etheria back into the universe?"

"Of course not." Hordak scoffs. "I'm not opening the portal to bring Etheria back into the wider universe."

"Oh, right. You want to bring the Horde's forces through to take over the planet." How does she—"Shadow Weaver sold you out. If you'd bothered to ask, I would've told you not to trust her as far as you can throw her."

"Do not mouth off to me, *child*"—

"But that's not the point." She's annoyingly bold, Hordak thinks. "*Could* you bring Etheria back into the larger universe?"

The question makes Hordak pause. "It's not impossible. But I hardly see the point."

"No, you wouldn't see it," Catra grumbles. "You're not the one who has thousands of years of fuck ups on your shoulders. You *can* do it, though. That's what I'm gathering here."

It is a *possibility.*" Hordak stresses the word. Catra narrows her eyes at him.

"*If* I give you the sword, how strong does that possibility become?"

Hordak stares at her for a long moment. "Are you trying to *bargain* with me?"

"No, I *am* bargaining with you." Such an ego. "The sword is the key to the planet. You're not going anywhere without it."

"And why shouldn't I just kill you now and take the sword?"

Adora stiffens, her hand going for the stun baton on her belt. Catra calmly holds up a small charm. "Because the sword won't work without me. I mean, I guess you could try, but you'd look kind of stupid using a little cat charm to work your portal. And you don't seem like the kind of person who takes failure well."

Hordak grits his teeth. Adora's eyes flick to the lever that activates his insane air-stealing machine across the room, thankfully. "What are your terms?" the Horde lord finally asks.

"Get Etheria back where it belongs. Get off the planet. And go away. I don't know why you want to go back, and I don't care. Just leave."

"And if I don't?"

"Then you better hope that whatever *greater evil* is waiting on the other side gets to the planet before I run you through."

Entrapta is eerily still, looking between Hordak and Catra. Adora is still poised to attack if Hordak tries anything. He's sizing Catra up, frowning. "I suppose we can find a way to work together," he finally says, holding his hand out. Catra takes a step back.

"One more thing. Entrapta is the *only* person who touches the sword." Entrapta lights up. "*Not* to experiment on it." She sighs in disappointment. "Use it for whatever portal-related things you need, and then it goes straight back to me. *Got it*?"

"Got it!" Entrapta says happily, bouncing over. Catra clenches the charm for a moment, letting out a breath before changing it back.

"Entrapta?"

The princess tilts her head. "Yeah?"

"Thank you. For helping the others rescue me after *someone* stabbed and kidnapped me." Adora rolls her eyes. "I'm sorry you were left behind."

To say Entrapta is surprised is an understatement. "I-It's okay," she says uncertainly, hair flexing toward the sword. Catra hands it over, turning to Adora.

"Can I borrow a tracker pad?"

"Completely irresponsible, going out to the middle of nowhere and"—

"Mom, I know!" Glimmer throws her hands up. "I know , I know *all of this*, but we don't have time right now! We need to save Catra!"

"And how do you propose doing that?"

"Um..well"…

Perfuma, Frosta, and Mermista look at each other, then at Bow. They've been cast out of the war room for the mother and daughter to argue, as if that will stop them from listening. "You want to propose yet another mission into the Fright Zone with no plan." Angella's voice is flat. "To rescue someone who handed herself over to the Horde willingly."

"It wasn't like that," Glimmer protests. "She was trying to help us. She's..She's hurting. A lot."

Angella sighs, closing her eyes for a long moment. "I understand that we've asked a lot of her , and that she's been conflicted. But she's made her choice."

Bow can hear the pain in Angella's voice. He knows she cares about Catra. Not being able to help her must be killing the queen. Glimmer , apparently, is less aware. "What about Shadow Weaver? She knows the Horde. Maybe she"—

"Shadow Weaver can not be trusted. And I will *certainly* not trust her with Catra's safety."

"But *you're* not doing anything for her, either!" Glimmer yells. "She *needs* us! If we just turn our backs on her"—

"No." The queen's voice is cold now. "We are not putting more people in danger. We need to think of the Rebellion as a whole, not just one person."

"You dont care about the Rebellion!" Bow winces. He already knows that's too far. "All you do is stay in the castle and make excuses to not fight! The Rebellion was frozen for years until *I* started doing something. And if you wont help"—

They hear Angella's chair scrape against the floor as she stands. "I said *no*." The authority in her voice is undeniable. "I am your queen, and your leader, *Commander* Glimmer. You will *not* be leading another rescue mission into the Fright Zone unless you can come up with a reasonable plan. That is my final word on the matter. Do you understand?"

A long moment of silence follows before Glimmer says, "Yes," in a small voice. Bow gestures to the princesses, and they hurry down the hall, letting themselves into Glimmer's room just as she teleports in.

"Hey, itll be okay," Bow says, reaching to hug her—then stops when his tracker pad goes off. "Huh, incoming call." He accepts the call. Catra's face appears on the screen. "Catra!"

"What!?" Four princesses are immediately on top of him, trying to look at the screen as well.

"*Hey, guys, it's been like three hours. Are you* that *bored without me? Liberate a village or something*."

Glimmer grabs the tracker pad and teleports up to her bed. "Are you okay? Is Adora holding you hostage? Is she *there*? Blink twice if you're doing this against your will."

Catra sighs; Glimmer hears a snort and a muttered, "*Princesses*," somewhere off screen.

"*I chose to go with her, Glimmer*." Real name. That's serious.

"I know, but you...you wouldnt." Glimmer deflates, tears in her eyes. "What're you doing, Catra?"

Catra's shoulders slump, gaze dropping to the floor. "*I have to fix this. Even if it means helping the Horde. Hordak is the only person with the technology that can possibly make a difference.*"

"Did you give them the sword?" No answer. "Catra!"

"*Look, you don't get it!*" Catra snaps. "Your *ancestors and… past self, or whatever, didn't epically fuck up the entire planet! I've got this under control, okay? I just… I need you to trust me right now, and* not *do anything stupid.*"

"*You* need *us* to trust you? How can we do that when you dont even trust us?"

"*Shut up, you know I trust you!*"

"You *left us* for the Horde!"

"*I didn't!*" Catra stops, running a hand through her hair and taking a deep breath. "*I'm coming back after all of this. There's still going to be a war to fight, and I know which side I'm on. I'm not staying here. But right now I* need *Hordak's help.*"

"And what about what Shadow Weaver said? About the Horde armies that could invade the planet?"

"*It's not like they're going to be waiting to ambush us. We have time to prepare.*"

"Prepare to fight a huge army?" Bow cant help but notice how much Glimmer sounds like her mother in that moment. "How?"

"*I don't know! I don't know, okay? But we're not going to get anything done if we just keep sitting in this empty universe and fighting. Something has to move.*" She sounds tired. She looks tired. "*Please, Glimmer. Let me deal with this. I'll be back before you know it. Okay?*"

Glimmer looks helplessly at Bow, then back at Catra. "Okay ," she says quietly . "Stay safe. Punch Adora for me."

"*Oh, of course.*"

She ends the call. Glimmer looks at the blank screen for a moment, then frowns, and teleports away.

Catra sighs, dropping back on the bed and staring at the ceiling. "Nice digs. Beats the hell out of the bunks."

Adora, who's leaning against the wall with her arms crossed, shrugs. "Y eah. It's a room. How are you not constantly exhausted from dealing with that princess?"

"Glimmer? She grows on you after awhile." Catra chuckles. "Y ou should hear her argue with Angella, it's kind of hilarious sometimes."

"Y ou're on a first-name basis with the queen?"

"Oh." Catra winces, closing her eyes. "Y eah. Kind of."

They sit in silence for a long moment. It's not the same, comfortable silence they used to bask in — the silence that comes from knowing someone well enough to not need words. But it's close. "What was that underground place we found you in?" Adora asks after a moment. Catra opens her eyes again, gaze hazy now.

"Half Moon. It' s where I. I mean, it' s the Magicats' kingdom. Or was."

"What" —

"Shadow W eaver." Catra' s claws dig into the blanket. "It' s always fucking Shadow Weaver, isn't it?"

Adora takes a moment to process that. "I hit her for you," she says finally. Catra laughs.

"I *saw* that. What happened?"

"I finally figured out that she didn't really care about you. Or me." Adora narrows her eyes. "She never cared about us at all, did she?"

"Of course not. She's a self-serving bitch." Catra snorts. "I can't believe you fell for her shit for so long."

"Ugh, fine, you can hold that against me."

"Oh, I can hold *that* against you but not you *stabbing me*?"

"*Wooooooooow*, fine." Adora rolls her eyes, diving forward to tackle Catra. "You can hold *stabbing you* against me too, happy?"

Catra laughs, wiggling and trying to shove Adora off. "Yes, thank you *so much* for your permission to be angry that you did bodily harm to me."

They laugh, wrestling playfully for a few moments before Adora gets Catra in a headlock. "Get *off* me you crazy person!"

"Say the magic words," Adora sings. Catra bites her hand. "Ow!"

The distraction is enough for Catra to break free and roll out of arm's length, laughing. They both giggle madly, and for a moment, it's like nothing has changed.

But the laughter dies away eventually, and they find themselves staring at the ceiling. "You said there was nothing for you in the Fright Zone," Adora finally says quietly. Catra lets out a long sigh.

"I didn't mean that didn't include you. If you would've just *listened* to me about Shadow Weaver—"

"You still wouldn't come back even after she was gone!" Adora protests, sitting up. "You just told… *Glimmer*, or whatever, that you'll go back to Bright Moon after all of this."

"Well, yeah, there's still a war to fight." Catra sits up as well, blinking at Adora. "Etheria still needs a protector and that's me."

"No, it's *She-Ra*." It's hard to miss the resentment in Adora's voice.

"Yeah, and *I'm* She-Ra, so"…

"So what, a princess and a weird AI tell you that you have some weird destiny and you just go along with it?" It sounds crazy when she puts it that way. "I mean, come on, Catra. You've never listened to anyone in your life. Why start now?"

Catra chuckles, tucking her arms under her head and closing her eyes. "You're such an idiot." The words are spoken with too much fondness to be cruel. "It's not just following orders. Sometimes I actually feel like I'm, I dunno, making a difference. Making the world *better*. That's more than I ever would've accomplished here. And you can't tell me you're *really* happy with all of this."

She waves a hand around the room. Adora looks around, then drops her gaze to the ground. "I, I don't know. But wasn't *this* always the plan? We were gonna rise up and run this place together."

"I know, but Adora." Catra sits up, eying her best friend seriously. "You *know* the Horde is the bad guy in all this."

"I didn't know that mattered to you," Adora says quietly.

"I thought it mattered to *you*."

"I thought so too, I guess." She shrugs. "But you left, and it felt like nothing really mattered anymore."

Catra hates to admit that she understands what Adora means, but… as much as she loves Glimmer and Bow, they don't fill the Adora-shaped hole in her life. "You don't… *have* to stay here, you know," Catra points out slowly. Adora looks up at her.

"What do I do, *join the Rebellion*?

"Or just leave, I dunno," Catra says. "Maybe you could be like, a mercenary or something. But the Horde isn't your only option. And if you did want to join the Rebellion, I bet they'd take you. Angella apparently loves mothering broken people. Just turn on the big old puppy eyes, and Bow will want to keep you within an hour."

Adora stares at Catra for a long moment. "That's insane. You know that, right? You get She-Ra to hide behind, I'm just"—

"Someone I would vouch for on my life."

"Wow, do you like me?" Adora teases, grinning wickedly. "How embarrassing for you."

"Oh shut *up*." Catra reaches over to shove Adora. "I can't believe I just tried to be sincere with you. What a joke."

"Bright Moon's making you soft."

"It *is*." Catra groans. "They really like talking about *feelings* around there. It's like this whole *thing*. Talk about how you're feeling Catra, don't just punch the wall, *tell us* things, we're your *friends*"—

"That sounds like the most annoying thing ever," Adora says without a hint of sarcasm. Of course she understands. Catra smiles despite herself. "And you want me to go *live there*? Maybe try and sell me on something other than *we talk about feelings*."

"Fine." Catra stretches, humming. "Let's see... they have real food. Not just ration bars, like, actual food."

Adora raises an eyebrow. "What's *actual* food?"

"You know, like... real food. Fruits and chocolates and meat. I've had fish." Catra grins. "It's sooooooooooooo good. Don't tell Sparkles I said that, though. Also, her name is Sparkles, not Glitter. She can't have two nicknames."

"Do you ever call her by her *actual* name?"

Catra shrugs. "Sometimes. Not really . I think she's gotten used to it by now. Oh, the beds are pretty cool. Like, not a stone slab."

"Hey , I like my stone slab," Adora argues half-heartedly .

"They're actually kind of unreasonably soft, honestly . I sleep in the window nook a lot."

"Wow, a *window nook*. Fancy."

"Shut *up*." Catra rolls her eyes. "Why do I want you to come with me again?"

"Because you liiiiiiiiiiike me." Adora sits up, reaching over to scratch Catra's ears. Catra ducks away, swatting at her arm. "It's okay, I won't tell anyone."

"First of all, I *don't* like you. Second, bullshit you won't tell anyone. You can't keep a secret to save your damn life."

"Suuuuuuuuure, Catra. Sure."

"Ah, Princess. I had a feeling I would be seeing you sooner or later ."

Glimmer's lips twitch into a scowl, her eyes narrowing. She feels sick being here, in front of Catra's abuser, about to ask her for help. But this is partially *her* fault. She can help clean it up.

"Catra's gone."

"Of course she is." Shadow Weaver sneers. She's perfectly comfortable in her prison, with a chair to lounge in and a book. Why does she get to be comfortable? She's weak. She went with Adora, didn't she?

Glimmer's jaw clenches. "We found Half Moon."

"Oh, did you? Were there any survivors?"

"*No*. You're a monster."

"And yet, here you are." Shadow Weaver is not at all bothered, of course. She has leverage. She knows it. Glimmer is here for a reason. "You must need something only I can provide. I can offer plenty of insight into Adora and Catra and how to exploit their weakness for each other"—

"We need to get into the Fright Zone and stop Catra from making a huge mistake," Glimmer snaps. "She's giving them the sword. They have everything they need to make a portal work now." That brings Shadow Weaver up short. "She's scared, and she's hurt, and she thinks she's fixing the mistakes everyone else made. She won't listen"—

"Catra's never been known for her ability to *listen*." The alarm is clear in Shadow Weaver's voice despite the jab. "If Hordak has what he needs to open his portal, he will do so immediately. The Alliance will never make it in time. But perhaps"…

Glimmer narrows her eyes, taking a step closer. "*Perhaps*?"

"Let me out, and I can help you teleport right into the heart of the Fright Zone."

That gets a laugh from Glimmer. She thought this woman was *smart*. "I couldn't even get to the edge of the Fright Zone without running out of power. I'm nowhere near strong enough."

"But I can make you stronger." Glimmer's eyes widen. "I'm still the only sorceress who has ever been able to tap into a Runestone. If you allow me to access your connection to the Moonstone, I can enhance your powers. You could teleport us all the way there."

All the way there. Without running out of power or collapsing or being useless. "You can really make me that powerful?" she asks in a small voice.

"You think of yourself only as a princess. But you're the child of a great sorcerer. You have a more powerful connection to magic than you've ever realized." She holds out a hand. "Let me show you."

Glimmer folds her arms, trying to defend herself against… something. Shadow Weaver? Her own desires? "I'll get back to you."

She disappears before Shadow Weaver can protest.

"Shadow Weaver? Are you kidding?"

Bow isn't impressed. Glimmer hadn't expected him to be happy with this development. "I know, I *know*, but she knows the Fright Zone, and she can help—"

"She's just using you to escape!"

"But if it's still *my* power, do you think she can really use it?" Glimmer knows she's grasping at straws. She's desperate. They *need* to stop this.

"I don't *know*. That's the problem. No one knows." But Bow knows that look in Glimmer's eyes. "You're going to go with her anyway, aren't you?"

"Someone needs to stop this. Someone needs to save Catra from herself."

Bow sighs. "Okay. But you're not going alone. I still don't trust her."

"Neither do I," Glimmer admits. "But if she helps us, then at least she's making herself useful and not just lounging around in her cell. Mom gave her a *chair*."

"Hospitality is a big deal."

"She's—ugh, never mind. Let's go."

Bow takes her hand, squeezing it tightly, and they teleport back to Shadow Weaver to finish their deal with the devil.

"I think you'd really like cake."

Adora raises an eyebrow, looking down at Catra. They're still fantasizing about living in Bright Moon together. *Fantasizing* because it seems too ridiculous to be reality. "Oh yeah?"

"Yeah. It's like...like the grey bars, but waaaaaaay sweeter. And I know grey's your favorite."

"You keep talking about food, and now I'm getting hungry."

Catra laughs. "Of course you are. When *aren't* you hungry? I heard your stomach growling when you were *sleeping* sometimes."

"Shut up." Adora throws her pillow at Catra, smiling. "C'mon, let's get something to eat. Do you think you can stand to go back to ration bars after all that great *real* food?"

"No, but it's not like I have a choice."

The alarm blares overhead as Catra stands. She looks up, then looks at Adora. "I knew she wouldn't listen."

Adora shoots her a sharp look. "You don't seriously think—how would they even get here?"

"Glimmer's stubborn as fuck. Come on."

They hurry out of the room and down the halls, turning a few corners before running into—

"*Shadow Weaver*?"

Well, Shadow Weaver, Glimmer, and Bow, but the sorceress is who Catra fixes on first. Adora takes a step forward to put herself in front

of Catra, arm out as if to guard her. "Oh, Adora." Shadow Weaver sighs, sounding ridiculously like a put-out mother. "What have I told you about getting mixed up in Catra's nonsense?"

"At least I'm not literally holding hands with a princess."

"Catra." Glimmer steps forward, releasing Shadow Weaver's hand. "*Please*, we have to talk about this."

Catra eyes her warily, taking a step back. "Why are you with Shadow Weaver?"

Glimmer's eyes widen as she realizes her big mistake, far too late — aligning herself, however reluctantly, with the woman who had tortured Catra for her entire life. "We needed her help getting here" —

"I told you not to come! I have this under control."

"No, you don't!" Glimmer throws her hands up, exasperated. "You're helping Hordak do something that could destroy Etheria because you think *you* have to make up for what people did hundreds of years ago!"

"I know what I'm doing."

"You're going to get us killed, you stupid *child*," Shadow Weaver hisses, glaring at Catra with obvious hatred behind the mask. Catra clenches her fists, hissing.

"Ignore her," Bow says, stepping up to stand with Glimmer. "We know you think you're doing the right thing, Catra, and maybe you are, we don't know. But that's kind of the problem. We don't know enough about the other universe or how the portal works or what we're getting ourselves into. What if you do something you regret?"

Catra is still looking between them, distrust obvious in her gaze. But something else is starting to stir in her as well. "What do you two know?" Adora snaps, stepping up to defend Catra.

"What do *you* know?" Glimmer shoots back. "It's not like *you've* ever had Catra's best interests at heart."

Adora winces back slightly. Glimmer's not *wrong*, but it still hurts. "Oh, and you have? The only reason she's with you is because of She-Ra. You wouldn't have cared about her otherwise."

"You're *all* missing the point," Shadow Weaver cuts in loudly. No one notices the way Catra flinches back. "This isn't about *Catra*, it's about stopping Hordak and the portal. And if *you two*—she focuses on Adora and Catra, "won't help, then you can stand aside and let someone else fix *your* mistakes for you."

Catra takes a step back. And then another. Her heartbeat is in her ears, mind racing.

The Magicats betrayed the First Ones.

The First Ones were making a weapon that would destroy Etheria.

Light trapped Etheria in an empty universe in a fit of madness.

Light was actually saving Etheria from a worse evil.

Opening the portal would put Etheria back where it belongs.

Opening the portal would put Etheria in danger.

Hordak was always going to do this, though, with or without the sword. What if this way is safer?

What if it's a mistake?

"Catra?"

Adora's voice barely makes it passed the rushing noise in her ears. She's backed up slowly, away from everyone;after a moment she turns and runs. Everyone tries to chase her, but she's faster, and she knows the vents. They don't stand a chance.

It’s not quite as easy as it was when she was little, but Catra still knows the vents better than anyone. She finds Hordak’s lab, and sees Entrapta working at a computer.

“Entrapta!”

The princess jumps as Catra bursts out of the vents. “Oh, hi Catra! Do you like using the vent system to move around as well? I hid there for a couple days before Adora found me, it’s really fascinating”—

Catra grabs her by the shoulders, not even listening to what she’s saying. “Tell me about the portal,” she demands. The princess tilts her head.

“What do you want to know?”

“Is it dangerous? What do you know about what’s waiting on the other side?”

“Science always has a few dangers.” She’s far too blase about this. “Hordak’s told me a bit about the other universe and where he came from, it’s all quite interesting”—

“Am I making a mistake?”

The question catches Entrapta off guard. She stares at Catra, eyes meeting for a long moment before she turns back to the screen. “I don’t think it’s a mistake. But it’s science. One-hundred percent certainty is impossible.”

Catra’s fingers tighten around Entrapta’s arms. “What could happen if things go wrong?”

Entrapta’s eyes dodge around the lab, frowning. “I would have to run a few tests to pick out possible anomalies.”

“Can you do that? Now?”

Her eyes focus on Catra, and she nods slowly. "I can look into it and "—

"Entrapta!"

Hordak's voice echoes through the lab. Catra straightens up to meet the man's gaze. He glares back at her. "What are you doing here?"

"I had some questions about the portal," she replies as calmly as she can manage. "I assume I'm allowed to ask, seeing as how I *gave* you the sword."

Hordak's eyes narrow. But he notices that Entrapta seems relaxed enough. So he nods, letting it go. "What *questions* can I help you with?"

"You have an army waiting for you on the other side of the portal, right?"

"The plan is to get them a signal so they can open their own portal and invade Etheria."

"Yeah, see, that's where I'm having problems." Catra steps forward. "I told you to get off Etheria and leave us alone if we pull this off. Why should I trust that you'll keep up your end of the bargain?"

"That seems like something you should have thought of *before* you gave me the sword."

He's right. Catra knows he's right. She steels herself, putting on the same face she had for years when dealing with Shadow Weaver. "I can still take it back. I gave it to Entrapta, not to you."

"And you believe she'll take your side?"

Not really. Catra can hear Entrapta shuffling uncertainly behind her, caught off guard by suddenly being in the middle of this. "If you opened the portal right now, could you guarantee it would work?

Putting aside the fact that I don't need the sword to kill you if you go back on our deal."

Hordak sneers, clearly unimpressed. That's the problem with the Horde. It's always underestimated what Catra is capable of when pushed to the edge. "The portal has everything it needs to work correctly. Entrapta, do you believe there could be any problems with activating it now?"

"There's always a chance of a few anomalies," Entrapta says quietly. "I would have to run more tests to be sure. But everything up to the point has gone according to plan."

"The princesses are here to stop you." Catra's gaze is hard and cold as she looks Hordak right in the eye. "They think I was wrong to give you the sword."

"And what do *you* believe?"

She isn't sure anymore. That's the problem. "I believe putting Etheria back where it belongs is the right choice. But I'm still its protector. And if you do anything to endanger the planet, I *will* kill you."

Hordak is clearly unruffled by the threat. Good. Maybe it'll make him easier to fight, if it comes down to it. "Then perhaps you should make peace with your choices now instead of letting others try to tell you what's *right*."

A familiar tinkle of bells echoes in the air; Catra snaps around to see Glimmer and Shadow Weaver appear in the middle of the lab, just a few feet away.

"We left Bow—"

"*Focus!*" Shadow Weaver snarls, squeezing her hand. A sickly aura forms around them as she channels Glimmer's power. Is *this* the deal she made to get Shadow Weaver's help?

"You manipulative *bitch*"—

Catra is scowling as she storms forward, claws bared, but Shadow Weaver blasts her back into the far wall. "Catra!" Glimmer yanks her hand from Shadow Weaver's, cutting her off. The lab door opens, Adora bursting through, swinging her staff to knock an arrow out of the air. Bow is right behind her.

"*Enough*!"

Hordak's furious voice cuts through the haze in Catra's head;she looks up blearily to see Hordak ripping a pillar out of the ground (*that seems a bit dramatic*), and swings it as Shadow Weaver and Glimmer. The sorceress grabs Glimmer's hand to throw the pillar off its path. Catra straightens up as the lab shakes, machinery raining down from the walls and ceilings. She sees Adora duck under a piece of falling debris, barely missing being crushed, but putting them both near the portal lever, alone, with everyone else cut off on the other side. Their gazes meet. They don't need words.

Is this what you want?

She wants to fix this. If that means working with Hordak...well, Glimmer aligned herself with Shadow Weaver. What's the difference at this point?

Catra nods. They move, grabbing the lever.

And together, they pull it.

Chapter End Notes

So. Portal next chapter . Who's excited?

(No really, please tell me if you're excited, I really love getting people's reactions to things)

In A Perfect World

Chapter Summary

Everything is perfect?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra's eyes shoot open.

The ceiling above her is unfamiliar. No, it's familiar. It's her room, how could she not recognize it?

She sits up, head snapping around. Artificial light slips in through the curtains of a window, casting shadows around the room. She can make out the outline of a dresser, a wardrobe, an open door that leads to the connected bathroom…

What is wrong with her? She presses a hand to her forehead, taking a few deep breaths. She can't remember what she was dreaming about, but that must have something to do with her disorientation. Right?

A knock echoes at the door. She jumps, looking to it. "Um, come in?"

The door creaks open; a young woman with dark brown fur and bright green eyes pokes her head in. "Good morning, Princess. Vice-Captain Adora is here to see you."

Someone groans behind the woman. "You *know* you don't have to call me that"…

Catra smiles. That's a voice she'd know anywhere. "Hey, Adora."

The other magicat smiles and steps aside, letting Adora into the room. "Sleeping in again?" she teases as she crosses the room to open the curtains, letting light in, then joining Catra on the bed. She tilts her head, frowning slightly. "Are you okay?"

"Yeah. Yeah, I... I had a weird dream."

"What was it?"

"I don't remember. That's the problem." Catra shakes her head. "It's nothing, I'm sure. You know how dreams are."

"I mean, I always hope you're dreaming about me"...

Catra snorts, shoving Adora away. "You are *such* a dork."

Adora laughs, grabbing Catra and pulling her in for a kiss. Catra relaxes against her, smiling, finally feeling better. The world is clicking back into place. She's with Adora. Everything is fine.

"Please tell me you didn't wake up at the crack of dawn and spend all day walking here."

"Of course not." Adora sounds offended, as if that isn't something she's done before. "Glimmer dropped me off."

"I'm sure she'll be thrilled when she doesn't have to do that anymore."

"I think she's still mad that you're stealing me."

"Boohoo." Catra leans in to steal another kiss. "Maybe she should marry you if she wants to keep you around."

"I definitely do *not* want to marry Glimmer." Adora laughs.

"Wait, are you *choosing* to marry me?" Catra gasps. "That's so embarrassing, Adora. Do you *like* me?

Adora shoves her away. "No. I just don't want to take over when Juliet retires."

"Like she's ever going to retire," Catra scoffs. "What would Queen Angella and King Micah do without her?"

"I'm *sure* they'd survive."

"Maybe." Catra climbs out of bed, going to get dressed. "Come on, let's get breakfast."

She dresses in her deep maroon robes, trimmed with a darker red, and settles her mask on her head before reaching for Adora's hand. Adora smiles, taking her hand. "Do I have to wear fancy robes when I marry you?"

"Not until I take over as queen, don't worry. You can keep your stupid jacket."

"It's not stupid," Adora insists, pulling at her jacket—a light purple zipper-up with white sleeves. Bright Moon colors.

"Uh huh. Would it kill you to at least change to a different color?"

"Why? You jealous that I'm still repping Bright Moon?" Adora teases. Catra shoves her away.

"I change my mind. Go away forever."

She doesn't, of course. They enter the dining room hand in hand, and Catra smiles when she sees her mothers are still there, wrapped up in a rather enthusiastic conversation, if their hand gestures were anything to go by. Lyra lights up when she sees the two—mostly her future daughter-in-law.

"Adora, good! We were just talking about clothing. You still need to be measured."

Adora's smile looks absolutely pained. Catra bites down a laugh as she swoops in to kiss Lyra, then Cyra. "Sometimes I think Mama is happier to see Adora than she is me."

"You know that isn't true," Cyra scolds her with a playful smile, squeezing her arm. The truth is that there's not a lot of time until the wedding—just a couple of months, which feels long enough in Catra's opinion, but her mothers insist it'll fly by. And Adora doesn't spend nearly enough time in Half Moon (again, in Catra's opinion), so they have to ambush her for wedding talk when they can.

They get through the meal without too much difficulty, and Catra drags her out to the garden for a walk after. "I love the gardens," Adora says with a content sigh as they make their way down the path. She brushes her fingers against the flowers, smiling. "Are you ever going to tell me what your ridiculous bouquets mean?"

"I go through all the trouble of creating beautiful bouquets for you. You can do some legwork and figure out the meanings for yourself," Catra teases.

"I tried asking Lyra. She won't answer."

"That's not what doing the legwork yourself means!" Catra laughs, pushing Adora and rolling her eyes. "Just find a book about flowers, I'm sure there's one in Bright Moon's library."

"Why can't you just tell me?" Adora whines, leaning on Catra.

"Because it shouldn't be that hard for you to figure it out just using common sense." Catra knocks her knuckles against Adora's forehead. Adora grabs her hand and tugs her close, kissing her.

"But I want to know exactly how *much* you love me," she whispers against Catra's lips.

"I am *not* feeding your ego," Catra says, smiling, before pressing closer to kiss her again.

They resume their walk eventually, Catra beginning to grab flowers and handing them to Adora. "Let's see if you can figure it out on your own. This is a white Camellia."

"Okay?" She twirls the flower uncertainly.

"It's meaning is part of your name."

Adora frowns, tilting her head. "Adora," she says slowly.

"Riiiiiiiiiiiight."

"I don't get it."

"For the love of—you're lucky I love you," Catra scoffs. "*Adorable*. It means adorable you absolute *dork*."

"Oh." Adora's eyes light up as the words set in. "Oh! Aaawww, you think I'm adorable?"

"No, I think you're a dummy." She grabs another one, smiling despite herself. "Red Chrysanthemum. This one is about as easy as it gets."

"You just like making fun of me, don't you?" Adora grumbles, but she's smiling. "Um. I. I dunno, you *did* just call me a dummy, so…"

"It doesn't mean *that*." Catra sighs heavily. "It means I love you."

"Aaaawwww."

"Are you going to *aaawww* at everything? That one shouldn't even be a surprise!"

"I know, I know. It's just so sweet how you can say so much with flowers." Catra smiles, grabbing a white Hibiscus and tucking it into Adora's hair. "What does that one mean?"

"Not gonna tell you."

Adora huffs. "Why *not*?"

"Because you'll probably hate it." It means *delicate beauty*. Adora would absolutely take offense to being called *delicate*. But it makes Catra happy.

"You don't know that if you don't tell me," Adora pushes. Catra grabs another flower. "Is that a rose? Those mean love, right?"

"Red ones do. Pink ones mean happiness." Another flower goes to the small bouquet. "Violet."

"Ummmmm. I don't know." Adora sighs. "You just like making fun of me, don't you?"

"It means loyalty. Devotion. Faithfulness. You know, all those things that come with marriage."

Adora gives the bouquet a dopey little smile. "I really should learn more about flowers so I can do bouquets for you too."

"I'm sure Mama would be happy to help you. She keeps telling me I need to hurry up and give her grandchildren so she can pass her teachings on"…

Catra's voice drifts off when she sees Adora blushing, and she realizes what she said. They haven't really talked about kids. "I'm sure she'd be just as happy to teach you," she corrects herself quickly. "She just wants someone to listen"—

"Do. Do you want kids?"

Okay. They're doing this. "I'm not sure," Catra admits. "I mean… not *right now*."

"No, definitely not right now," Adora agrees quickly. "But… maybe? Someday?" She gasps suddenly. "Would they have little magic cat ears?"

Catra laughs, tugging Adora close again.

"Your priorities are"…

Her voice drifts off when something moves in the corner of her eye. She turns quickly to see a mass of white disappearing into the nearby bushes. "What the"…

"Catra?" Adora calls after her, frowning, as she walks toward the bushes. "What's wrong?"

"I thought I saw"…

Nothing. There's nothing there when she parts the shrubbery to look. Just more flowers. "Thought you saw what?" Adora's voice is wary now; Catra can practically hear her going into threat assessment mode.

"Um…nothing I guess." She looks down at the bush, passively noting the flowers. Gladiolus. *Remembrance.* She brushes her fingers against the flowers before straightening up again. "Why don't we head into the village? Maybe we can find a new jacket that you'll tolerate."

"Just admit you're jealous that I wear Bright Moon colors. It's okay, really."

Adora is smirking, daring Catra to take the bait. She rolls her eyes, gently tugging Adora's ponytail as she walks by.

"Don't flatter yourself."

Normally, Catra would need a guard of some kind to walk down to the village—not that she thinks anyone would ever hurt her. Magicats are peaceful. But her mothers are overprotective. They trust Adora, though; they always have. It's certainly *odd* to marry outside of the magicat kingdom, but they never judged Adora or

made her feel unwelcome. Catra is grateful for their easy acceptance of this.

The tailor greets them as they walk into the shop, humbled by the presence of the princess. Not that Catra doesnt make a habit of visiting whenever she can. She likes the village. She likes her people. But they always seem slightly awestruck by her.

"We're trying to get Adora a better color for her jacket," she explains, pointedly ignoring Adora mouthing *she's jealous* to the tailor. The old tomcat chuckled.

"I'm sure we can find something suitable and to her liking. If you'll come with me"…

Adora follows the tailor, smiling. Catra begins to as well, but her attention is drawn to a piece of paper on the counter ~~-no~~tes the tailor had abandoned when they had walked in. Except they're not notes anymore. Instead, they're one word.

Mara.

Static consumes her hearing; her head snaps up to see cracks forming in the air around her, breaking apart the store and the world beyond, like a picture being ripped to pieces. She screams.

"Catra?"

And just like that, the world's back to normal. Catra snaps around to look at Adora, who's grabbed her shoulders, trying to get her attention. "What's wrong?"

Catra opens and closes her mouth a few times, looking back at the counter. The piece of paper is just notes again. There are no shining white cracks in the air around them. Everything is fine.

Everything is fine.

"N-Nothing. It's nothing." She shakes her head, taking a few deep breaths and try to calm her trembling body. "I'm just going to step outside for a minute."

"I'll come with you"—

"It's fine," Catra assures Adora gently, tucking a strand of hair back behind her ear. "Keep looking for a jacket. I think I'm just feeling a little squished."

It isn't a big shop, and there are clothes racks on all sides. Adora frowns but steps back, nodding, and allows Catra to step back out onto the street. She takes a deep breath, feeling herself relax slightly. This must be because of the dream she'd had – whatever it was. She's just a little on edge. It's fine. She's fine. Everything is fine.

The sound of a child crying reaches her ears. She looks up without really looking, ears twitching at the noise. It's not uncommon to heard children crying for one reason or another…

"*Be quiet you insolent child!*"

A hand slaps across the face, knocking her away. She tries to stifle her sobs as she straightens up, rubbing her cheek…

Catra recoils, a hand automatically reaching for her face before she quickly stops herself. Had that been part of her dream? Her mothers would never hit her like that, and the voice hadn't been familiar. So why does she feel like she knows it?

"Princess?"

Someone has stopped to look at her, wide-eyed and frowning. She must look upset. She forces a smile, her voice brittle as she says, "Sorry, I'm fine."

The man doesn't look sure, but Adora appears behind her then, taking her hand, and he knows she'll be okay. He leaves; Catra turns

back to Adora, rolling her eyes. "Did you miss me that much?"

"Shut up." She smiles, kissing Catra's cheek, but something in her voice is strained. "I *actually* found something I like. The tailor said it should be ready by the end of the day."

Catra fakes a gasp. "*You* found something you *like*? Amazing. Can I see it?"

"No, it's a surprise."

That gets Adora a pout. "You know, I could walk back in there right now and order him to let me see it."

"Yeah. But will you?"

Of course she won't, and they both know it. They start down the street again, enjoying their time together. They don't see each other nearly enough. But that'll change when they're married, won't it? Adora will be here all the time. They'll be together. It'll be perfect.

Perfect.

Why does the word feel wrong?

Adora sighs, resting her free hand on Catra's arm. "We'll be home soon. I'm sorry."

"*What—*"

A bolt runs through Catra's spine. She yells in pain and surprise, collapsing…

Catra jerks to a halt, pulling her hand away from Adora's without thinking. Adora stops, surprised, and looks back at Catra, blinking. "What's wrong?"

"I, um…"

She's being ridiculous. She shakes her head, letting out a long breath, and shoots Adora a reassuring smile. "I'm fine. Sorry . The dream I had is staying with me."

Adora carefully reaches out, grasping her arm again and squeezing. "It's okay. It was just a dream, right? Nothing can hurt you here."

Catra nods, smiling and sliding her arm to grasp Adora's hand. "Yeah. I've got the best guard in all of Etheria with me. I'm not scared."

Adora grins, tugging her close and kissing her again. Catra sighs, content, her nerves settling. "We should go home. I'm sure Mom and Mama have a million more questions for you."

"And I'm sure I have no answers." Adora swallows, nervous. "Is this a big deal because I'm marrying a princess?"

"Yes." Catra kisses her cheek. "Regret it?"

"Nah. It's worth the extra work."

Glyra and Lyra do indeed have ten million more questions for Adora —or that's how it feels to her, she tells Catra in hushed tones during breaks in conversation. Glyra and Lyra hear, of course, and do their best to pretend they can't to save Adora's dignity. Somehow, she still hasn't figured out that no living thing is capable of being quiet enough to go undetected by magical hearing.

"And there's still the matter of colors," Lyra is saying when Catra tunes back in to the conversation. "I imagine you would look good in a nice, dark red, dear"…

"Me?" Adora looks down at herself, uncertain. "I dunno"…

"What about that dress you wore to Princess Prom?" Catra suggests. "That was red. It was a nice color on you."

"You're biased," Adora informs her, rolling her eyes, but she's smiling.

"We'll ask Glimmer, then." Catra looks at her mothers, hope in her gaze. "Can we take a break? I'd like to spend a *little* time with Adora before she has to go back to Bright Moon."

"Of course," Cyra says before Lyra can answer. "Take some time together. You don't get nearly enough."

"But we need to talk more about clothing before Adora leaves!" Lyra adds. "We want this to be the perfect wedding."

"I know, I know"…

Catra grabs Adora, dragging her out of the room. Adora relaxes noticeably once they're in the hall. She really hates talking about clothes and what looks *good* on her. "Relax," Catra says, squeezing her hand. "Whatever you end up wearing, you're going to look amazing."

"You don't know that. What if I look like an idiot?"

"Then you'll be *my* idiot, and I'll still love you."

Adora smiles tentatively. It's weird to see her insecure about something, but Catra's seen it enough to be familiar with it. "I love you too," she says, tugging Catra into a tight hug.

"*Mira dearie*!"

The voice echoes in Catra's ears. She pulls away from Adora and looks around, as if she thinks she can locate the source, but she knows there isn't one. Not one she can see, anyway. "Catra!" Adora grabs her shoulder, gently shaking her back to reality. "What's wrong?"

"Um." Catra shakes her head. "I…think I need to lie down."

"*You can't escape the truth, Catra. You're not a hero. You're a harbinger of chaos. Nothing good will ever follow you." Catra stares up at her, too numb to react. "Come home. The Fright Zone is the only place you belong."*

"Catra?

She jumps. They're back in her room. "What...how did we get here?

"We...walked," Adora says slowly. "Remember?

She's not sure *what* she remembers anymore. Did they walk? It doesn't feel like they did. "Maybe you should see a healer," Adora suggests, squeezing her hand. "You're starting to worry me—"

"Adora, how did we meet?

The words tumble out of her mouth without her permission. Adora's eyebrows crinkle in concern, a frown creasing her lips. "We met in Bright Moon. Your...Your mothers brought you to meet the other princesses during a meeting."

The other princesses. Glimmer. Perfuma. Mermista. Entrapta. Netossa and Spinnerella. But that doesn't feel right. She doesn't remember meeting them as a kid. She remembers...Adora. Only Adora.

"Catra?" Adora sounds a little scared. "Catra, talk to me. Please. What's going on? I'm worried about you."

"I'm fine." Catra's voice sounds hollow. Feels hollow. She swallows hard, looking around the room. Why does it feel wrong? Everything is supposed to be perfect. Why does she feel like she's standing in a dream?

White light flashes again, cracks appearing in the air as if reality is falling apart. Catra jerks back in surprise, yelping.

"*If you open a portal, death and destruction will follow.*"

And the room is back to normal again. Adora's hands are tight on her shoulders, her voice hopping up an octave or two in her concern. "I *really* think you need to see a healer"—

"No." Catra takes a few deep breaths, trying to steady herself. "I don't think this is something healers can fix."

She steps away, stopping Adora when she tries to follow. "I'll be right back. Just wait, okay?"

"I'm not just letting you wander off"—

"I'm going to see my moms. That's it. I'll be back in a few."

She takes off before Adora can protest. Adora will probably chase her, but she's faster. She's always been faster. It's one thing she's certain of.

It's the only thing she's certain of, at the moment.

Cyra and Lyra are in Cyra's office when Catra bursts through the door, frazzled and breathless. "Catra! What's wrong"—

"How old am I?"

Her mothers exchange uncertain glances. "You're twenty, sweetheart. You know that."

"When was I born? When did I meet Adora? When did we get *engaged*?" She rips her mask off her head, metal edges cutting into her palms as she grasps it. "What is this?"

"Cyra and Lyra exchange uncertain glances. "Catra, maybe you should rest"—

"Answer me!"

Golden light bursts to life as the mask starts glowing, and for the first time since waking up, Catra feels as if she can *see*. Her mothers are.wrong. Glowing. Fading. Catra backs up, shaking. And in that moment, she knows.th.is isnt real.

None of this is real.

But it could be. The thought startles her. *It could be real. You could have this family. This kingdom. A dora. All you have to do is let go and forget*.

No. Catra sqeezes her eyes shut, shaking her head. She cant do that. She knows she cant. "I'm sorry ," she whispers to Cyra and Lyra. She wonders if they were ever real. Or if they had just been created for this perfect world.

She turns and runs out again, sprinting down the hall to find Adora. They crash into each other on the stairs;Catra barely grabs Adora to keep her from falling.

"There you are! Will you please tell me what' s going on?What —W - Why is your mask glowing?"

Catra meets her gaze, sees the fear in her eyes. *Adora* . Sweet, naive, well-meaning Adora. "It' s not real," she says qietly , tears filling her eyes. "W e made a mistake."

"What do you mean?"

The ground shakes, opening up beneath them. Adora tackles Catra, sending them both back down to the ground, then grabs her hand to drag her up so they can run. Catra fumbles to settle the mask back on her head, then grabs Adora and jumps, hauling them both up to the nearest window sill. "What".Adora is looking around, stunned, before her eyes settle back on Catra. "What' s happening?"

"I was wrong." Catra drags her arm across her eyes. "I was wrong, Adora. Im so, so sorry . This isnt what I wanted."

They jump from the sill, landing outside, and beginning running down the path to the village. Everything is shaking and crumbling now. "Catra, I don't understand," Adora says desperately. "What do you mean we were wrong? What's happening?"

"We pulled the lever." Catra can see it in her head now, clear as day. The desperate looks they gave each other before they silently agreed. Their hands grasping the lever. Together. "I thought we were doing the right thing, and you listened to me, and I… this is all my fault." Her voice breaks on the last word as she tries not to cry. "I just wanted to fix everything. I wanted things to be *okay* again—"

She stops abruptly as they run into someone, knocking them both back. "Well now!" a reedy voice declares. "It's about time! Keeping Madame Razz waiting. I'm an old lady, you know, I don't have time for this!"

Catra looks up, surprised. Pinkish skin, white hair, large glasses magnifying her eyes…

"*Razz*?"

She surges up, grabbing the old lady by the shoulders. "*Please* be normal, I don't have time for—"

"You don't have time for a lot, from the looks of it, kitty."

That surprise Catra. "You know me?"

"Of course I know you, we've met! Or we will meet. Hmmm." She tilts her head, thinking. "I always get those two mixed up."

It's weird that this is the most *normal* Razz has ever sounded. Catra's hands shake as her fingers tighten. "I messed up, Razz. I tried so hard to fix everything, but I'm just like them, aren't I? Mara and the magicats—"

"Mara and the magicats saved the world!" Razz emphasizes her words by bopping Catra's head with her broom. "Haven't you learned anything?" The words stun Catra into silence. "There's still time to fix all of this. But you must act quickly. You must go back to the beginning."

"The...what?" Catra's mind is racing. "Do you mean the Fright Zone?"

"No, not that beginning, *your* beginning! You need to find the sword!"

"The...sword. Catra's eyes widen as the pieces click into place. "The sword. Glimmer and Bow!" She whirls to look at Adora, who's still staring in disbelief. "We have to find—"

She stops, horrified, when she sees the ground behind Adora cracking apart. There's no thought in her next actions; she grabs Adora's arm and whirls to shove her away, nearly throwing her into Razz. The old lady's grip is surprisingly strong.

"Catra!—"

The earth breaks apart, a fissure separating them. Catra stumbles back, trying to catch herself. But she already knows there's no time left.

Her mind flashes quickly back to the hologram of Mara, sitting in the chair on the ship, bent over, injured, speaking through pain. To Half Moon, a desolate kingdom with nothing but a few bodies left of the once thriving society.

This is her legacy. This is her destiny, as She-Ra and as the last Magicat. She has to fix the world. No matter what.

Catra rips the mask off her head, throwing it to Adora. "Find Glimmer and Bow! They'll be able to help you." She's not sure how, but she believes in them. Believes in the stupid Best Friend Squad. They can fix this.

“*Catra*!”

Adora dives to try and grab Catra before she falls away, but it’s too late. All she can do is watch, horrified, as her best friend falls from sight. She drops to her knees, shaking.

No. No, come back. I need you. Come back.

“You have to go, dearie.” A gentle hand rests on Adora’s shoulder. “You can still save her, but you have to go *now*.”

Adora looks up at the old lady, lost. Her resolve hardens after a moment, and she nods, pushing herself up. Find Glimmer and Bow. That shouldn’t be too hard. She knows exactly where they are.

Razz watches her run off and smiles, sweeping the ground absentmindedly. “I think you’d like them, Mara. They’re both so much like you.”

And with that she turns, walking into the encroaching abyss.

Chapter End Notes

> So uh.... you might've noticed I really went in a different direction with this..... let me know what you think, maybe?? I've been looking forward to posting this for MONTHS (yes I've been planning ahead that long), and it'd be really nice to hear thoughts.
>
> Also, I know the question is coming - Is Catra the lost Magicat princess?
>
> Answer: ¯_(ツ)_/¯ It's not going to come up again, and I've put a lot of thought into it both ways, but at the end of the day, I'm leaving it to reader interpretation. But it doesn't change the story (and Catra eventually half-asses some excuse to justify why her brain thought princess and engaged to Adora were her prefect

world), and at the end of the day the magicats are still dead, soooooooooooooo. Whatever brings you the most joy.

Fixing Their Mistakes

Chapter Summary

I remember . How do we fix this?

Adora looks up at the swirling vortex over their heads. Catra and Angella follow her gaze, find the shape right in the middle of it all. "The sword," Catra murmurs, putting it together . "If we pull out the sword"—

"Then everything goes back to normal," Adora finishes.

"And what happens to the person who takes the sword?" Angella asks. Adora doesn't answer .

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The run to Bright Moon takes what feels like minutes. Which is absolutely wrong, Adora thinks, because it's definitely at least half a day's travel. But in no time at all she's bursting out of the woods, running to the bridge.

"Adora!" Glimmer appears beside her , beaming. "I thought you were spending the night in Half Moon? Did you bring Catra with you?"

Adora freezes, staring at the princess in disbelief. She's talking like they're friends. Because they are, in her mind. She grew up with Adora. Adora *would* have been the captain of her future guard, if not for the whole marrying Catra thing. That's how things are in this world.

This fake world, which is falling apart, quite literally , at the seams.

Adora holds Catra's mask close to her chest, taking a few deep breaths. "I have to talk to your parents. Now . It's an emergency."

Glimmer looks at the mask, then at Adora, her expression falling. "Adora? What's going on?"

"No time. I'm sorry . We need to go *now*."

The princess hesitates before nodding and taking Adora's hand, teleporting them inside.

To say Micah and Angella are stunned by Adora's story is an understatement.

"Adora, are you okay?" Micah asks after a moment. *Is she okay?* No, of course not! The world is *literally* falling apart, Catra is gone, and it's somehow on *her* to fix everything and as the last year and a half has proved, she is *terrible* at fixing anything. Now she has to fix the entire world? Of course she's not okay! What kind of ridiculous question is that?!

"Y -Yes, your majesty," she mutters, staring at the floor . "Trust me, I'm aware of how crazy all this sounds, but it's it's true."

She remembers being in the portal room with Catra. The silent agreement to pull the lever. Grabbing it together. Sealing their fates. *Together at the end of the world*.

Except they weren't together now .

Micah and Angella exchange looks before turning back to Adora. "Did something happen in Half Moon?" Angella asks gently . "Did you and Catra have a fight?"

"Wha —no!" Adora's a little insulted. "You think I'd make all this up for for attention or something?!"

"Not necessarily , just.perhaps"…

Angella looks to Micah for help. He shakes his head. "It' s all just a little *much*, Adora. You know we trust you"—

"Then trust me with this," Adora says desperately . She's never had to do something like this before —Shadow W eaver and Hordak had always been straight forward, rather than dancing around the point. She has no idea what to do. "I *wish* this was all some lie or hallucination!" She hugs the mask tighter to her chest. "Catra… Catra sacrificed herself to save *me* even though I dont deserve it."

Tears are filling her eyes now, the weight of a year of anger and hate and spite and jealousy crashing in all at once. "I treated her like she was an idiot, like she had no idea what she was doing, like there was no way she could possibly be making this kind of choice for herself. I.I . *stabbed her*." Adora laughs, almost hysterical. "She has every right to hold that against me! And then I brought her back to Shadow Weaver and I almost let her.she was going to"…

Adora shudders, squeezing her eyes shut. "And then I was mad at her for leaving. But of course she left, why *wouldn't* she? Shadow Weaver was terrible to her and I.I .let her get away with it. I let Shadow Weaver hurt her for *years* when I said I was protecting her. I *promised*."

Silence follows, then the sound of footsteps, and a gentle hand rests on Adora's shoulder. She looks up, meeting Angella's gaze. *No wonder Catra likes it better here*, she thinks vaguely. "Adora, we know you care about Catra. If something happened, and you say you didnt mean for it to, then we believe you."

You shouldn't. All I've done is hurt her . Do I really care about her at all?

She knows the answer. She's just been going about trying to prove it all the wrong ways.

"Give us a moment, please. Obviously we…have a lot to discuss."

Adora nods numbly, turning and walking out. She's barely closed the door behind her when a hand grabs her jacket, and then she's in another room. Teleporting, she realizes faintly when she sees Glimmer and Bow in front of her. Is…Is he wearing *glasses*?

Focus.

"Okay, have you lost your mind?" Glimmer demands. "You have to tell us if you've gone crazy."

"What do you mean?"

"We heard what you told the king and queen," Bow explains. "No offense, but it all sounds a bit"…

"Crazy," Glimmer finishes for him. "It sounds crazy."

"I'm *aware* that it sounds crazy, okay?" Adora says impatiently. "Good to know you're still *completely* unhelpful and frustrating."

Glimmer scoffs, offended. "*I'm* unhelpful and frustrating? You're the stubborn one who!" She stops very suddenly, blinking in surprise.

"Glimmer?" Bow asks uncertainly. The princess is staring at Adora now, as if seeing her for the first time. Her eyes fix on the mask.

"Catra. Where's Catra?"

Adora's shoulders slump. "I lost her," she admits quietly. "But…But I think I can fix this. I *have* to be able to fix this. There has to be a way. I'm just not sure *how*."

Bow tilts his head, thinking. "Well, you said all of this started with a portal, right? Can you think of anyone who—" He stops, just like Glimmer had, momentary surprise, then confusion fluttering through his features. "Entrapta."

"Entrapta!" Adora repeats, heart jumping. "Of course, she'll have an answer, she *always* has an answer! Whether I want it or not!" One of her less endearing traits, but it was fine. Adora would love it right now. "Glimmer , can you take us to Dryl?"

"T o *Dryl* ?" Glimmer repeats, raising an eyebrow . "Not really . I mean, that's pretty far."

Right. Of course it is. Adora blows out a long breath, running her hands through her hair; her gaze happens to fall on the window overlooking the woods. They're starting to come apart. Just like Half Moon.

"Okay , can you teleport us to the front hall?"

"Um..probably." She of fers Adora her hand. Adora takes it, Bow resting a hand on her shoulder. And they appear in the entrance hall.

"Great! Now just a brisk… *run* to Dryl, and"—

"What are you three doing?"

They jump, whirling to see Angella and Micah standing behind them. "Um..going for a walk?" Glimmer says weakly . Angella raises an eyebrow at her, then looks at Adora.

"If you want us to take your concerns seriously , this is hardly the way to prove"—

"I *know.*" Adora can't put enough stress on that word. "I know , trust me, but we *have* to go. We have to see Entrapta."

"Entrapta? The Dryl princess?"

"Y es! If anyone can help, it's her. You *have* to let us go"—

"Glimmer?"

Adora looks at Micah, then at Glimmer, who's staring at him as if she's just seen a ghost. *Oh*. Adora doesn't know much about the Bright Moon monarchy. But she knows King Micah – the *real* King Micah – died years ago.

More cracks appear in the air around them, the ground crumbling. "Oh no," Adora groans, backing up. "It's getting worse. We have to go. *Now*."

Glimmer wipes the tears from her eyes, nodding and putting on a smile for her parents. "I'm sorry. But we have to fix this. We have to make it right."

"What are you"—

Bright light flashes around them; the ground gives out from beneath Adora's feet. She screams as she falls, vaguely hearing Bow and Glimmer fall with her…

And then they're in a dark room, lit only by screens and with filled with robots. And one pink-haired young woman. She turns, sliding her mask up and tilting her head. "Hello! Do I know you?"

This is apparently Entrapta's perfect reality. Alone in her castle with only her robots for friends. No human interaction. It's a little sad, Adora thinks as she watches Entrapta babble away. Catra's perfect reality had been them, together, happy. Glimmer's was having her father. Bow's was not having to be a soldier.

Entrapta's is, apparently, complete solitude.

Feel bad later. Focus now.

Adora clears her throat. "Entrapta, I know what i'm about to say sounds crazy-"

"Is this about the unstable portal slowly consuming and warping our reality?"

"Now , you're not gonna believe"—Adora stops, blinking at her . "W ait. What did you just say?"

Entrapta walks back to her computer, tapping away at the keyboard, bringing up some images Adora doesn't quite understand.

"Oh, I figured it out a while ago. An unstable portal is the only thing that would account for all the anormalies I've been picking up in my research. The portal exists somewhere in our world and as long as its still open, it's gonna keep to destablising reality, making this disappear until —bam!" She rockets back on her hair to stare at all of them, wide-eyed and slightly manic. "Nothing's left!" The laugh that follows is cut short as she soberly adds, "Which is a bad thing."

"How do we stop it?" Adora asks desperately , stepping forward. Entrapta turns away, her voice soft.

"Portals are gateways." She walks back to her computer . "W ormholes that connect one area of space to another. The only way to turn it off is from the inside. But who ever shuts down the portal can't leave. they'll be trapped between realities, possibly forever." She pulls up a diagram as she speaks. It' s all gibberish to Adora. "Oh! Imagine the data they could collect!"

"W ait," Glimmer demands, "so whoever turns it of f will be trapped inside it forever?"

Entrapta wont look at them as she speaks. "Exactly ."

"There must be another way!" Adora insists. "T ry to remember, Entrapta. When you and Hordak built the portal machine"—

She cuts off as Entrapta gasps. "Remember" she says distantly . "I remember , I had a lab partner, Hordak, we were friends. I was helping him. Catra. Catra was scared it was a mistake, and"…

The castle begins to shake, snapping her out of her stupor. "No, no!" Adora protests. "This can't be happening already! We should've had more time."

"There is no more time," Entrapta says slowly. "The portal is… following you. But why you? It's powered by the sword, which is Catra's, but she's not here."

Her eyes trail down to the mask Adora is still clinging to. "Unless… it's following the power from the mask. The sword and the mask were created to work together, to sense each other. If Catra isn't here, it would grab the next best thing."

"The mask," Adora repeats. "It's following the mask. And I have the mask."

"Exactly." Entrapta nods, smiling a little, before starting to fade.

"Wait, no!" Adora springs forward to grab her, but she's already intangible.

"You need to remove the sword from the inside," she reminds them. "It's powering the portal. It's the only way to fix all of this!"

"Wait, I—"

I can't do this alone. I need someone.

I need Catra.

The castle cracks apart around them, and then they're in the Whispering Woods. Adora whips around, recognizing the palace they're standing in front of—the place she'd followed Catra into once.

She doesn't recognize the woman standing in front of the building.

But there's no time before a fissure cracks the ground between them, a blur of pink and white energy washing her away. Adora

whirls to look at Glimmer and Bow, who staring back, wide-eyed. And she feels a sharp pang of pain. These two…they had taken care of Catra when Adora couldn't, picked up the slack where she failed. Adora owes them so much.

"I'll fix this." Her voice wavers slightly as she speaks. Glimmer steps forward, taking her hand. Bow takes both their hands in his.

"We believe in you."

Adora laughs hollowly. "You sure that's a good idea?"

"No." Glimmer smiles as she says the word. "So don't make us regret it."

They're starting to fade, their hands slipping away. Adora drops her arms to her sides, watching them go. And she nods, turning to face the vast expanse of whiteness before her.

She's not sure where she's going, or how long she walks before a faint whimper hits her ears. Her head snaps up, eyes wide. Is someone else in here? "Hello?"

No answer. Adora turns a few times, trying to pinpoint the noise, and finally runs off to the left. She runs long enough for her side to hurt, for her breath to come in heavy pants, and she's about to stop when she notices something huddled up ahead. Something red, with a mane of bushy brown hair.

"*Catra*!"

She doesn't react when Adora calls her name, or when Adora drops to the ground beside her. "Catra—hey, what's wrong? Look at me, please"—

She slowly starts to unravel. And Adora sees the problem.

The portal's done… *something* to her. Her right arm and half her face are just black, as if someone erased her features but left the shape

of her in place. Adora stares in horror, mouth hanging open, until Catra finally speaks.

"Adora?"

Her voice is twisted, distorted —and scared. She' s so scared. Adora hasnt heard that in her voice since they were kids, since the days when words alone were enough to hurt her. Before she'd grown and turned hard against the world. Before the universe had conspired to break her, and succeeded in so many ways.

"I'm here."Adora wraps her in a tight hug, taking her corrupted hand and squeezing tight. "Y ou and me, together at the end of the world. Right?"

Catra laughs. "Right."

They stay that way for a few moments, Adora only pulling away to slip Catra's mask back into place. The ground cracks beneath them, opening up. Adora feels them fall, and hugs Catra closer, hiding her face in the magicat's hair, the last safe place in the entire universe…

And then a pair of arms grabs them both, pulling them out of the white, out of the void, to the one safe place left in reality.

The girls grunt as they're gently deposited onto the ground. Catra shoots up, patting herself down, trying not to panic. She's fine. She's fixed. Her arm is back to normal, her face no longer twisted, and though she hasnt spoken yet, she knows her voice will be normal. She turns quickly to find their savior .

"Angella!"

It's been a long, long few days, and Catra is completely wrung dry. Shell blame that for why she throws herself at the queen and holds her tight, if ever asked. Angella holds her close, looking up to meet Adora's gaze.

I remember . How do we fix this?"

Adora looks up at the swirling vortex over their heads. Catra and Angella follow her gaze, find the shape right in the middle of it all. "The sword," Catra murmurs, putting it together . "If we pull out the sword"—

"Then everything goes back to normal," Adora finishes.

"And what happens to the person who takes the sword?" Angella asks. Adora doesn't answer .

"They're stuck," Catra concludes, stepping away from Angella. "Someone has to stay here so everyone else can live."

Silence falls, save for the winds whistling around them. "W ell." Catra rolls her shoulders, taking a deep breath. "I lived a good life."

"Catra"—

"It' s okay." She tries to smile as she looks back at Angella. "This is what I wanted. To fix the mistakes Mara and the magicats made. If there are no more First Ones, and no more magicats, then... then She-Ra won't come back. And maybe it' s better that way." She can't help the tears that well in her eyes. "Maybe it' s better to end this curse."

"Y our existence is not a curse," Angella protests, taking her by the shoulders. Catra laughs bitterly, wiping the tears away.

"But this is how it' s supposed to be. Destiny, or whatever. Besides, it's all I'm good for . Taking hits for everyone else."

A hand grabs Catra's wrist. She turns, meeting a familiar gaze. "Hey Adora." W ords she's uttered a million times in their relatively short lives. Words she'll never say again.

It feels weird to think about that.

Adora pulls her forward, wrapping her in a tight hug. It's wonderful. It's familiar. It's like coming home. Catra buries her face in Adora's neck, letting herself have this one last indulgence. Adora meets Angella's gaze. There's a burning determination in those eyes.

"Hey ." Adora pulls away to look at Catra, giving her a small smile. "You look out for me, and I look out for you. Right?"

"Yeah." Catra chuckles. That promise feels like another lifetime. "We've been really bad at that lately ."

"*I've* been really bad at it lately," Adora corrects her . "But I'm going to fix it."

"You're"—

Adora knees Catra in the stomach, then shoves her back. Angella grabs Catra as she tries to recover from the surprise attack, while Adora runs to the edge of their safe spot, jumping and landing on a floating rock.

Catra coughs, trying to catch her breath. Watering eyes open just in time to see Adora jump again, higher .

"*Adora* !"

Angella's grip around her is surprisingly strong. The queen's seen that determined look before in Glimmer 's eyes. In Micah's. It's the look of someone ready to die to do what's right.

"Let me *go*!" Catra's voice cracks as she shouts, straining against the arms holding her in place. "Adora!"

She lands on another rock, closer now, and looks back. She's smiling, Catra notes dumbly. She looks peaceful. "I'm sorry ," she calls, voice steady. "I'm sorry I didn't protect you the way I should have. I'm sorry I didn't believe you. I should've known you've always been the smart one."

Catra stares, horrified, and struggles to find her voice. "Are you *stupid*!? You're going to die!"

"Yeah, well." Adora shrugs. "I was voted most likely to die in some ridiculous way for a reason, right?" She squares her shoulders. One more jump, and she'll be close enough to grab the sword. "You're more than cannon fodder, Catra. You don't just exist to take hits for other people. You're amazing, and brave, and strong, and I wish... I wish I'd listened to you sooner. But I can do this to make up for it. I can fix all of this. It'll be okay."

She jumps.

Catra can only watch, Angella's hands tight on her shoulders, as Adora grabs the sword. It crackles with energy as she pulls, grimacing. Catra's mind has gone blank, leaving room for one errant thought — *I wonder if it hurts*.

The sword comes free. Adora stumbles back, losing her grip; it falls, the vortex collapses on itself, closing Adora in its folds.

Catra's eyes hurt. She stares blankly as the sword floats down, reaches out automatically to catch it. She simply stares, silent, unsure if she wants to scream or cry or collapse to her knees or sleep and never wake up…

She does nothing. Her hands shake slightly, fingers tightening around the hilt of the sword, but her mind is empty.

I can fix all of this.

Except it was never hers to *fix*. This isn't Adora's fault. Stupid, fucking, idiotic, naive Adora. Too good for the Horde, and too good for this world.

It's not fair.

"Catra." Angella's voice is soft, mournful. Catra nods, raising the sword. There's no time for her feelings. She has a world to save.

"For the honor of Grayskull."

Catra doesn't remember leaving the portal. Or arriving back in the lab. Or slicing the portal apart with enough intensity to cut through a building.

It's Bow and Glimmer who snap her out of the haze, barreling into her with enough strength to nearly knock her over.

"You did it!"

"What just *happened*?!"

"I knew you'd — *Mom*?!" Glimmer nearly chokes on air when she sees her mother calmly approaching. "I — I can explain—"

"This is all very sweet," Shadow Weaver drawled. "But I believe it would be best to make our exit now."

"She's right," Angella agrees, though it looks painful for her to do so. The princesses, the queen, and Bow gather around Shadow Weaver. Catra takes a long moment before stepping close enough for the spell to catch her.

And then they're back in Bright Moon. It's so bright. So happy. Everything Catra's not at the moment. Everyone else is cheering and celebrating, and Catra swears she sees Perfuma hug Shadow Weaver. She decides not to ask about it.

"Tell us everything!" Glimmer says as she tackles Catra again. Bow gets her in a hug from behind. "Mom, how did *you* end up there?"

"It's a long story," Angella says.

"We pulled the lever." Catra's voice is dead. It fits the rest of her. "The only way to fix it was to get the sword out and go back to destroy the portal." She transforms, happy to slip back into her own skin. She wants to throw the sword out the window right then. "But to get the sword, someone had to stay behind."

It's obvious when each person understands what this means, but only one of them voices the thought.

"Adora." It's Shadow Weaver, of course. Catra's eyes flash; the sword drops to the ground as she closes the space between herself and her former guardian, grabbing her and shoving her as hard as she can into a wall.

"Catra!"

"*You* don't get to say her name," Catra snarls, claws raised. "You don't get to say her name *ever again*." The last few days are catching up fast. Images of Half Moon, of bodies, of a world falling apart, flash before her eyes. The years of abuse, using each other as punishment and leverage over the other, the unspoken but growing resentment they felt for the responsibility. "You did *all of this*! *You* fucked us up, *you* made Adora think she was only worth what she could do for everyone else, you're the reason I ended up in the Fright Zone! None of this would have happened if you'd just *died* before you even left Mystacor!"

"Hey." It's Mermista, surprisingly, who grabs her wrist. "She's not worth doing something you'll regret later."

Catra *vehemently* disagrees. It's worth a lot. Catra won't lose any sleep. And she'll be doing the world a favor. But she lets Mermista pull her away from the shadows, back to Glimmer's and Bow's waiting arms.

She's tired. She's *so tired*. She lets herself be wrapped up, hearing Angella call for guards to bring Shadow Weaver back to her cell. Catra wait until she knows the sorceress is gone. And then she

breaks. Bow takes most of her weight as her knees collapse;he lowers her gently to the ground, where Glimmer joins them and hugs her tight. Catra knows she should be ashamed or embarrassed or… *something*. But she can't bring herself to care.

It feels like there's a weight on her shoulders, keeping her down, keeping her head bowed. She sags into her friends' arms, hiccuping. It's not fair. None of this is fair. She's never been delusional enough to think that the world would treat her fairly —Shadow Weaver beat that notion out of her early enough —but she had never really thought it was actively against her, either. Or maybe she had just thought it didn't matter , as long as she had Adora.

"*Nothing bad can really happen as long as we have each other."*

"*You promise?*

"*I promise*."

"I'm tired,"she finally whispers hoarsely . "I'm sorry ."

"There' s nothing to be sorry for,"Bow assures her while Glimmer nods vigorously, resting a hand on each of their shoulders.

"Want me to take you to your room?"

The idea of teleporting should make Catra feel sick, but she doesn't care. She nods once, wiping her eyes over Bow's shoulder.

And they disappear in a shower of sparkles.

Chapter End Notes

> So... I'll be on hiatus for two weeks, updates will resume January 29th.
>
> Please let me know what you think?

One Month Later

Chapter Summary

"But you won't *talk* to us. Please, Catra, we need you—"

"No, you need *She-Ra*," Catra shoots back. "I'm just the only person unlucky enough to turn into her."

"That's not true!" Glimmer protests. "You've helped us as yourself plenty of times, and you're our friend. No one thinks you're *just* She-Ra."

Catra scoffs. "Sure. I wouldn't even be here if I'd never found that stupid sword, and you know it." Glimmer can't really respond to that. It's true that she probably never would have ended up in Bright Moon, in the Rebellion, if she hadn't found the sword. "And *you're* the one who brought me here."

Glimmer stiffens. "Are you saying this is all *my* fault?" she asks in disbelief. "You're the one who gave the sword to Hordak! *We* tried to stop you!"

The Fright Zone is the only place you belong. It's the only place that will keep the rest of the world safe from you.

You're not a hero. You're a harbinger of chaos. Nothing good will ever follow you.

"I'm saying none of this would've happened if I'd stayed in the Fright Zone." Catra turns away, squeezing her eyes shut. "Just...leave me alone."

Chapter Notes

https://crackedfishtank.tumblr.com/post/640780970702913537/image-made-for-catrasredemptions-magicatra-au check out this

amazing fucking art I got commissioned.

And be ready for pain

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"We've officially taken back Thaymor, for real," Glimmer says proudly, tapping Thaymor on the map and turning it from red to purple. The map was still largely red, but they're making progress.

It's been a month since the portal. The Horde seems to be in disarray —losing their second-in-command had probably hit hard. The disorganization is working in the Rebellion's favor. Slowly but surely, they're taking back Etheria, village by village, town by town. It's wonderful. It's invigorating.

"We have guards in Erlandia, shoring up their defenses," Bow says, tapping away on his tracker pad. "Perfuma reports all quiet on her end. Mermista washed out the one base near Salineas. It seems like a lot of their forces are pulling back. And the ones that aren't have no idea what they're doing."

"I can't say I'm surprised," Angella murmurs. "I was starting to get the feeling Adora was in charge of everything there."

Glimmer's eyes flick to the empty seat on the other side of Bow. There's a lump in her throat that she has to swallow before she can try to speak. "Catra would probably have a little more insight on this."

"Perhaps," Angella agrees with a sigh. Glimmer looks at Bow , who shrugs sadly.

"I tried to talk to her yesterday , but I think she needs a little more time. Everything with Shadow Weaver and Half Moon and the portal really got to her. I'm sure she'll be okay , though."

"Yeah," Glimmer says, looking back at the table. They've been saying to themselves since the first day Catra cried herself to sleep

in their arms. She would be okay. She just needed time. She just needed to work through things.

It's been a month since the portal.

Catra is *not* okay.

Knock knock knock knock.

Catra snaps out of her daze, raising her eyes to stare at the door. "Catra?" Glimmer calls. She's finally learned how to knock, Catra thinks, relaxing back into the bed. "I get it if you don't want to talk, but if you need anything just...let me know, okay? You don't have to be alone."

That almost gets a laugh out of Catra. Of course she has to be alone. Doesn't Glimmer get it? She hurts people. She doesn't deserve friends or anyone who cares about her. She's just going to hurt them in the end. Shadow Weaver was right. All she does is bring chaos wherever she goes.

They all would have been better off without her.

"*I can fix all of this*."

Catra squeezes her eyes shut, burying her face in the covers and curling tight around a pillow. Stupid fucking Adora. She always needed to *fix* things. She always had to be an idiot.

Needed. Had. Past tense. Adora's trapped in a place where nothing can be *fixed*.

"Catra?" Glimmer tries again. Catra can tell she's crying now. "I don't even know if you're still in there, do I? You could've jumped off the balcony and ran away."

Wouldn't be that out of character. Isn't that what she does, after all? Runs away and lets other people deal with her mistakes?

"But I believe you're still here," Glimmer continues. "And when you're ready, we'll be here too. Okay?"

You'll leave eventually.

Catra sighs, closing her eyes and listening to the princess' fading footsteps. Maybe she can get some sleep before the nightmares start again.

Scorpia looks between the files in her pincers, crestfallen. Everything feels like it's falling apart. "We lost Thaymor! And someone, I forget who needs ammunition, *and* I can't find the file. How did Adora do all of this?!"

"I'm pretty sure she gave up on paperwork," Entrapta says without looking away from her computer screen. Scorpia sighs deeply. She wasn't *exactly* promoted, but Adora's gone, and Hordak is locked in his lab, and somehow, running the Horde has fallen on *her* shoulders.

She is *not* doing well.

"Have you talked to Hordak?" she asks Entrapta desperately. The other woman is the only one who ever seems to have any luck talking to him.

Entrapta shakes her head. "He won't even open the door. I had to go in through the ducts. He wasn't happy."

"Did he happen to mention when he'd start running the Horde again?"

"I don't think so, but let's check." She produces her recorder, rewinding and hitting play. Scorpia winces as Hordak yells. He's

scary in a recording too. "No mention of running of the Horde," Entrapta concludes, stopping the playback.

"Great."

"Scorpia." Bonnie pokes her head into the room. Scorpia resists the urge to groan. No one talks to her for no reason anymore. "You got a minute? Things are getting a little messy in one of the training rooms."

"Uh. Can you ask someone else?" Scorpia asks weakly.

"Octavia said you'd take care of it."

"Right." Scorpia sighs, then puts on a smile. "Okay, it's fine. What's going on?"

"One of the training bots has gone rogue."

"Oh!" Entrapta bounces out of her seat and hurries to the door, passed a bewildered Bonnie. "You found Isa!"

"Isa?" Bonnie looks at Scorpia, who shrugs.

"Entrapta will take care of it."

"Oooooooooookay." Bonnie leaned on the doorframe, watching Scorpia. "You uh... need help with anything?"

"You know how to run army?"

Bonnie laughs wryly. "Nah, I'm just a grunt. How'd you end up with Adora's job, anyway?"

"No clue," Scorpia says honestly. "I just woke up one day and everyone was asking *me* what to do. Can you believe that? How am I supposed to know? It's not like Adora ever gave me instructions on what to do if she..."

She doesn't know how to finish that sentence. Bonnie is suddenly very interested in the floor, hands stuffed in her pockets. "I know she was your squad mate," Scorpia continues after a moment. "I'm sorry."

"It is what it is." Bonnie kicks at the floor, frowning deeply. "I learned not to get too attached after Catra took off. And I didn't even like *her* that much to begin with."

"You seem pretty close to Rogelio and Kyle."

Another shrug. "They're my squad mates. And this is war. People are gonna die." She pushes herself up, rolling her shoulders. "Lemme know if there's anything I can help with. I'm good for yelling at people."

"I'll probably take you up on that." Scorpia chuckles. "Thanks."

"Any time."

Scorpia looks back at the files as Bonnie walks away.

This is war. People are gonna die.

How old even *is* Bonnie? She has to be around Adora's age if they were in the same squad. That's too young to be that cynical. To be broken. Adora was always stressed, Catra had looked exhausted the entire time they had been together after coming back from the Crimson Waste. She and Adorr had leaned on each other like they were the only things left in the world, even after everything that had happened.

Maybe *because* of everything that happened.

"Okay, that's taken care of!" Entrapta announces as she walks back in. "I'll look at fixing the walls later, don't worry"—

"Entrapta?

The princess stops, looking around. "Yeah?"

"Is there...any way to open the portal again? Any at all?"

A strand of hair rubs the back of Entrapta's head. She looks uncomfortable. "In theory, maybe? But it would end the same way — someone has to stay behind to close the portal. And I'd have to get the Sword of Protection again, and I don't think Catra's going to give that to us."

"Oh." Scorpia looks back at the paperwork, sighing. "Right."

The Rebellion has been dismantling the Horde's forces, but all the reports have one peculiarity — She-Ra hadn't been seen in any fights since the portal. And she stands out, so it's not like everyone just happens to be missing her. So where she is?

Another, smaller part of Scorpia wonders, *Is she okay?*

"*Why did I ever listen to you?*

Catra takes a few steps back, eyes wide. Adora is glaring at her, standing in front of the portal. She looks so angry.

"*I… I…*"

"*Shadow Weaver was right. All you've ever done is drag me down.*" *The words are like a knife through her heart.*

"*You're the one who took the sword,*" *Catra snaps back, trying to ignore the waver in her voice. She won't cry. Not like this. Not in front of Adora.*

"*To fix* your *stupid mistake! Again!*"

Suddenly Adora is in front of her, shadows swirling around her body, fist raised. Catra yells, taking a step back—

Her eyes snap open. She gasps, shooting up in bed, head snapping around.

Bright Moon. She's in Bright Moon. Not in the portal, not arguing with Adora about whose *fault* all of this was, or who should have been responsible for fixing it. Catra is safe.

*b**like a**dora* .

Catra stumbles out of bed, shaking as she makes her way to the bathroom. The plan is to take a quick shower , to wash off the cold sweat currently clinging to her body. She steps into the bathroom, turns on the light without thinking…

And freezes when she sees herself in the mirror.

She's not in the portal. Logically , she knows that. She knows that cant really be *her* in the mirror, with her arm and half her face turned black by the portal's corruption.

And yet, there the twisted abomination is, staring back at her with its weird, corrupted eye.

Catra screams, reeling back, then clenches her fingers into a fist and drives it into the mirror, shattering the glass. She's breathing heavily as she refocuses, noting the glass embedded in her knuckles. Her reflection is back to normal, though fractured by broken glass. Fitting.

She should take care of her hand. She should get dressed, leave the room, and face the damn world like the hero she's *supposed* to be. She should get over it.

Instead, she sinks to the ground, curls up in a ball, and cries.

Glimmer doesnt really plan on teleporting into the room —she just wants to listen for signs of life. Shell leave Catra alone, because that's what Catra wants, and—

She hears the scream.

"Catra!"

She teleports in without a second thought, finding Catra curled up on the bathroom floor, holding a bleeding fist and crying. "Are you"—

"Do you *ever* knock?" Catra snaps, cutting Glimmer off. She's trying to glare at the princess, although it's weak at best. Still, Glimmer takes a step back, surprised.

"I've been *knocking* for a month now, but you screamed and"—

"And you decided to just let yourself in? What part of *I just want to be alone* did you not get?"

Logically, Glimmer knows that Catra is lashing out. That she's hurting, she's upset, and she has so much bottled up. *Logically*, Glimmer knows all of that.

Emotions aren't always logical, though. "I'm *trying* to help you," Glimmer grits out, clenching her fists. "What's your problem?"

Catra laughs, a loud, hysterical, humorless sound. It's a little disconcerting. "My problem? I don't know, you got six months to sit and listen to it?"

"You know I would," Glimmer says quietly. "But you won't *talk* to us. Please, Catra, we need you"—

"No, you need *She-Ra*," Catra shoots back. "I'm just the only person unlucky enough to turn into her."

"That's not true!" Glimmer protests. "You've helped us as yourself plenty of times, and you're our friend. No one thinks you're *just* She-Ra."

Catra scoffs. "Sure. I wouldn't even be here if I'd never found that stupid sword, and you know it." Glimmer can't really respond to that.

It's true that she probably never would have ended up in Bright Moon, in the Rebellion, if she hadn't found the sword. "And *you're* the one who brought me here."

Glimmer stiffens. "Are you saying this is all *my* fault?" she asks in disbelief. "You're the one who gave the sword to Hordak! *We* tried to stop you!"

The Fright Zone is the only place you belong. It's the only place that will keep the rest of the world safe from you.

You're not a hero. You're a harbinger of chaos. Nothing good will ever follow you.

"I'm saying none of this would've happened if I'd stayed in the Fright Zone." Catra turns away, squeezing her eyes shut. "Just...leave me alone."

A long moment of silence follows before Glimmer teleports away. Catra looks at her injured hand and sinks back to the floor to begin the painful process of pulling out each piece of glass. Alone. Like she's meant to be.

It's dark when Catra jumps down to the grassy ground, heading for the woods. She's not running away. Not *really*. She plans on coming back, but she has questions, and there's only one person she can get answers from.

The woods cooperate today. She finds the Crystal Palace in no time, ripping her mask off as she storms in.

"Light Hope!"

The AI appears, expression passive and unruffled despite the annoyance on Catra's face. "Hello, Catra."

"Yeah, hi, whatever," Catra grits out. "I want answers. *Real* answers, not just that's insignificant."

Light Hope stares at her for a long moment. "You are allowing your emotions to control you"—

"I'm a little emotional right now!" Catra throws her arms up in disgust before beginning to pace. "Sorry, that's what happens when your stupid dumbass best friend sacrifices herself to fix your mistakes!" Her shoulders slump slightly even as her expression hardens. "The mistakes *you* told me Mara and the magicats made."

"Mara made a choice fueled by dangerous emotions"—

"She wasn't a robot!" Catra cuts in. "Or a hologram, or an AI, or whatever! She was a person, and people have feelings!"

"That can not be allowed when one has as much power as Mara wielded. As you currently wield." Catra furrows her eyebrows as she stops, staring at Light Hope. "You can not afford to lose control."

"So what am I supposed to do? Just turn off all my feelings? Pretend like nothing ever bothers me?" Light Hope doesn't answer. Catra bites her tongue for a moment. "Mara opened the portal and brought Etheria to this place. Fine. *Why*? She thought she was doing some right, no matter how faulty her logic was. What did she think she was saving the universe from?"

Light Hope is quiet for long enough that Catra was starting to think she wouldn't answer. "Mara believed the power of She-Ra was too strong for the universe. That one person alone could not control it, with or without the mask."

Catra narrows her eyes slightly. "So she stranded us in an empty universe to protect the rest of the larger universe from what the First Ones and the magicats created?"

"Precisely. As I said, faulty logic."

Catra isn't entirely sure she disagrees with Mara, but she sets that aside for later. "What do you know about her? And I know you know *something*. She mentioned you specifically."

Light Hope's expression remains impassive even as her face and body distort slightly, glitching. Catra takes a step back, yelping. "Mara was the She-Ra before you. Mara was—" Another glitch. "Mara—" Glitch. "Mara—"

Catra watches in horror. There is something *way* more fucked up around here that she doesn't have time for. Not right then. "Never mind," she says quickly. "I don't want to talk about her."

If it were possible for AI's to relax, Light Hope probably would have done so. Her form returns to normal, body no longer glitching. Catra takes another step back, mind rewinding to something else Light Hope had said. "You're saying if I'm too emotional, I'm going to end up like that as well?"

"It is a possibility, yes. Living beings are fallible, after all. All you can do is learn to control yourself."

"*You gave Hordak the sword!*"

She had. She couldn't run away from that. And worst yet, she had *wanted* to—wanted to give the hellish responsibility to someone else.

And look how that ended up.

She's already made her mistakes. She can't afford any more. As much as she's not sure she trusts Light Hope, the AI is right about one thing—emotions are always her downfall. From acting up to lashing out to blaming everyone else for the things she did.

"So, what, do you think you can teach me to *control* myself?"

"It is a possibility," Light Hope says slowly. "If you are willing to commit to it. I have told you from the beginning that you must be single-minded, focused. You've consistently allowed yourself to be distracted by outside forces."

Catra grits her teeth, clenching her fists. *You gave Hordak the sword*. She had been *distracted* by her own feelings, by Adora, by Shadow Weaver, by...everything. Would it be better for her to stay here? Away from the world? From everyone?

She shakes off the thought. *No*. Even she knows that kind of isolation is stupidly bad.

"Right," she says quietly, stepping away. "Thanks for the answers. Great pep talk. Let's do this again some time."

She's allowed to leave with no interruptions.

The plan is to go back to the castle—it really is. Catra has no desire to run away or spend any more time in these woods than is absolutely necessary. Besides, it's late, and while she knows she can take care of herself, she doesn't particularly feel like fighting.

And yet, when she stumbles into a clearing and sees the tattered cloth covering the cave entrance, she's not surprised.

"Razz?" she calls wearily. The curtain is swiped aside as the old lady strolls out, sweeping the ground like there's some chance of cleaning it. She lights up when she sees Catra.

"Ah, Mara!"

Of fucking course. "I'm not Mara," she grits out. "I'm Catra. I'm the one who wrecked the world in a completely different way, remember?"

"Psh!" Catra swears Razz just scoffed at her. Did this old lady *scoff* at her? Has Razz been spending too much time with her? "You didn't wreck the world, and neither did Mara."

"Really?" Catra scoffs right back. "It looked pretty broken to me."

"You were led astray by outside forces," Razz says wisely. "The same forces tried to lead Mara."

Catra stares at Razz for a long moment before collapsing to the ground, leaning against a tree trunk. "Did she make a mistake by bringing Etheria here?"

"It depends on who you ask. The victors tell the story."

"I know, I *know.*" Catra groans, hiding her face in her hands. "History is written by the assholes who didn't go into hiding for possibly noble or possibly selfish reasons."

How is it she's done so much, and she *still* doesn't have any answers? Knowing more about the magicats has somehow just confused her more. *She* had opened a portal, and it had just made things worse. How had Mara opened a portal and not fucked everything up?

"*If you open a portal, death and destruction will follow.*"

Maybe Mara had known what would happen. Maybe she hadn't been as irrational and stupid and *led astray by emotions* as Catra clearly had been. Maybe Light Hope has a point about her just staying in the Crystal Palace. If nothing else, the rest of the world will be safe from her.

A broom comes down on Catra's head, snapping her out of her reverie. "Hey!" she grumbled, knocking the broom away. "Can you not be a weird old lady for a minute? I'm trying to think."

Razz waves the broom at Catra. "You're thinking too much. You always have."

"I always —seriously , lady, I'm not Mara"—

"No, you're Catra!" Razz huffs, hitting her with the broom again. That's starting to get old. "And you always overthink! What are you doing out here alone, anyway? You never do well alone."

"How. How do you know that?" Catra stutters in disbelief. "You know what, never mind. It doesn't matter." She's weirdly gotten used to Razz acting like they had known each other for years. Maybe they had, in her mind. Catra is starting to wonder if time actually applies to Razz.

She curls her legs up to her chest, letting out a long sigh. "Nothing is going to fix this," she says after a moment. "Nothing can undo the damage I did."

"Then maybe you should be less worried about fixing things and more focused on the future." It's the clearest, possibly wisest thing Catra has ever heard Razz say. "Now get your basket, dearie. We're going berry picking."

Catra looks up at her, blinking a few times, then stands. "Rain check on the berries. I think I need to get back before anyone realizes I'm gone."

She can only imagine what kind of reaction they'd all have to her disappearing. "Travel safe, dearie," Razz sings after her as she starts off into the woods again. She's tired when she finally climbs back into her room, dropping onto the bed and staring at the ceiling.

Be less worried about fixing things and more focused on the future.

Fixing things .

"Fuck, when did I turn into Adora?" she groans, covering her eyes with one hand. Okay, new plan. Get some sleep. Clean up in the morning. Get out of her damn room.

The world still needs She-Ra, after all. It doesn't have time to wait for Catra to get her shit together.

"Elberon's been recovering well, they benefit from some assistance, though"—

Spinnerella stops as the war room door opens, and everyone turns to see Catra slinking inside. She doesn't look at any of them as she takes her seat next to Bow, arms resting on the table. Angella looks at her for a moment, then back at Spinnerella.

"I'm sure we can arrange for some aid to be sent to Elberon, if you can get an idea of what they need."

"Oh." Spinnerella shook her head, refocusing on Angella, recognizing the not-so-subtle attempt to draw the focus back to the meeting and off Catra. "Right, yeah, of course. We can swing back through."

"An excuse to go to Elberon?" Netossa chuckles. "Hell yeah. The food there is great."

Bow and Glimmer carefully examine Catra the best they can without looking. She's traded her old outfit for a pair of black leggings and dark red shorts, with a matching shirt. The top third is black, and there's a whole sleeve covering her right arm, along with a glove on her left hand. Possibly the most alarming part of it all is her hair, which has been completely smoothed back, not a strand out of place, gray tuffs cut away. She looks so different. So much older. So much *sadder*. It hurts.

Frosta is talking about scouting missions in the North. They quickly refocus to make sure they're not about to be sent back there.

The meeting continues for another hour. Catra doesnt speak, and no one tries to make her. She continues staring at the table when they adjourn, lost in thought.

"Glimmer?"

It's odd how hearing her own name sounds weird. Glimmer stops to look at Catra as everyone else leaves, then exchanges a look with Bow and nods. He steps out, giving them the room. Catra stands, fidgeting as she leans against the table, before finally looking up.

"I'm sorry about what I said. None of this is your fault."

The apology is sincere, but it takes Glimmer a moment to get over how quiet Catra seems. Muted. Like someone drained the life out of her. "It's okay," she assures her with a small smile. "I know you're dealing with a lot. Just please dont push us away. Okay? We're here for you, whatever you need."

Catra nods slowly, the ghost of a smile on her lips. She had felt bad for snapping at Glimmer, she really had. She knows she cant take her temper out on other people. She's responsible for her own actions. Trying to shirk that is what got her here in the first place. "I know. Thanks."

Glimmer closes the space between them, hugging Catra tight. She groans. "You people and your hugs"…

She still returns it.

Chapter End Notes

> Remember - Reviews are like bells. Every time a reader gets one, they get more motivation to write

P ocessing

Chapter Summary

"W e're doing what now?"

"Going to Mystacor!"

Catra, as predicted, is less than thrilled about this development. "Okay , Ill bite. *Why* are we going to Mystacor?"

"W ell, *I'm* going because Aunt Casta is the best teacher for learning more about magic. *You're* going because we do everything together."

"Y ou can have a real Mystacor experience!" Bow squeals, delighted. "Ooooh, the hot springs! Y oull love the hot springs, they're great, it' s like, like being wrapped up in a super warm blanket"—

"Except it' s *wet*. What part of me screams I love water 'to you?"

"It'll be fun," Glimmer insists. "Pleeeeeeeease?"

She's been learning the puppy eyes from Bow. It's not fair. Catra sighs. "*Fine* . Just for like, a day though. I mean, you can stay as long as you want, but Im coming back to Bright Moon."

It's the best they can ask for, Glimmer supposes. Theyll work on getting Catra to relax more when they get there.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Catra, can we slow down?" Bow huf fs, doubling over to rest his hands on his knees.

"What?" Catra scoffs. "Are you tired already?"

"We've been doing this for like three hours."

Catra's been absolutely relentless about training since coming out of her mourning hibernation. Juliet had to tell her to lay off the guards after she ran an entire group into the ground. Now it's Bow's turn.

"Come on, you haven't taken a break all day. Did you even breakfast?"

"I don't need you to fuss," Catra grumbles, stepping away from Bow before he can rest a hand her shoulder. "If you're not going to help, just leave me alone."

"But"—

Glimmer watches from a balcony as Catra walks away from Bow. She's been different since the portal. They know *why*. They just don't know how to help. And it hurts to see her suffering.

"Glimmer?" Angella approaches from behind, gently calling her daughter's name. Glimmer turns to look at her, smiling slightly. "What're you doing?"

"Watching Catra and Bow." She turns back to see Catra tackling bots on her now. "Or just Catra, I guess."

Angella joins her at the railing, humming noncommittally when she sees Catra working by herself. Glimmer ventures to break the silence after a moment.

"Mom?"

"Yes, dear?"

"I want to learn more about magic. *Real* magic. I know I can be stronger than I am with just the Moonstone, and we *need* stronger

fighters."Her voice borders on pleading. " *I* need to be stronger. Im the weakest person in the alliance right now."

"That' s not true,"Angella admonishes her with a frown.

"Y es it is! Perfuma holds back, but she could literally destroy the planet from the inside out. Frosta could start an ice age. Mermista could flood the planet"—

"What youre saying is that we should be afraid of them,"Angella says dryly.

"No. W ell, yes. But it's not just them. Bow is smart and knows how to fight without magic, and Catra is basically a goddess. And I"… Glimmer sighs, looking at her hands. "I can barely teleport to another kingdom. If..If. Shadow W eaver hadnt helped us, if I couldve gotten us to the Fright Zone without her , maybe things wouldve been different. Maybe they wouldnt have opened the portal."

Maybe Adora would still be alive, and Catra would be okay .

Angella looks Glimmer over uncertainly. "I suppose it wouldnt hurt for you to know a bit more about your magical side. Im sure Castaspella would be thrilled to help."

Glimmer lights up. "Really?"

"I can send a summons for her , if youd like."

Glimmer looks back at the training grounds, considering it for a moment. "I think Id rather go there."

A small, amused smile pulls at Angella's lips. "I suppose Catra and Bow will be accompanying you as well."She knows exactly what Glimmer is thinking.

"If you dont mind sparing them for a couple days."

"Of course not. Im sure theyll be happy for the break."

"We're doing what now?"

"Going to Mystacor!"

Catra, as predicted, is less than thrilled about this development. "Okay , Ill bite. *Why* are we going to Mystacor?"

"Well, *I'm* going because Aunt Casta is the best teacher for learning more about magic. *You're* going because we do everything together."

"You can have a real Mystacor experience!" Bow squeals, delighted. "Ooooh, the hot springs! Youll love the hot springs, they're great, it's like, like being wrapped up in a super warm blanket"—

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It's the best they can ask for, Glimmer supposes. Theyll work on getting Catra to relax more when they get there.

Entrapta peeks into Hordak's lab, her hair flitting about. He hasnt really said much since the portal. Just.been angry . A lot.

"Hordak?"

He's standing at a table, looking over the broken bits of what had been the portal. Entrapta droops slightly when she sees that. *If I'd had more time to test*…

She still doesnt understand why Catra and Adora pulled the lever . Maybe she never will. She's learned that not *everything* is as logical as she'd like it to be.

"Scorpia—Force Captain Scorpia, that is—is kiiiiiiiiiiind of wondering if youll—I mean, with Adora gone there isnt really anyone else in charge—"

Hordak slams his hands on the table. Entrapta blinks, tips of her hair tapping together. "Not. Now ." He speaks through gritted teeth. A small frown pulls at Entrapta's lips. She hits the button on her recorder and starts speaking.

"Log eighty-six post-portal. Hordak continues to be unresponsive and leaving his duties as leader to someone less than adequate, which may be offensive to anyone else, but I believe Scorpia would agree with me—"

"Entrapta!"

Right, people dont like it when she talks about them in front of them. "I'm *right*, though," she points out, jabbing a strand of hair in his direction to emphasize the words. He doesnt answer . "Did your signal to get through?"

"Y es," he admits after a moment.

"Then it still worked, even if there were a few anomalies," Entrapta says brightly, trying not to remember that one of the anomalies had resulted in her friend's death. "All you have to do is wait."

Hordak looks up, contemplative. "W ait," he repeats slowly . "Entrapta, will you tell Force Captain Scorpia Id like to meet with her when you see her again?"

"Sure!" Entrapta pauses before tilting her head slightly . She knows she just caused *something*, but she cant quite put her finger on what. It bothers her more than it usually would. "What're you gonna do?"

"Continue with the original plan, and take this planet in Horde Prime's name."

Oh. That's what she's caused. Oops.

Catra stays back as Castaspella wraps Glimmer and Bow in an excited, exuberant hug. Nope, she's having nothing to do with that, she definitely does not need—

"What are you doing hiding back there? Come here!"

And then Casta is grabbing her as well, hugging her tight. Catra groans. Glimmer and Bow look thrilled. Isn't this supposed to be *relaxing*?

"Bow wants to show Catra how a *real* Mystacor experience is supposed to go," Glimmer explains to her aunt. "Instead of her own experience of being brought here unconscious and sleeping for two days."

"Oh, that sounds like fun! Are you going to try the hot springs?"

Catra raises an eyebrow. "Cat. In water. How does that sound at all fun?"

"It's a completely different experience when it's warm water," Casta assures her. "Give it a try."

Bow grins, wrapping an arm around Catra's shoulders. "It'll be great," he says. Catra glares at him, very much doubting it.

"*Fine*. Let's go."

They don't *start* with the hot springs, thankfully. Bow gets a couple blankets and leads Catra out to the beach. Gentle waves break against the sandy shore, creating what's *probably* a relaxing atmosphere for most people. But Catra is tense, ears twitching, jaw clenched. She doesn't want to *be* here. There's still a war going on, pathetic as it may be *now*, considering Hordak has apparently given

up in the absence of anyone to actually lead. And they expect her to lie on a beach and stare at the sky? Or *sleep*?

"First of all." Bow gently plucks the mask from Catra's head.

"Hey!"—

"And where's the sword?"

"You've *got* to be kidding me."

Bow raises an eyebrow, looking her up and down. He's not kidding. Fine. She retrieves the charm from a hidden pocket and turns it over. Bow smiles, satisfied. "Good. Now take a blanket and get comfortable."

"Bow, seriously"—

"Seriously. You've been working yourself into the ground, and it's not going to do any good if you just end up collapsing from exhaustion or something." He gently shoves a blanket into her arms. "At least try."

She sighs. "Fine. *Fine*."

They spread their blankets out next to each other, settling down. Bow falls asleep almost immediately. Must be nice, Catra thinks, rolling onto her side to face away from him. The rolling waves are a nice sound to concentrate on. Maybe it's like meditating. Perfuma had done her best with a less than stellar student, and Catra could more or less turn her mind off when she wanted to. Sometimes.

She takes a deep breath and tries that now, closing her eyes, focusing on the waves and trying to choose one thing to think about out of her racing mind.

The portal. Of course it's the portal. What else is there to consume her every waking moment and drown her guilt until she couldnt breathe?

She and Adora had been engaged? That's so weird to think about. It's not like—nope, not going down that track. Catra had been a *princess*. She shudders at the thought. She definitely does *not* want to be a princess. She just wants things to be easier. Maybe the portal had latched on to that desire and created a world where she could live the easiest life—a princess during a time of peace with a fiancee, two loving mothers, and a kingdom which absolutely adored her.

C'yra.

The name bounces around in her head. She's seen and heard it so many times now, between the portal world, reading it on those bits of letters at the library, Razz mentioning she had met the Magicat queen…

Maybe Angella would know. Maybe it's like… a name that gets passed down. Like a title. Is that a thing? How do I know absolutely nothing about royalty after living in a castle for like two years?

She's starting to get off track. Deep breath. Focus again. The portal. Adora. Adora's arms around her as they kneel together in the light, waiting to be consumed just like the rest of the world. Her hand clinging to Catra's blackened, corrupted fingers.

"*You and me, together at the end of the world. Right?*"

That's what they had always promised each other. They would rise through the ranks of the Horde together, to a position where Shadow Weaver would no longer have any power over them, and they would be strong enough to unseat Hordak. Then *they* would be in charge, together. They'd fight together. They'd overcome *anything* together.

Except stupidity. Can't fix that together when one of you is drowning in a fucking savior complex.

Adora and her stupid savior complex. It's all Shadow Weaver's fault. Right from the start, she had made it clear that Adora's choices

would effect Catra's life. Or possibly end it. Adora had to be perfect, or it would all come down on Catra's head.

No fucking wonder she thought she had to save me from the Rebellion, Catra thinks bitterly. *And she's done her entire life is save me from Shadow Weaver's fucked up power games*.

The worst part is, Catra isn't sure if Adora succeeded or failed in that. Had Catra ever really been *saved* from that bullshit? Or had she just run away from it, hidden behind the protection of Bright Moon and She-Ra, pretending Shadow Weaver didn't matter anymore and she couldn't hurt Catra again?

Catra sits up abruptly, growling slightly. Bow is still heavily asleep. Screw this. She stands, making her way back to the castle, walking silently through the empty halls. She doesn't really think about where she's going, but at the same time, she's not surprised when she ends up in front of Light Spinner's statue. She glares up at the passive face, fingers curling into a fist.

"You never get punished for the things you do, huh? Not really, anyway. You fucked up here, so you ran away to the Fright Zone and got Hordak to give you power so you could torture two kids for their entire lives. And when that fell through, you just slinked into Bright Moon like you owned the place and talked me into healing you before you told me you murdered every single magicat on Etheria. And now you get to say you helped *save the world* because Glimmer needed you to help her teleport to the Fright Zone. It must be real fucking nice to never face the consequences of your bullshit, huh?"

She doesn't *answer*, of course. It's not like Catra is expecting that. But somehow, it still makes her angry. "And even if someone *did* confront you, you don't even care. You're completely heartless. You've never cared about anything but yourself, and you still don't. Adora's *dead*, and you get to fucking live, and it's not *fair*!"

She kicks the statue. And regrets it when at least three of her toes definitely break. She doesn't scream, at least, but she *does* stagger

back and collapse again the wall, cradling her foot and trying keep down the pained tears filling her eyes. Oh fuck, fuck, fuck, fuck, fuck, fuck—

"Um"…

Catra's head snaps up to see a young woman with pale skin and chestnut hair standing at the end of the hall, watching her with some concern. She was healer. Catra vaguely recognized her from her last checkup after Shadow Weaver had tortured her.

"Are you okay?" she asks, tilting her head.

"Yeah," Catra grunts, leaning against the wall, still holding her foot. "Sorry, it's…Meg, right?" She nods, smiling. "Yeah, I'm fine. Sorry about…whatever you saw…"

"There's nothing to apologize for," Meg assures her. "Is there anything I can do for you?"

Turn back time? Stop me from pulling the lever? Stop Shadow Weaver from slaughtering an entire kingdom? Stop me from ever finding the sword in the first place?

"No." Catra's voice is quiet, eyes locked on the statue. "There's nothing anyone can really do."

Silence falls for a moment, but she doesn't hear Meg walk away, and she can feel the gaze still locked on her. "I'm sorry if it's a bother," Meg finally says, "but can you come with me for a moment?"

Catra doesn't have the strength to argue. Instead she nods and stands, stretching for a moment before walking toward Meg, trying not to limp too much. She misses the weight of the mask on her head. She should have taken it when she left Bow.

The Healer smiles when she sees that Catra is cooperating, and turns to start down the hall, assured that Catra will follow her.

"Scorpia?"

Scorpia looks up from the paperwork, sighing when she sees Entrapta looking at her, almost contrite, the tips of her hair poking together. "I...may have made a mistake," she says slowly. Scorpia frowns. That's not something Entrapta admits lightly.

"What happened?"

"Well, I went to talk to Hordak again, and he wants to push forward with the war and take over Etheria before Horde Prime gets here." Entrapta rushes out the words. It takes Scorpia a moment to catch up.

"He wants to fight the Rebellion again?" Entrapta nods. "Oh. Okay. Well that's that's uh...does he have any idea how to *do* that?"

As far as anyone can tell, Shadow Weaver, and then Adora, were the ones who really ran the Horde, while Hordak hid away in his lab and presumably working on his portal. Does he actually know how to lead?

"I'm sure he'll think of something." Entrapta doesn't sound overly enthused about the idea, however. Scorpia notices this.

"Entrapta? Do you want to keep fighting this war?"

Entrapta's shoulders slump; she sighs. "I never wanted to fight," she admits. "I just followed the science. But after what happened with the portal"…

Scorpia nods as Entrapta's voice trails off. She's not a soldier. She's gone along with this for so long, knowing there was no way out, not really. She was born into this. But she's not sure she can do this for much longer.

"Hordak wants to see you, when you have a minute," Entrapta says after a moment of silence. Scorpia nods slowly, rubbing the back her neck.

"Right. Ill talk to him in a bit. Thanks, Entrapta."

Catra looks around warily as Meg leads her into a small room. The smell of incense is instantly overwhelming, making her nose twitch. Why did she think following this woman was a good idea?

Better than sitting around waiting for Bow to find you and nag you about being bad at relaxing.

Right.

She looks around the room, tilting her head. The walls are made of some kind of jagged crystal, with bits sticking out of the wall The lighting is dim, a mirror on one wall barely visible. It's warm, but comfortable, like sitting in the sun.

"What is this?" she asks slowly , turning to look at Meg.

"It's a meditation chamber. We have several for different types of ailments."

Catra raises an eyebrow. "Ailments? Like what?"

"Illnesses, mental and physical damages." Meg pauses, hand brushing against the jagged wall. "The crystals are meant to encourage healing. It's not a cure-all, mind you. Meditation is just one part of treatment." She looks back at Catra. "Castaspella told you about magical abuse leaving scars, right?"

"Yeah," Catra says slowly . "She said it was treatable, but…"

"But you didnt want to. That's understandable. Trusting magic after it's hurt you so much isnt easy ."

"That's what this place is for, isn't it?" Catra's tail is stiff. "Healing magical damage."

"Yes and no," Meg says calmly. "This particular one is for mental ailments, but there can be a lot of crossover between mental and magical damage." She sits, gesturing for Catra to join her. Catra hesitates before slowly sitting so she's facing Meg. "Have you ever meditated before?"

"Um...kind of. Not anything magical, though."

"Would you be willing to indulge me, then?"

Catra shrugs, and nods. Why not? At least she can say she was trying to do something relaxing. Meg smiles gently. "Close your eyes and think."

"About what?"

"Whatever you want."

Well, that's helpful. Catra sighs and does as she's told. Her mind, of course, goes to Adora. Brave, sweet, *stupid* Adora. Adora the favorite, Adora abused in ways Catra can't imagine, because Shadow Weaver's abuse of *her* had always been straight forward and obvious. Adora holding her. Promising.

"*Nothing really bad can happen as long as we stick together*."

But they hadn't. Catra had left, driven away by the fear of what Shadow Weaver would do to her if she found out about any of this She-Ra stuff. Fear which had turned into a begrudging acceptance that she was meant to play the hero, no matter how impossible it seemed. And begrudging acceptance had turned into true caring for Glimmer and Bow, for Angella, hell, for *all* the princesses.

And then Shadow Weaver had come along to ruin *that* as well.

"Catra?"

The gentle call of her name brings her back to reality. She opens her eyes, frowning when she realizes it's brighter in the room – then yelping in surprise when she sees her own reflection in the mirror. There's a golden light around her, surrounding her figure like a bubble. But it keeps glitching, spaces turning red or temporarily disappearing.

"It's okay," Meg says quickly as Catra backs against the opposite wall, curling in on herself. "It's your aura. Did Castaspella tell you about this?"

The words trigger something in the very back her memory.

"*Everyone has an aura of some kind. Prolonged magical abuse causes permanent damage to that aura.*"

"Yeah," Catra says after a moment, letting out a long breath. "Yeah, she did. I've never really seen it though. Why is it so bright?"

"It's reflective of your inner self." That doesn't answer anything. By all rights, it should probably be black. A She-Ra thing, Catra supposes. "Do you see the glitches and marks?"

Catra nods. "Magical scars?" she guesses quietly.

"Yes. This type of disruption your aura often has an affect on your mental state as well. As I said, crossover between mental and magical damage."

"Can. Can you fix it?" Catra asks after a moment. She reaches up as if to touch the aura, but her hand goes straight through one of the red areas. A shock runs through her fingers.

Crimson energy flares to life around Shadow Weaver's hand; the current of electricity bolts through Catra, and she yells, momentarily seizing, straining against the bindings…

Catra immediately pulls her hand back, trembling. The pain is already a fading memory. "Some of it is still treatable," Meg says softly. "But there are parts that are likely permanent. Not all scars can be erased."

Of course. Catra lowers her forehead to rest on her knees, laughing humorlessly. "So that's it then, huh? There's really nothing left Shadow Weaver can take from me."

Adora, the safety of Bright Moon, her own fucking sanity, nothing is safe from the sorceress. Nothing has *ever* been safe. Catra grew up with that knowledge and internalized it. She's sure it's the only reason she survived for so long. Nothing is ever safe from Shadow Weaver.

"Even if it can't be fixed, you can still take it back," Meg assures her. "You have more control over this than you think. But it takes time."

"I don't have *time*. I'm supposed to be Etheria's great hero or… whatever." *Some hero*.

"You need to take care of yourself before you try and take care of anyone else."

The words surprise Catra enough that she looks up, meeting Meg's gaze. There's a quiet determination in her eyes – the look of every single person who thinks they're right and won't back down. The glow fades away, leaving Catra in the shadows, staring at herself in the mirror.

"Trauma is hard to process, and without help it can be impossible. But you don't have to do it alone."

Catra stares at her reflection for a moment, then turns back to look at Meg. And she nods.

"Okay."

Castaspella and Glimmer are settling in for dinner when Bow finds them, chewing his thumbnail. "Hey ," Glimmer says, yawning. Aunt Casta really ran her through hoops to learn simple things. "What' s up?"

"Oh, nothing!" His voice cracks. "I just, um. I... lost Catra."

"Y ou did *what*!?" Glimmer 's chair screeches against the floor as she jumps up. Castaspella looks at Bow , alarmed.

"What do you mean you *lost her*?

"W e were on the beach, and I fell asleep, and when I woke up she was gone." Bow' s voice is frantic, several pitches higher than usual. "I swear I've looked all over but I can't"—

"Can't what, get through puberty?"

Bow freezes, then slowly turns to see Catra in the door, accompanied by one of the Mystacor healers. "Seriously , even Kyle' s voice never cracked that bad." There' s a faint smirk on the magicat's lips as she walks by Bow, clapping a hand on his shoulder, then goes to sit and help herself to some food. Castaspella looks at her curiously, then at the healer, who smiles in return.

They had talked a lot about Catra after her first visit to Mystacor — she had outright rejected the thought of magical help, and no one could really blame her for that. But there were other, slower ways to help her.

Meg must have found something that works, Castaspella thinks fondly. She's young, but always a step ahead.

"Are you okay?" Glimmer asks Catra. She snatches a bread roll and takes a bite, shrugging.

"Right as rain, Sparkles. How'd magic training go? Y ou blow anything up?"

Glimmer huffs, rolling her eyes. "I dont know why I worry about you."

"Honestly , neither do I."

Bow sits beside Glimmer, feeling just a bit lightheaded. He had spent *hours* running around the palace, desperately trying to find Catra, terrified she had run off without anyone realizing. And she's just been with a healer the entire time, apparently. Doing *what*? And she hasnt even asked about her sword or mask.

They have no idea what's happened, but theyll take it.

Chapter End Notes

> Don't worry, this is far from the end of Catra's mental breakdown. There's plenty to come.
>
> Reviews are high in nutrition and a reqired part of a writer's diet.

Interlude I

Chapter Summary

Something is a little different

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Adora!"

Her eyes snap open, fist swinging out, hitting air. "Watch it!" A familiar voice laughs. Adora turns to see Catra next to her, grinning. Catra? "You were sleep fighting again. Im surprised you havent punched me yet."

"How"…

Adora looks around, blinking rapidly. Her head is spinning, ears ringing slightly. "Where are we"?

Catra tilts her head, raising an eyebrow. "Home" she said slowly. "Are you okay"?

"Yeah, Im..Im fine."

Home. Half Moon. Adora sits up, scanning the room. Catra's room. *Their* room. Catra is kneeling beside her, watching her uncertainly. "Are you *sure* youre okay" she presses gently, voice low.

"Yes," Adora says with a little bit more effort. "I just..had a weird dream. Threw me off a bit."

Catra's concern turns to a small smile. She leans in, softly kissing Adora;she pushes her back on the bed, settling on her chest as they

gently reacqaint themselves with this reality . "Better?" she eventually asked, split gaze meeting Adora's bright blue eyes.

"Hmmmm. I dunno. Maybe need a little bit more help with grounding"…

"Ugh." Catra groans, grabbing a pillow and shoving it in Adora' s face. Adora laughs, pushing back and tackling Catra. "Hey , get off me you crazy woman!"

"Mmmm, nope." Adora nuzzles her cheek against Catra' s, settling in and taking a deep breath, prepared to spend the entire day snuggling. "This is comfy . You're so soft."

"Y ou're the worst," Catra grumbles, trying to push Adora of f with almost no actual effort. She's perfectly happy to let Adora snuggle her for as long as it takes for her to settle back in from her weird dream. If that happens to be all day, well then.who is she to argue?

There's a knock at the door. "Girls?" L yra calls, peeking into the room. Adora looks up, and Catra tilts her head back to look at her mother. Lyra chuckles when she sees them. "I hope I'm not interrupting."

"Will you leave if you are?" Catra asks flatly . Adora swats her shoulder, shushing her. Lyra knows better than to take her daughter seriously.

"It' s getting a bit late. The other princesses will be here soon."

"Uuuuuuuuuuuugh," Catra groans again. "Is that today?"

"Y es, it is," L yra says, ignoring Catra's attitude Adora snickers, rolling to lie back down so Catra can get ready. "Don't get comfortable, Adora. You're required to attend as well."

"What?" Adora balks, sitting back up. "Why?"

"The downside of marrying a princess."

It's Catra's turn to laugh at her wife's distress. "Come on, *Princess*," she teases, throwing a pillow at Adora. "Time to get up and join the princess meeting."

"*You're* a princess."

"And so are you now." Catra sticks her tongue out at Adora. "Move it."

Lyra shakes her head, smiling, and leaves the girls to get ready. Adora sighs as she rolls out of bed. At least she doesn't have to wear robes or anything overly formal — *yet*. Catra looks good in all that, but Adora is sure she'll look like a completely moron, and she isn't ready for that.

Catra watches her get dressed, pulling on her new jacket (dark red, matching Catra's robes) and fixing the little pin on the lapel (a smaller version of Catra's mask — the symbol of Half Moon). "What's it gonna take to get you halfway presentable again?" Catra asks. "You looked pretty good at wedding."

"Oh. shut up," Adora grumbles, blushing and focusing on her pin. She hadn't *felt* like she'd looked good, but everyone had complimented her multiple times. Catra, Glimmer, and Bow didn't count, but they were far from the only ones.

Catra gently pushes her back against the wall and steps right into her personal space, pressing another kiss to her lips. "We need to work on your self esteem," she teases with a small smile, resting their foreheads together. "I dunno how you can look at yourself in the mirror and not see what I do."

"You're biased," Adora replies, pouting.

"Maybe," Catra allows. "But have I ever lied to you? Remember when you tried bangs?"

Adora bites her tongue to keep from laughing. Yes, the bangs had been *awful*, and Catra had *not* kept her opinion to herself. She had taken one look at them and stormed into the Bright Moon throne room to ask Angella why she would allow Adora to do something so horrible to herself.

"I just," Adora cups Catra's face, sighing. "Nothing ever feels *right* on me."

"To be fair, you've only worn like three different shirts your entire life." It's true, even if Adora thinks Catra *could* be nicer about it. "Maybe you should spend some time trying to explore fashion and figure out what you like instead of wearing what everyone else says looks good on you."

"Maybe," Adora mutters. "It just feels like a waste of time."

"It's not a waste of time to find something you feel *comfortable* in, stupid." Catra slaps her shoulder slightly. "Stop acting like your existence is some big inconvenience. We're stuck together now, and I want you to be happy. And you *know* my mothers would be happy to see you change your wardrobe around a little."

They would, Adora thinks with a small smile. She knows Cyra and Lyra love her. But she also knows they die a little when they see her wearing the same three jackets every single day.

"Okay."

Catra grins. "Great, we can—"

"Of *course* you two are busy making out," an exasperated voice says behind them. "Come on already."

And then they're in the dining hall. Catra is leaning on Adora's shoulder, groaning. "Found them!" Glimmer announces, shoving them into a pair of nearby arms. They both yelp as Scorpia scoops them up.

“Hi guys!”

They’re quickly piled on by Perfuma, Spinnerella, and Netossa. Mermista is rolling her eyes, saying, “Yeah, yeah, this is all *wholesome* or whatever,” while Frosta is asking when breakfast will be ready.

“Was that necessary?” Catra groans, twisting to look at Glimmer, who’s watching with her arms crossed, lips pulled into a satisfied smirk.

“Absolutely. And it was *fun*.”

Adora laughs as Scorpia finally sets them down; she takes Catra’s hand, squeezing and smiling gently. There’ll be plenty of time to talk later.

There will be plenty of time for everything.

Chapter End Notes

A few things before you click that comment button:

1) Yes this is the chapter
2) No, there will not be another update this week to make up for the shortness of it
3) This was intentionally short to give you a peek into what Adora is dealing with - or not dealing with, since she gets to continue their perfect life, but same difference.
4) I am really, really, really not in the mood for complaints about how short this is. So please just... don't?

Power and Control

Chapter Summary

"So, what, are you just going to beat the emotions out of me?"

"Learning to control yourself is a strenuous process," Light Hope says simply. "You must take time."

Why does it feel like these conversations always go in circles? "You're the one who told me I need to learn!" she says impatiently, grip on the sword tightening.

"I've also told you several times that you can not afford to waste time with others." Stupid, overly logical AI. "If you were to simply stay"—

"I already told you, *no*," Catra shoots back. "I need better company than this."

"Then you must live with what I can teach you in the time you are here."

She's being *snarky*. Catra kicks at the air, looking around. "*Fine*. Just give me more bots to fight."

It's not perfect, by any means. But it's an outlet for the unending energy. The twitchiness. It's an outlet for the *anger*. Sitting around and meditating isn't doing any good. She's not sure if this is, either. But she can *move*, and that's something. That's better.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Would anyone else remember Adora?

The thought consumes Catra as she curls up into herself, staring at the large mural of King Micah. He had been a hero, he had been royalty, of course he would get this huge thing dedicated to him. Adora had been part of the Horde. A Force Captain. Someone who led raids on villages and tried to help (albeit accidentally) erase She-Ra from Catra's mind. There are no memorials to honor fallen soldiers in the Fright Zone. No one outside of the Princess Alliance knows what Adora did. And they don't owe her anything after what happened.

She'll never have a memorial like this. But she'll always have a home in part of Catra's mind.

"Catra?"

Angella is there. Catra looks up, meeting her gaze. The queen looks tired. Older, somehow. As if the last few months of have aged her several years. Catra can relate.

"Hi, Angella." She tries to smile, but it's weak. "Sorry, I can go if I'm in the way or anything…"

Angella laughs softly. "Sometimes I feel like you get more comfort out of coming here than I do," she says as she joins Catra on the bench, looking up at her late husband. "Micah was always good at making people feel better, though."

"It's a nice place to come and think." Catra follows Angella's gaze. "The company seems pretty all right, too."

"I do believe that's a compliment, coming from you." Catra smiles humorlessly. "What are we thinking about tonight, then?"

"I don't know. Nothing much." *Too much*. Her brain can't decide what to settle on. It's making her antsy.

"The portal," Angella guesses. She's eerily good at that kind of thing.

"I guess, yeah. You. You remember it all too, right?" Bow and Glimmer didn't seem to, not that Catra had seen them there. She'd already been swallowed by the portal at that point.

"I do. Micah was there."

"Oh." Catra's ears fall slightly. "Shame I didn't get to meet him."

"It truly was a perfect world." Angella sighs. Catra leans back so her head is resting on the wall behind them.

"You. You said you'd met the queen and princess of Half Moon. Do you remember anything about them?"

Angella frowns faintly, thinking. "It was a long time ago. The queen's name was Cyra, that I remember for sure. She had a spouse I never met. I don't remember much at all about the princess – as I said, she was *very* young. Why do you ask?"

"In the portal world. I was the princess of Half Moon. And I was *engaged* to Adora, who worked for the Bright Moon guard. It was weird. Really, really weird." Catra closes her eyes. "I dunno if it was just... some kind of weird messed up illusion or if it was the world we *could* have lived in if one or two things had gone different, or"…

"You'll drive yourself half mad trying to figure it out," Angella says softly. "Trust me. I've spent a long time wondering *what if*."

"I can't just *not know*, though. It'll drive me crazy either way."

"You could spend the rest of your life chasing answers you'll never get."

She's right, and Catra knows it. But it's still frustrating. Even Shadow Weaver won't know much, if Catra really wanted to drag herself down and face the sorceress – which she *really* does not. But she wouldn't know anything about Half Moon beyond what she had

already told them. There was no one left alive who could tell Catra the truth.

"Do you ever feel like everything you do is just for nothing?" she asks quietly. "Like, not matter what, you're never going to change anything?"

"Yes," Angella admits. "I've felt that way quite often since Micah died."

"How do you still get out of bed in the morning?" Catra usually wakes up wishing for everything to go away so she can sleep forever. She's trying not to fall too far down that rabbit hole.

"I remember that I still have a lot to live for. I have a kingdom to protect, a war to win, people who depend on my ability to function. The Rebellion suffered for years because of my reluctance to actively engage in battle. *You* have suffered for it multiple times. I don't want that to happen again."

Catra shoulders fall as she leans forward to rest her forehead on her knees. "I'm so tired," she mumbles after a minute. Angella rests a hand on her back.

"I know. You've been through far too much that you didn't deserve. But there are still people who care about you. Try to remember that, and hold on to them."

Catra nods, still curled in on herself. People who care. People like Glimmer and Bow and Angella. And she's grateful to them, she really, truly is. She doesn't know where she'd be if she had stayed with the Horde.

But it doesn't help how much she misses Adora.

"Thaymor is under attack!"

Everyone looks up from the table, surprised, as a guard runs into the war room. "Are you *serious*?" Glimmer asks, groaning.

"Is it the Horde?" Catra asks. The guard nods. "So much for them being out of commission."

Glimmer rests a hand on Catra's shoulder, then Bow's, and in a shower of sparkles they appear in Thaymor. The place is already full of soldiers and tanks. "*Great*," Catra grumbles, producing the charm and transforming it back. "For the honor of Grayskull!"

It's a standard army, and Catra isn't too worried. She jumps, landing on the closest tank and driving her sword into it. The soldiers bail, and Catra gets away right before it explodes.

"Property damage!" Glimmer calls as she takes down a few soldiers.

"Yeah, yeah"…

One soldier aims their gun at Catra; she transforms the sword into a shield, deflecting the blast, then rushing forward and shield bashing the hapless soldier. Bow pins one soldier down with green goop. Useful, Catra thinks as she disarms another, then jumps to another tank and takes out the barrel with a swipe of her claws. Glimmer grabs two soldiers and teleports them away.

It's laughably easy, when all is said and done. The army quickly retreats, and Glimmer deals with the villagers while Bow and Catra tie up the captured soldier and dragging them out to the woods. Bow gets the honor of pulling off the soldier's helmet.

"Bonnie." Catra laughs. "Long time no see."

"Not long enough," Bonnie grumbles, glaring at her. "You still look fucking stupid."

"And you look like a hostage," Catra replies, changing back but keeping the sword slung over her shoulder. Just in case. "This was a

terrible attack. What happened?"

"Why should I tell you?"

"In honor of a lifelong friendship?" Bonnie scoffs in response. Catra grins back humorlessly. "How about because you're our prisoner and you don't have much of a choice?"

Glimmer appears beside Bow, tilting her head when she sees Bonnie. "How's it going?"

"I think they're reuniting."

Catra ignores them both. "Look, Bonnie, I'm not gonna lie, I don't particularly care what's going on. But if you guys are gonna be a pain in the ass, that's unfortunately my business. So just answer the questions and make it easy on both of us."

"Or what? You gonna take me to Shadow Weaver?"

Something dark flashes in Catra's eyes; Glimmer grabs her as she clenches her fist, fully prepared to haul off and punch Bonnie. "Trust me," she says through gritted teeth, "I don't need Shadow Weaver's help getting answers."

She hears a rustling in the trees and whirls just as two figures emerge from the tree line. Wilde and Rogelio. Of course. "Seriously," Catra mutters. "Do you three exist just to make my life miserable?"

They've both got guns pointed at her, although Wilde is shaking slightly. "Let her go." His voice is *almost* commanding. Almost. Catra laughs, transforming the sword into a shield.

"Or *what*? You're gonna fight me?"

Rogelio grunts; Catra rolls her eyes. "No, big guy, I am definitely not *scared* of you. Look, we'll let Bonnie go if you answer our questions. Easy deal, right?"

He lowers his gun slightly, conflicted. Rogelio makes a noise, nudging him. "I don't want to fight them," he mutters in return.

"Seriously?" Bonnie demands, groaning. She's ignored. Catra lowers the shield to her side, raising an eyebrow.

"We got a deal, then?" He nods once. "Good. It's been three months. Why the sudden attack?"

"We're not sure." Catra believes that. He's not a great liar. "Things have been kind of crazy every since the portal. Force Captain Scorpia was trying to keep everything under control, but she's not… great at that. Then out of nowhere, Lord Hordak came out and said we still have a war to win. Force captains started getting squads organizes, and our first mission was Thaymor to test the waters."

"Thaymor is way too easy of a target," Catra mutters to Glimmer. "We might want to do something about that." Louder, she says, "So Scorpia's running the show now?"

"I don't really… *know*. It seems more like Hordak is actually taking over." That's odd. He'd let Shadow Weaver, then Adora, run the show for years. Why the sudden change?

"We've taken back a *lot* of ground since the Horde went quiet," Bow reminds Catra quietly. "If they start targeting everything again"…

Then they're fucked. The Horde still has numbers on its side. Overwhelming attacks can make up for lack of competency, if necessary. Catra's jaw clenches for a moment. "Fine," she finally says, changing the shield to a dagger and dragging Bonnie up. She cuts the bindings and shoves her toward her squad mates. "Just get the fuck out of here."

Bonnie is scowling, but Rogelio grabs her shoulder, and the trio disappears into the woods once more. "So Hordak wants to make a grand comeback," Glimmer guesses, looking between Bow and Catra.

"He *did* start the war," Bow points out. "He had to do something before Shadow Weaver and Adora. Maybe he's taking over again because he doesn't have a choice."

"He spent a few months pouting over the portal being a massive failure, then decided to jump back into it," Catra summarizes darkly. "And now he wants a war again. Great. Fine. He wants a war, he'll get a fucking war."

Glimmer and Bow exchange uncertain looks. This is going to end poorly. "Maybe we shouldn't get ahead of ourselves," Bow says slowly.

"Maybe we should get back to Bright Moon and tell Angella what's going on," Catra counters. She's right, as much as they hate to admit it. Glimmer grabs both their arms and teleports them back to Bright Moon.

Everyone pretends they don't hear the yelling coming from Hordak's lab. It's not just one person being subjected his wrath, at least ~~—~~all the force captains are taking the brunt for the failed raid on Thaymor.

"That guy is *scary*," Scorpia says in a high-pitched voice as she walks into Entrapta's lab. The princess is sitting at her computer set up, typing rapidly. "Does he ever yell at you?"

"Sometimes," Entrapta says, shrugging. "It's not really *at* me, though. More like about general circumstances in my vicinity."

"I don't know what he's so angry about. It's just Thaymor. It's not like it's anything important."

"That might be why he's mad," Entrapta points out. "Thaymor is probably the weakest link ~~—~~if you're not capable of reclaiming that, then bigger ventures like a whole kingdom are far out of your reach."

"Ouch." She's not wrong, though. Scorpia sighs, sitting on the floor and cradling her head in her pincers. "I'm not sure what he wants us to *do*, though."

"Well, he wants you to help him conquer the planet so he can present it to his brother when he opens the portal to bring Etheria back to the larger universe."

"His.what?"

Oh, right. Scorpia doesn't know about that. "It's kind of a long story."

Scorpia blinks a few times, tilting her head. "Okay. So we're supposed to conquer the planet. But does he have a plan for that, or?.."

Entrapta shakes her head. "I didn't really ask." She's still pretty sure she did the wrong thing by talking him into continuing the war, albeit accidentally. She's accidentally encouraged a lot of bad things in the last year and a half.

"What're you doing?" Scorpia asks after a moment, shaking Entrapta out of her thoughts.

"Exploring some theories." Entrapta refocuses on the screens, frowning. She still has all the data from the portal. If she can figure out where they wrong…

She doesn't want this to get back to Hordak, though. The portal is a touchy topic, for good reason. This is best kept to herself for now.

Their next trip to Mystacor is a few days later. Usually, Casta comes to Bright Moon to train with Glimmer, but they've managed to talk Catra into doing semi-regular meditation sessions with Meg in an attempt to at least work on *some* of her problems. Which is more important now than ever if they're going to fight a war.

"How're you feeling?" Meg asks as she leads Catra into the meditation chamber.

"Fan-freaking-tastic," Catra mutters. It's a lie—she hasn't been able to sleep in three days between nightmares and worrying about the Horde's next move—but she doesn't really expect Meg to believe her. "Let's just do this."

Meg's version of meditation is *way* more exhausting than Perfuma's. Catra knows there's some magic at work, trying to help her redirect dark thoughts and anger into something more constructive, and she knows it's necessary, but trying to reset the way her entire brain works is hard.

On the other hand, the sessions always guarantee that Catra will get some sleep that night. So that's good, she supposes. Something to look forward to when she gets back to Bright Moon and collapses into bed.

The Horde's starting to move again. They're going to fight back. Even if Hordak is a terrible leader, they still outnumber us. I can't take an entire army on my own.

You're not on your own, though. The voice that isn't quite hers counters. A saner, more reasonable voice. What she could be, maybe. *You have the entire Princess Alliance.*

And a lot of fucking good that does me.

You don't mean that.

Maybe I do! It's not like they've been much good so far—

That's not fair, and it's not true. Take a breath. Step back.

She draws in a long breath, trying to relax her shoulders. Meditating always makes her so aware of how tense she is. How much she

clenches her jaw. How *alert* she is, ears constantly twitching like she's waiting for something. Living with constant paranoia isn't fun.

Fine, they're not useless. But I can't depend on them, either. I can't depend on anyone.

Why not?

Because none of them have the same responsibilities. None of them are She-Ra. None of them are like me.

Apparently the magic can't even argue with that. Catra bites her tongue until she tastes blood, suddenly unable to sit still. She jerks upward, running her hands through her hair. "I can't do this today," she says stiffly, surprising Meg.

"What—"

"Just. I can't. I'll try again another day."

She walks out without another word, leaving the befuddled healer behind her.

She needs to fight. She needs to work off some of this energy. She needs to *do something*.

Light Hope is more than happy to provide her with some bot simulations.

It's not much, but it lets Catra move and swing the sword around a little and gives her some satisfaction as she slices through hologram after hologram. She skids to a halt, taking a deep breath and turning to look at Light Hope.

"So, what, are you just going to beat the emotions out of me?"

"Learning to control yourself is a strenuous process," Light Hope says simply. "You must take time."

Why does it feel like these conversations always go in circles?

"You're the one who told me I need to learn!" she says impatiently, grip on the sword tightening.

"I've also told you several times that you can not afford to waste time with others." Stupid, overly logical AI. "If you were to simply stay"—

"I already told you, *no*," Catra shoots back. "I need better company than this."

"Then you must live with what I can teach you in the time you are here."

She's being *snarky*. Catra kicks at the air, looking around. "*Fine*. Just give me more bots to fight."

It's not perfect, by any means. But it's an outlet for the unending energy. The twitchiness. It's an outlet for the *anger*. Sitting around and meditating isn't doing any good. She's not sure if this is, either. But she can *move*, and that's something. That's better.

Angella stands in the door of her daughter's room, watching her read what looks like a book on war tactics. She's so much like her father. Too much sometimes. It scares Angella. Glimmer has more than proven herself capable, but... Micah had been capable as well. That isn't always a guarantee that one will come home safely.

"Mom?"

Glimmer draws Angella's attention back to reality. She smiles, sitting on the couch below the bed. "There's something I want to talk to you about." Glimmer tilts her head. It's amazing how she can look so grown up and so child-like at the same time.

"*Why are children fighting this war, Angella?*

Because they're the best hope the world has now, Angella thinks sadly. If she had been quicker, if she hadn't spent so long mourning for Micah, hiding in Bright Moon...being a coward...maybe it would be different. Maybe she could have saved Glimmer from this burden. Or maybe it wouldn't have mattered either way.

"I believe...you would make far better use of having more access to the Moonstone than I have."

Glimmer blinks, eyes going wide as her mind runs through the implications of what Angella is saying. "Wait can...can you do that? Like, give it to me?"

"In a sense." Angella smiles dryly. "I can...pull back on my bond, so to speak, and allow you more control."

Which would allow her more power. Which would make it easier for her to fight. Children are fighting this war, and at this point, they're the world's best hope. The least Angella can do is give them everything they need to win.

Glimmer shrieks, disappearing and reappearing to throw her arms around her mother, hugging her tight. Angella laughs, patting her back. "When? Can we do it now? Like right now? Now now?"

Angella is trusting the universe now. She hopes it won't let her down. "Yes, dear. We can do it now."

It's late. Entrapta is still sitting at her computer, looking through all her old records from the portal. There has to be something here. Science *always* has the answer. They're just harder to find sometimes.

Emily beeps a few times, reminding Entrapta that she should sleep. Entrapta smiles fondly, patting the bot. "I know, Emily. Don't worry, I'll go to sleep soon."

Her ears aren't sensitive enough to pick up on the faint shimmer of magic which breaks the room's silence.

"Entrapta?"

She jumps, surprised, and turns to see Glimmer standing behind her. "Glimmer?" Entrapta tilts her head. Is it possible she's fallen into another dimension? Unlikely, since all she's done is sit here. But perhaps space was moving *around* her. It was the only explanation for why Glimmer would be *here* and not in Bright Moon. "Why're you?..."

"I know this is weird," Glimmer says quickly. "But I've been wonder if, you know, there's any way to save Adora."

Definitely another dimension, Entrapta decides. "I wasn't aware you cared that much about her."

"I don't," Glimmer admits. "But Catra does. Besides, she risked her life to save all of us, and to save the world. What kind of future queen would I be if I didn't even *try* to repay the favor?"

The logic tracks, Entrapta supposes. She looks back at her computer screen. "I've been sifting through our data, trying to figure out where the portal went wrong. Obviously there were anomalies I didn't test for, but I wasn't expecting the lever to be pulled when it was, either. If I could test it in a stable environment, with the right time and resources, I might be able to recreate it. But I can't say for sure it would work."

"But you've been looking," Glimmer says. Entrapta nods.

"Scorpia asked the other day, and I couldn't stop thinking about it. Adora was good to me. I mean, she was kind of mean sometimes, and it was hard to have an intellectual conversation with her, but Scorpia is the same way. It's not their fault." Glimmer bites her tongue to keep from laughing. "I want to save her if we can."

Glimmer nods. "So do I. Is there anything I can do to help?"

"We're going to need tech. *Bits* of First One tech."

Bits of First One tech. Hoo boy. Okay. "We'll figure something out. Send a message if you have any ideas. And don't tell anyone else about this, not right now. Except Scorpia, I guess, since she kind of already knows."

"Why shouldn't I tell people?"

Because it will break Catra if she finds out that bringing Adora back really is impossible. "Just don't want anyone to get their hopes up, ya know?"

"Oh. I guess that makes sense," Entrapta agrees. "Okay. I won't tell anyone."

Glimmer smiles, relaxing slightly. "Are you okay here? Staying safe?"

"I'm safer than anyone else. I never leave."

That's not necessarily a guarantee for safety, Glimmer thinks, but she lets it go. "Okay. Just... if you ever want out of this place, just say the word, okay? I know things have been complicated, and I'm so sorry you were left behind. But we have to stick together as much as we can now."

If there's one thing they've all learned, it's to keep their friends close. Entrapta smiles a bit despite herself. "I think it'll be easiest to do my research from here. But... thank you."

"Standing of fer," Glimmer assures her. "I'll see you later."

Entrapta waves with a lock of hair as Glimmer disappears. This is certainly a turn of events, she thinks as she turns back to her screens, hair reaching for her recorder. She hit record.

"Operation saving Adora, log one. Glimmer approached me today about rescuing Adora. It's surprising that she and Scorpia share similar goals, although for different reasons." She tilts her head, humming for a moment. "The situation may be more complicated than I had originally anticipated. While staying in the Fright Zone no doubt allows me access to the technology I would need to even begin such a project…"

She pauses, fingers tapping absently against her keyboard for a long moment. "I've always followed the science. I've made so much progress working with the Horde, but for the first time, it's come with a cost. A *real* cost. Was it wrong to build the portal in the first place? If I had just had a little more time…"

That's what she's told herself, over and over, in the weeks that have passed. If she had run more tests, if she'd had just a little more time, maybe she could have predicted what would happen and stopped Catra and Adora. Or maybe they would have done it anyway. "Human emotion ~~or~~ magicat emotion, in this case ~~is~~ always an unpredictable factor, no matter how well thought out the science is. Perhaps I should have taken that into consideration before I built anything."

Entrapta stares at her screens ~~he~~r oldest friends ~~fo~~r a long moment before stopping the recording and lowering her face mask with a lock of hair.

Chapter End Notes

> I told you there would still be plenty of bad choices, right?
> (also believe it or not there's a lot of important stuff here setting up for the future. I know it all seems random, but I promise it's not)

Favors

Chapter Summary

> *"Don't."* There's something raw in Catra's voice. A pain that shouldn't be experienced by someone so young. "Just don't. This isn't about. I'm She-Ra, right? So just let me be She-Ra, and let me do my job."
>
> "And what do you think that job is?"
>
> Catra looks at her in disbelief. "What do you mean? I'm supposed to protect Etheria, aren't I?"
>
> "Yes, but at what cost?" Catra stares, uncomprehending. "How much are you willing to sacrifice in the name of protecting the planet?"
>
> "That. That doesn't matter." Catra clenches her fists, frustrated. "None of that matters anymore."
>
> Besides, she's already lost everything she can stand to lose. What's left?

Chapter Notes

> I know the Crimson Waste episode in season four was important for Perfuma's character development, and you can assume that aspect hasn't changed, but I wanted to focus on Catra instead of straight re-writing that whole bit, so....

"Wow, Sparkles," Catra says dryly, leaning on Glimmer while she waits for the world to stop spinning. "Really working on that distance."

"Does it get worse when we go further?" Bow asks curiously.

"I dont know , it all just sucks."

Catra rubs her eyes, straightening up. They're not far from Plumeria, if her allergies are anything to go by —she barely muffles a sneeze, and shoots Bow a look that clearly says *make one comment and die*.

"Maybe Aunt Casta can help with that, too," Glimmer says cheerfully .

"I dont need a magical answer to everything," Catra shoots back, frowning. She's already wary enough of how much magic she's allowing to mess with her head, completely out of her control. She doesnt need more.

"Okay , okay. Yeesh, someone's in a bad mood."

Catra bites her tongue to keep from responding, taking a deep breath before slowly saying, "Can we just talk to Perfuma and get out of here?"

"What's worse, this or the Crimson Waste?" Bow asks curiously .

"Absolutely this. At least nothing makes me sneeze in the Crimson Waste."

"No, it just *tries to kill you*." Glimmer rolls her eyes. "Why are you always so dramatic?"

"*I'm* dramatic? I swear , Sparkles"—

"Oh, visitors!" One of the Plumerians cuts off the insult and announces their arrival to the village. Catra lets Glimmer and Bow deal with that, arms wrapped around herself as she looks around. How can anyone stand to live here? She's been in the trees for two minutes and she already wants to claw her nose off…

"Glimmer , Bow, Catra!"

And there's Perfuma. She tugs Glimmer and Bow into a hug as she catches up to them, and Catra immediately backs away, ears down,

trying to give off the clearest *do not touch* signal she can. Perfuma gets it, thankfully.

"How are you guys?"

"We're good, we actually need your help with something ~~-is~~ there anywhere private we can talk?"

"Of course." Perfuma gestures for them to follow; they go further into the village, ducking into Perfuma's hut. It's somehow *worse* than outside. Catra wrinkles her nose and muffles another sneeze.

I hate this place.

"What can I do for you? Oh, do you want snacks?"

"No, we're good" ~~-~~Glimmer tries to say , but Perfuma is already going to the kitchen to get cookies. "We need your help with something."

"My help?" Perfuma peaks out, tilting her head. "With what?"

"There's an old First One's ship in the Crimson Waste," Bow explains. "We want to get it out of there before the Horde thinks to look for it. I don't even want to think about what Entrapta could do with that much tech."

Perfuma sets a plate of cookies in front of them, frowning deeply. "Yes, that is...troublesome. Do you really think I could help with that?"

"More useful than Bubbles or Snowflake," Catra points out. "Water and ice don't do well in overwhelming heat. Plants grow in the desert, right?"

"Cacti do," Bow said. "What do you think, Perfuma?"

She thinks for a moment, then nods. "Let me make a few arrangements for while I'm away, and I'll be happy to help you

however I can."

She leaves them to the cookies, going to find whoever she needs to find. Catra waits until she's gone to look at Glimmer and Bow. "I know I made fun of Mermista and Frosta, but are you guys really sure Perfuma actually *can* help with this? The Crimson W aste isn't exactly a friendly place. Remember the snake?"

"W ell, we're gonna get Huntara too," Glimmer says cheerfully , grabbing a cookie. "Hopefully . Between the two of them, we should be fine."

"And we can teleport further now ," Bow adds. "Less walking, less snakes, more help. Well definitely be fine."

"Ready when you all are," Perfuma says as she dances back into the hut. "This should be a breeze."

"A breeze," Catra repeats, standing. "Right."

Glimmer takes her hand, then Bow's hand, and Bow takes Perfuma's hand. And in a shower of sparkles, they're standing outside a shady looking building. Catra leans on Glimmer until the world stops spinning, listening to the others debate.

"So.we should go in, right?"

"Maybe not all of us. W e might stand out."

The door opens, giving them a quick glance inside as a tall, green reptilian walks out. Definitely the kind of place a bunch of outlaws would hang out. The others would stand out like a sore thumb.

"Y ou're all useless," Catra grumbles as she pushes herself of f of Glimmer and heads inside, ignoring the protests behind her.

"Catra, wait—"

"She' s going to die!"

The door swings shut behind her. She rolls her eyes, looking around, and spots the darkest corner with the most people. She makes her way over —and is blocked by a purple-skinned goat lady .

Oh you have got *to be kidding me.*

"What do you want, outsider"?

"I want you to get out of my way ," Catra says stif fly. "I dont have time for this."

The lady puffs her chest out, clearly trying to look tough. "Y ou better *make* time"—

"No." Catra steps back and summons the sword, turning it to aim the edge at the lady's neck. "*You* better get out of my way before I make good use of this sword, and a bad mess for the bartender to clean up."

Dead silence follows. It's broken by a chuckle as Huntara stands. "Down, kitty . Im sure youre not here to cause trouble."

Catra glares at the goat lady, who immediately backs off, looking a bit paler now. Good. "Y ou need better friends," she informs Huntara shortly.

"W e cant all have of a princess glued to us. What do you want"?

"*I* want to go home. The princess wants to talk to you."

Huntara huffs under her breath, but follows Catra back out to the desert. Glimmer and Bow let out a sigh of relief when they see Catra, alive and unharmed.

"Kitty cat says you all need a favor? Dont you owe me enough already"? The words are mostly joking.

"One more thing" ? Glimmer says hopefully . "W e need help getting that ship you led us to out of the Wastes before the Horde thinks to

go after it."

Huntara tilts her head, thinking for a moment. "I suppose I could use some time outta this place," she says thoughtfully , eyes sweeping over the group. Her eyes fall on Perfuma. "Oh, you're a new one. Sure this place isn't a little rough for you, Flower Girl?"

Perfuma frowns, looking offended. "I can handle myself just fine, thank you. And it's Perfuma."

"I call her Flower Power ," Catra says helpfully . "Has a better ring to it."

"Catra, stop trying to corrupt people," Glimmer says, rolling her eyes. "Let's just get to the ship and get it out of here."

"Yes ma'am."

"Why couldn't you have just teleported this thing home?"

"Because I'm not *that* strong," Glimmer grumbles, staring up at the ship. "Yet. But we don't have time for me to get that strong. The Horde knows this is here, and they have a princess who knows how to make weapons out of First Ones' tech."

"She'd probably be able to use this to destroy the planet," Bow adds unhelpfully. Huntara shakes her head.

"You princesses and your weird powers"…

"Hey , don't lump me in with them," Catra complains.

"Don't *you* turn into a giant woman with a magic sword?"

"Not the point."

Perfuma is lagging behind them slightly, looking around. Catra starts on to the ship, while Glimmer teleports to a nearby cliff to get a better

view, and Huntara patrols around the outside. Bow starts to follow Catra, but stops when Perfuma still doesn't follow. "Hey, you okay?"

"Yes. No." She sighs. "I'm no good with cacti."

"How do you know? You haven't even—"

"Yes, I have!" Bow is surprised by the outburst. "I've tried to keep cacti before but they're so...so prickly and harsh and unfriendly."

"Glimmer said the same thing about Catra when we met her," Bow points out with a chuckle. "Actually, she *still* says the same thing about Catra."

"I just don't understand them."

"Catra?" Perfuma stares at Bow for a moment. "Cacti. Right. I mean...even prickly things have a soft side, right? You just have to find it."

"But they're *so* difficult. How am I supposed to work with something like that?"

Bow looks at her, then toward Huntara, then up at Glimmer, then at the ship. "You figure out ways to deal with it."

Catra stares at the chair in the middle of the control room. The hologram is gone, but she can still see Mara sitting in the chair.

"*If you open a portal, death and destruction will follow. For the good of the universe, Etheria must stay in Beyondos.*"

She should have listened. Why didn't she listen?

Because you're selfish. Because you're a coward. Because you wanted to run away from your responsibilities. Because you never should have been trusted with power in the first place. Because—

"Shut *up*!" She punctuates the words with a kick to the chair.

"Usually people wait until after I say something to yell that," Huntara jokes from the door. Catra turns to look at her, surprise, her ears drooping.

"Sorry, that wasn't it. It's been a long day. Month. Year. Life. Etc." She waves her hands for emphasis. "Something wrong?"

"I think Flower Girl is having a bit of a meltdown at the boy, but no one's comin' to attack us if that's what you're askin'."

There's no one left to do that. Adora's the only person who's ever cared about chasing Catra. Although that's probably not what Huntara means. "Yeah. Cool."

She drops into the seat, curling her legs up to her chest and hiding her face in her knees. "Am I interrupting something?" Huntara asks uncertainly. She's not exactly the feelings type; Catra can tell she's trying to decide whether or not to get Bow.

"I'd say a mental breakdown, but that's been happening since I was fourteen." Catra laughs humorlessly. "You were in the Horde, right? You leave anyone behind?"

"A few friends. No one like Blondie." Catra's head snaps up. "Don't be so surprised." Huntara snorts. "You two weren't exactly subtle."

"It's not like—look, we were raised by Shadow Weaver."

"Eugh." Even Huntara sounds disturbed by that. Good. She knows what Catra means.

"Yeah. It sucked." Catra sighs, standing. "Doesn't matter now, I guess."

"Matters if it's still in your head," Huntara replies flatly. "Distracted soldiers get people killed."

Huntara doesn't know what happened. Catra knows she's not taking a personal shot at her. Not purposely, anyway.

And yet it still hurts. It still sends flashes of Adora's stupid, hopeful face through her mind as she declares that she can fix everything — all the mistakes *Catra* made — if she just does this one thing. If she just sacrifices herself for everyone. Stupid, dumb, heroic Adora.

Her ears go flat against her head, her fists clenching for a moment before she moves, walking passed Huntara. She's not prepared for the hand that grabs her shoulder, pulling her back. "What're you—"

"I can tell you're out of your head, kitty," Huntara informs her flatly, jabbing a finger at her. "You're not going to do anyone any good if you start breaking down."

Catra narrows her eyes at Huntara, yanking her shoulder away. "I'm *fine*," she informs the woman flatly. "And I don't need you telling me what to do, thanks."

"*Someone* needs to tell you what to do. And I have a feeling the princesses are a bit too soft for you."

"Fuck of f. I'm going to find out if we're any closer to moving this thing."

She storms away without another word, knowing Huntara is letting her walk away. The bigger woman could have held her back to argue if she really wanted. But cats have claws. And Huntara knows better than to provoke one that's already angry.

"Any luck out here?" Catra calls as she steps back out into the blazing sun. The look on Perfuma's and Bow's faces says no. "Great. Well—"

"Incoming!" Glimmer calls before reappearing beside them. "Nothing big, looks like a few bandits or something. Someone must have let it slip that it's open season on the ship."

"Oh good, just when I thought today was going to be a wash," Catra says dryly, summoning the sword. "At least I can get a little exercise.

You guys deal with this. Ill deal with them."

"Hang on, shouldnt you"—

Too late. "For the honor of Grayskull!"

"Let her do her thing," Huntara says with a shrug, turning back to the ship. "It' s not going to hurt anyone."

"It might hurt the people she' s about beat up."

They get the ship out of the Waste eventually. And the thugs limp back to town with a new story to tell about getting beaten half to death by She-Ra, as well as a threat from Huntara to get out of her town before sun down.

"Cant we move a little faster?" Glimmer asks impatiently . Casta raises an eyebrow.

"Y ou cant rush learning magic, Glimmer . It's a tricky thing. Mistakes can be fatal."

"I know , I *know*." Glimmer sighs, throwing her hands up. "But there *has* to be more I can do *now*."

Castaspella frowns. "Is something wrong?"

Everything is wrong. How can she even ask that? They're at war! It must be nice to live in Mystacor, to not be caught in the middle of all this. "The Horde is trying to take back ground again. Everyone is working so hard, and I hate that it feels like there' s nothing I can do to help."

"I understand," Casta says. "But you wont help anyone if you rush into something you're not ready for , either."

"I *know*." Glimmer slumps, staring at the ground. "I know ."

"*You think of yourself only as a princess. But you're the child of a great sorcerer. You have a more powerful connection to magic than you've ever realized.* "

The words echo in her head. She frowns for a long moment before standing. Casta looks up, surprised. "Are we done already?"

"I should get back and make sure Catra hasn't gone off and started another war with someone. She's been kind of...twitchy lately ."

"Meg's been asking about her. Try to get her to come back for another session."

"I will." Glimmer smiles, kissing her aunt's cheek. "See you later ."

—
—

Shadow Weaver is still in the castle. Catra *knows* Shadow Weaver is still in the castle, and will literally climb walls to avoid going within a thousand feet of her door. Which is how Glimmer knows she won't be overheard by sensitive ears when she teleports into the room.

"Ah, Princess." The sorceress sounds amused. "What can I do for you? Did Catra give the sword to another warlord?"

Glimmer ignores that. "You taught my dad, didn't you?"

"I did. He was *extremely* gifted. A shame that power went to waste for a world that would never understand him."

This is a terrible idea. Glimmer takes a deep breath. "Can you teach me too?"

For once, Shadow Weaver is shocked into silence. "I don't have time to go slow and learn the way Aunt Casta wants me to. There's a war going on and I need to be strong enough to help."

"Don't you think you owe me enough favors, Princess?"

"Consider it an exchange for me convincing Catra not to cut your throat open in your sleep," Glimmer replies icily . Shadow Weaver scoffs.

"I dont need you to protect me from that filthy mongrel."

"I'm *not* protecting you, Im trying to help *her*. You just happen to benefit," Glimmer said impatiently . "Are you going to do this, or just keep jerking me around?"

Shadow Weaver considers it for a long moment.then smiles under her mask. "Okay . Ill train you. But we do things *my* way."

Glimmer already doesnt like the sound of that. "Fine," she grits out. "As long as your way doesnt involve trying to escape."

"Dont worry , my dear princess. Im exactly where I want to be."

Another village, another Horde attack. Another day.

"There' s a lot of them. We cant just" Catra bolts out of the bushes, ignoring Glimmer entirely. "*Catra*! Hang on!"

She's already running at a tank, slicing through it with ease. Glimmer groans, teleporting to back her up, and Bow grabs an arrow. No plan, then. That's fine.

Catra falls into an easy rhythm –hit a soldier , move to the next one. The hilt of the sword or even her elbow both make for good, blunt objects to break through the helmets with. She twists and twirls, dodging two green energy shots, and swings the sword, cutting both guns in half. The soldiers holding them have no time to react before she grabs one and throws them into the other. Bots are starting to advance;Catra turns to them, readying her sword, and runs. They're machines. She can hack away with no remorse.

Entrapta might disagree with that.

Then Entrapta should stop building tech for the fucking Horde.

Her muscles are burning, her arms aching with every swing, and it feels *good*.The adrenaline rush from the battle around her is amazing. She doesnt care about anything, she doesnt hurt. All that matters is slicing each and every one of these bastards to pieces.

"Catra, behind you!"

She barely registers Bow yelling her name, and then a hand is grabbing her, pulling her away from the chaos. Teleporting isnt *as* bad with She-Ra, but Catra still leans over to rest her hands on her knees and groan. The teleporting and the very sudden adrenaline drop are making her head spin.

"What'd you pull me away for?"she demands, pulling her arm from Glimmer's hand.

"I was trying to save you from getting *impaled*!"She emphasizes the word with a finger jab at a robot Bow has just hit an exploding arrow with. "Were you paying attention at all?"

"Of course I was! I had everything under control."

"Could've fooled me."

"Guys,"Bow calls, interrupting the fight. "The Horde's retreating. Do we wanna follow, or?..

Glimmer and Catra glare at each other for a moment before letting it go. "No,"Glimmer grumbles. "Let's just help the villagers clean up."

"Oh, am I allowed to do that?"Catra asks through gritted teeth.

"Can you not?"Glimmer shoots back. "Well..talk about this later, okay?"

"Sure, fine."Catra turns away, heading into the village. "Whatever."

She lets Bow and Glimmer do most of the talking with people, busying herself with moving rubble and salvaging homes where she can. She's not sure *why* she's so frustrated with everything. But it's like a constant thrumming in her head, driving her absolutely insane. Nothing seems to calm it.

And she doesn't know what to do.

"There isn't really any… *pattern* to the attacks," Glimmer says uncertainly, looking over the table. "I don't understand what they're trying to do."

"Push the line and see where they can break through," Bow suggests. Catra rests her cheek against her fist, staring at the table in disinterest.

"Hordak isn't that smart. Unless he's picked up another second-in-command, and I can't think of one person who's even slightly qualified for that."

"Maybe that's why the attacks haven't been that bad. They're engaging to test us, then falling back when they get what they need to know," Bow says. "If they think they can find a blind spot in our defenses"…

Glimmer scoffs. "They *won't*."

"I know , but *if*. The best way to figure it out is to"…

Bow waves a hand at the table. "Use pawns to test the front lines," Catra finishes the thought. "Then focus everything where they think it's weakest and try to break us down."

"They're trying to bring the fight to us," Angella concludes softly .

"They managed it once, with Adora," Catra says, muttering her friend's name. "It's possible Hordak learned a few things about

leading while he had her around. But he can't recreate her exact strategy without messing up the Whispering Woods again, so he has to find his own way in."

"So what do we do to stop it?" Bow asks, looking between the women.

"We could bring the fight to them instead of waiting," Catra says darkly. "No one knows the Fright Zone or the Forge better than I do."

"The Horde still has numbers against us," Angella points out. "All that knowledge is useless if you're overwhelmed."

Catra snorts. "Please. I could take them alone."

"I would rather not test that." Angella is trying to be reasonable, but there's a stiffness in her tone. It hasn't escaped her notice that Catra's been more careless with her life ~~with everything since~~ the portal. "We can rest on it, for now. You all did good work today."

Glimmer perks up a bit, exchanging looks with Bow, and they both grin. Catra isn't nearly as enthused. "Cool." She stands to leave.

"Actually, Catra, could I have a word?"

Glimmer and Bow take that for the dismissal it is, and quickly leave. Catra looks back at Angella, jaw clenched. "What?"

Angella considers asking her to sit, then decides against it. "Castaspella mentioned you were seeing a healer in Mystacor." Of fucking course she did. "Have you been back there recently?"

Catra huffs, running her hands through her hair. "I don't need a healer or meditation, okay?" she grits out between her teeth. "I just need to *do* something."

"And how many soldiers will you have to take down before you realize you're not going to find what you're looking for in fighting?"

Her ears twitch, tail moving sharply back and forth. "I'm not *looking* for anything."

Angella sighs inwardly. She's about to go into a risky territory, and she knows it. "When I lost Micah"—

"*Don't*." There's something raw in Catra's voice. A pain that shouldn't be experienced by someone so young. "Just don't. This isn't about… I'm She-Ra, right? So just let me be She-Ra, and let me do my job."

"And what do you think that job is?"

Catra looks at her in disbelief. "What do you mean? I'm supposed to protect Etheria, aren't I?"

"Yes, but at what cost?" Catra stares, uncomprehending. "How much are you willing to sacrifice in the name of protecting the planet?"

"That. That doesn't matter." Catra clenches her fists, frustrated. "None of that matters anymore."

Besides, she's already lost everything she can stand to lose. What's left?

Angella regards her sadly, but lets it go. "Please go back to Mystacor. I think it would be good for you to have some time for yourself." Catra opens her mouth to argue. "I'll make it an order, if I have to," Angella threatens. Catra deflates slightly.

"*Fine*."

Meg is pleased when Catra returns. They go to their usual room, settling in. "Are you okay?" the healer asks, cocking her head. Catra laughs bitterly.

"I haven't been okay since I was five. Maybe four."

She's thankful Meg doesn't try to question that. "Let's begin, then."

Catra takes a deep breath, tail settling behind her, and closes her eyes.

"*And how many soldiers will you have to take down before you realize you're not going to find what you want in fighting?*"

The question has been bothering since the meeting. She had told Angella she isn't looking for anything, but that isn't necessarily true, is it? She knows exactly what she wants – peace. Not for the kingdom or the planet, but for herself. Her own, selfish peace. She wants all of this to be over, she wants Adora back, she wants to have never found that damn sword in the first place…

She wants the world she had in the portal.

The idea of being *Princess Catra* makes her cringe, but she can't deny that her life had been so much better in the portal. No Horde, no Shadow Weaver, no war. Engaged to Adora, which was a little weird, but it's not like she's completely oblivious;she' s loved Adora since they were kids, since she was old enough to comprehend such complicated feelings. She also knew that Adora had never and would never feel the same way. Shadow Weaver had seen to that. But they had been *happy* in the portal. It felt like Adora really had loved her.

But, like all good things, it hadn't been meant to last. Catra' s life had been built on an unstable foundation of bad treatment, bad choices, and bad behavior. It had built its way out of the shadows that threatened to consume it every single day, built toward a light that could never be obtained. Of course it would all fall apart.

She's never been good enough for anything else.

Interlude II

Chapter Summary

How's Adora doing these days?

"Do you think"…

Catra looks up at Adora as her voice drifts off. They're spending a few days in Bright Moon, celebrating Glimmer's and Bow's engagement (and collecting on some bets;Mermista is too pessimistic sometimes), and currently enjoying a quiet moment in the gardens, watching the night sky. Adora's lived in Half Moon for so long, she'd almost forgotten they're nocturnal. It's weird to be awake when the rest of the world is asleep.

"Do I think what?" Catra prompts. She's lying on the grass with her head in Adora's lap, bright eyes watching her wife curiously.

"Never mind," Adora says quickly, ducking her head. Catra reaches up to poke her forehead.

"Dont do that," she protests, frowning. "Talk to me."

"It's dumb." Catra raises an eyebrow, unmoved by the argument. "Angella just, um. she and your mom were talking, and she said something about grandchildren, and"…

Adora blushes, wishing she could hide her face further. Catra, to her credit, doesnt laugh. She looks almost thoughtful. "Is that… something you want? Kids, I mean?"

Yes. It's something Adora's been thinking about for a long time, if she's honest. They've been married for three years, and there's no rush, but Adora swears she gets a pang of longing every time she sees a baby in the village.

"Can we even do that?"

Catra snorts, rolling her eyes. "*Yes,* Adora, we can have a baby. We're adults, we can mostly do whatever we want."

Adora shoves her lightly. "I mean, like...you and me. Is that possible?"

"I'm not sure," Catra admits. "My moms had me, but they're both Magicats, so it's different. We won't know unless we ask, though. Do you *want* to ask?"

The question is pointed. There are only two acceptable answers. "Yes," Adora whispers after a moment. It feels so weird, so selfish to admit out loud, that she *wants* something. And not something particularly insignificant, at that. Having a child, a family...that's a *lot*.

Catra is smiling softly, raising a hand to cup Adora's cheek. "I do too," she says. The three words light a fire in Adora's chest. She feels warm in the best possible way ~~-in~~ ways *only* Catra can ever make her feel.

"Would our kid look more like a magicat?"

"I think so," Catra says, tugging Adora down to kiss her. "You just want to know if they'll have cat ears, don't you?"

Adora blushes furiously, but refuses to look away. She's made no secret of how absolutely adorable she thinks Catra's ears are. She's also the only person who's allowed to get away with it, and she knows it. "Maybe."

Catra laughs, gently head-butting Adora's stomach. "Cross-species relationships aren't exactly common, so we'll get what we get. But I'm pretty sure our genetics are stronger. We'll probably end up with a little furball who has ears and a tail."

"That's...That's *so*." Adora bounces slightly, trying not to scream in delight.

"*Cute*." Adora nods furiously. "Do you want to squeal?" Another nod. Catra laughs, a deep purr in her chest. Adora swoops in to kiss her again, her hair falling to frame their faces.

"I love you," she whispers against Catra's lips. "I love you so much."

Catra's hand snakes up to rest against the back of Adora's neck. "I love you too." Her eyes shine in the darkness. Adora brushes her fingers through Catra's hair, scritching the base of her ears. "So. Do we want to wait until we get home to talk to my moms, or steal the spotlight?"

"I think we can wait," Adora says with a small laugh. "Let Glimmer and Blow have their time."

"Uuuuuuuuugh, fine." Catra rolls her eyes, but she's smiling. "This just means everyone will have to come to Half Moon when I...or I mean, if one of us..."

She's blushing now. Adora tries not to smirk. "Do *you* want to be the one to carry?"

Catra's ears flatten against her head. She looks away. "Kind of," she admits quietly. "I've thought about this, you know. And the idea of carrying the baby just...it *feels* right."

Adora again feels selfish for the relief. She may have been the first to bring it up, but the idea of being pregnant seems absolutely *terrifying* to her. And Catra looks...weirdly at peace with all of it. Like she's already made her a choice and had been hoping Adora would be okay with it.

And she is. She's more than okay with it. Maybe she'll feel better about the idea after Catra—there's no reason they have to stop at one kid, after all. The idea of a bundle of small kits with their various

features mixed together to make a completely unique being made Adora want to cry from the pure joy.

"How many kids do you want?" Catra asks with a smirk. She really can read minds. Adora is certain of it.

"I don't know. I mean, your moms stopped at one—"

"They got it right on the first try," Catra says with a shrug. "Heterochromia is supposedly a symbol of good luck, you know."

"Really?" Adora asks, tilting her head.

"According to some old legends. I don't know. Mama knows the entire story if you want to ask her about it. Might be the only explanation for how I got you."

Adora laughed, brushing back Catra's hair. "Sap."

"Your sap."

"My *wife.*"

"Damn straight."

Catra is smiling as she closes her eyes, snuggling closer to Adora, purring contently. "Guess we should try and sleep," she says dreamily. "Gotta get on this weird *day* schedule everyone around here is so fond of."

"There are some perks to it," Adora points out. Sometimes she misses the daylight. Not enough to want any major changes—visits to Bright Moon work just fine to fulfill her needs.

"Too bright, too many people, no thanks," Catra says. She's showing no signs of moving. Adora smiles, raising an eyebrow.

"Am I carrying you to bed?" A loud purr answers her. Adora smiles, tucking one arm under her knees and wrapping the other around her

back, standing easily. Catra snuggles into her, smiling.

“I love you.”

“I love you too.”

Fault

Chapter Summary

"Dont you have a war to fight?"

She freezes, fur standing on end, and slowly turns to look at the inner courtyard she's walking by –and the masked sorceress behind the barrier. She hasnt seen Shadow W eaver since the portal, and she would have preferred to keep it that way.

"Dont *you* have a prison cell you should be in?" The words are a snarl. Shadow Weaver tsks, shaking her head.

"My… *prison cell* opens up into this courtyard. The queen was *gracious* enough to allow me a little more freedom." She gestures a hand around herself. "I suppose it could also be seen as a *thank you* for my part in helping to stop the portal you so desperately wanted to activate."

Catra grits her teeth. "How nice for you. It' s so convenient that you were taken prisoner by the kingdom that doesnt have a fucking dungeon in its castle basement."

"Honestly , Catra. Where does all this anger come from?"

This, Catra realizes, is what she left her room for. This is what she was looking for, what she couldnt find in solitude.

She's not worth it.

Oh, Mermista had been so, so wrong.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"This is everything I have from the first portal."

It might as well be another language, Glimmer thinks as she looks through the rows of data scrolling on Entrapta's computer screen. Scorpia looks glassy eyed;she' s clearly not taking any of this in. "As far as I can tell, opening the portal destabilized reality, causing it to slowly fold in on itself, because it wasn't strong enough to pull Etheria through to the other universe."

"So..that means it' s not possible,"Scorpia concluded, looking at Entrapta. "Right?"

"Mara opened a portal to bring Etheria here,"Glimmer says. "She was the She-Ra before Catra, a First One. It can't have just been a one-way door."

Entrapta's pigtail taps her chin as she frowns. "It' s possible she had access to technology I don't. Being a First One *and* She-Ra probably allowed her certain privileges."

"But we're neither of those things, and the First Ones are looooooooooooong gone."

"Y eah."Entrapta spun her seat, sighing, legs crossed under herself. "Part of the problem is that Etheria is out of balance --it has been for a really long time, because the Runestones aren't aligned. That probably made a difference when Mara was pulling Etheria through."

Glimmer tilted her head. "What do you mean the Runestones aren't aligned?"

"W ell, Shadow Weaver controlled the Black Garnet for a long time, which threw it out of whack because of the way she was using it. That, plus not being bonded with its intended princess has led to all the Runestones being slightly unbalanced."

Entrapta and Glimmer look at Scorpia, who blinks a couple times before realization sets in. "Oh, so if I bonded with the Black Garnet,

then that would balance out Etheria?"

"Yes. But there's still something else we need to make a portal *work*." Entrapta turns back to her computers. "Does Catra know anything else about Mara? We need more context for the first portal and how it was opened."

"If she does, she's not sharing," Glimmer says. "And I'm not asking. It's kind of a sore subject with her. Besides, I don't want her to ask why I'm asking."

"Is there anyone else left from a thousand years ago?"

"I don't think—" Glimmer cut herself off, eyes widening. "*Maybe*. I have an idea. No promises, but I'll let you guys know how it pans out."

She disappears before either of them can ask.

Glimmer appears on her bed and sighs, flopping over. It's late, or early, she's not really sure. But there's enough time for her to get some sleep…

"Where were you?"

She shrieks, bolting upright. Catra's caught her. Or her mother's caught her. She's so dead—

Then the voice registers. "Bow?" She looks over the side of her bed to see her friend on the ground, looking up at her with a raised eyebrow. "What are you doing here?"

"I *was* testing out a new arrow"—

"*What*?"

"But you weren't here to let me know how it went. Where were you?"

"Why were —st op shooting arrows through my window!"

"Stop avoiding the qestion!"

Glimmer huffs, teleporting down to grab Bow and bring him back to the bed. "*Look*," she hisses. "I'm working on something, and I don't want anyone else to know. Not yet. So can you please keep this to yourself?"

Bow crosses his arms, unimpressed. "What are you working on?" he asks. Glimmer presses her lips thin. "I'll tell Angella."

"Bow!"

"What's going on with you?" Bow demands. "You've been acting weird lately. Even Catra's noticed you're avoiding us."

"I'm not...not." Glimmer groans, covering her face. "Bow, *please*."

"Tell me the truth."

He's stubborn. And Glimmer has never been particularly good at saying no to him. "You have to promise you won't get mad." Bow raises an eyebrow. "I've been...working with Entrapta and Scorpia, sort of. To try and build a new portal."

"*What?*" Bow's voice cracks as it jumps several octaves. "Are you *kidding*, after what happened—"

"Shush!" Glimmer quickly covers his mouth. "That's *exactly* why I'm doing it! I...I want to save Adora." Bow's eyebrows crinkle in confusion. "We can't just… *leave* her there. She's Catra's… something. She's terrible at being a friend, but I think that's kind of the Horde's fault since Catra kind of sucks at it too. But I don't think she was a bad person. And if we bring her back maybe...maybe we can bring Catra back, too."

Bow pulls her hand from his mouth. "Catra's right down the hall."

"I *know*, but." Glimmer cast a look at her bedroom door, sighing. "She's so different, Bow. Don't tell me you haven't noticed."

Of course he has. It's hard to miss. The way she carries herself, her attitude, her demeanor, everything is different. Seeing the healer in Mystacor seems to be helping slightly, but at the end of the day, it's a bandage at best. Catra's entire nature seems to have shifted to something darker. Angrier. More sacrificial.

That's the part that worries Bow the most.

"Why wouldn't you just tell her that?" he asks, frowning.

"Because if there's no way to bring her back, it's going to break Catra. She already hates herself for it, but knowing Adora's really gone forever? What do you think that'll do to her?"

Again, Glimmer's right, as much as Bow doesn't like to admit it. "And you said you're working with Scorpia and Entrapta? That doesn't seem safe."

"I don't think they're as on-board with the Horde as they were before the portal. They both seem really depressed. And they'd already kind of talked about rescuing Adora before I even asked. Besides, we can't do anything without Entrapta. Do *you* know how to build a portal between dimensions?"

He doesn't, and they both know it. "For the record, I think this is a really bad idea," he says slowly. "*But* I know I'm not talking you out of anything, so… from now on, you take me with you when you go see them."

Glimmer hesitates, her shoulders falling after a moment. "Okay," she says. "There's… probably something else you should know…" Bow waits. Glimmer sighs. "I've been training with Shadow Weaver. Just a little!" she adds as Bow opens his mouth to protest. "I just… want to speed up the process a bit. Aunt Casta is a great teacher but I need to learn *more*."

"So you're trusting *Shadow Weaver?*"

"I," Glimmer runs a hand through her hair. "I just want to be stronger. She's the only one who can help."

"This is a *terrible* idea." Bow already knows there's no point in arguing about it—Glimmer has made her choice. All he can hope to do is mitigate the damage from the possible fallout if Catra ever found out the truth.

Catra can *never* find out the truth.

Catra's fingers are twitching. Juliet is talking to her, and she knows she should be listening, seeing as how she just cold-cocked one of the guards, but her mind is in other places. Repeating the words the guard had said, over and over, not realizing there was a vigilant magicat in earshot.

"*Ding was the best thing that Force Captain could've done. Practically handed us the war.*"

She hadn't used her claws. She deserves some credit for that.

"Catra! Are you listening to me?"

She snaps back to reality, looking up at Juliet. "I'm not apologizing."

The guard captain sighs. "I'm not asking you to. Just… *please* refrain from hitting the guards unless you're training. If you don't think you can keep yourself from breaking their jaws, sideline yourself."

"Fine," Catra says stiffly. "Can I go now?"

Juliet nods. Catra turns on her heel and walks away, sharp steps echoing off the walls of the silent hallway. She feels like she's crawling out of her skin. The Horde has been quiet, because the guard with a now broken jaw had a point—the Horde isn't

organized well without Adora telling it what to do. Catra idly wonders who's giving them orders now. Scorpia, maybe? She snorts at the thought.

She's not really paying attention as she walks. She has nowhere to be; she hadn't been going anywhere when she'd overheard the guards talking. She just needed to get out of her room and *move*.

"Don't you have a war to fight?"

She freezes, fur standing on end, and slowly turns to look at the inner courtyard she's walking by—and the masked sorceress behind the barrier. She hasn't seen Shadow Weaver since the portal, and she would have preferred to keep it that way.

"Don't *you* have a prison cell you should be in?" The words are a snarl. Shadow Weaver tsks, shaking her head.

"My… *prison cell* opens up into this courtyard. The queen was *gracious* enough to allow me a little more freedom." She gestures a hand around herself. "I suppose it could also be seen as a *thank you* for my part in helping to stop the portal you so desperately wanted to activate."

Catra grits her teeth. "How nice for you. It's so convenient that you were taken prisoner by the kingdom that doesn't have a fucking dungeon in its castle basement."

"Honestly, Catra. Where does all this anger come from?"

This, Catra realizes, is what she left her room for. This is what she was looking for, what she couldn't find in solitude. She could only destroy her own belongings and turn her claws on herself so many times before it stopped being a good outlet.

She's not worth it.

Oh, Mermista had been so, so wrong.

"You know what, I'm not sure," she snaps, slamming her claws into the barrier. Shadow Weaver flinches back just the smallest bit—a normal person wouldn't have noticed. Catra is *not* a normal person. "Let's go back a bit and see if we can figure it out. *I,* personally, think it started the first time my so-called *guardian*—the person who was supposed to *raise me*—used magic to *torture* me. Or that time right after the torture when you told me you would *kill me* if I ever dragged Adora down. Or maybe it started when you tried turning us against each other and using us against each other. Did you think we didn't see that? You never railed on *Bonnie* for not doing as well in training sims, or pointed out that *Kyle* was behind Adora, or that *Rogelio* failed to make first place *again*. It was just me and Adora. All of it was a sick fucking game to you, and it was all rigged. You wanted me to resent her, and you know what? It *worked*. This? *All of this?*" She waves a hand at herself. "All the anger, all the bitterness? *You* made me this way. And now you think you get to play the good guy?" She laughs darkly. "Give me a break. I know about Mystacor, you know. And Micah. You didn't care about doing the right thing then. You just wanted power. You still just want *power*. But your favorite student turned on you, and your boss hung you out to dry, so you had to settle for *second best*. You had to settle for the *mistake* you made when you took me from Half Moon and left everyone else to die.

"And now you're *here*, and I have to remember every single day that you're *here*, and I wasted my time and energy to *save you*, and *you* get to keep living in a fucking castle, with a fucking garden, while good people who *deserve* to live don't get that luxury, because of *you*."

There's a moment of silence. And then Shadow Weaver laughs. "You still blame *me* for Adora? *You're* the one who gave Hordak what he needed to make the portal work. You're the one who pulled the lever. You brought Adora down with you, just like I knew you would. I told her years ago to distance herself from you, but she didn't listen, and she paid for it. That is squarely on *your* shoulders. But by all means, continue to scapegoat me and run away from your problems."

Catra's shaking claws dig slightly into the barrier. But she doesn't break through. "Every single step we took was driven by *you*. But tell yourself whatever you need to sleep at night."

She shoves away from the barrier, storming down the hall. Damn it. *Damn it*. It had helped for a moment—unloading all of her anger onto Shadow Weaver, yelling at someone, taking it out on a person who *deserved* it. But now she's shaking again, hands trembling, breathing slightly rapid. She wants to go back. She wants to say more, to *do more*. She wants to rip that mask off of Shadow Weaver's face and drag her claws across her eyes just as she had Octavia when she was younger. She wants to *hurt* someone.

The thought brings her up short. But she isn't surprised or stunned by it. It actually brings her some grim joy. Because she knows exactly how she can do it. There are still plenty of villages being occupied by the Horde. And if Angella won't let her bring the fight to the Fright Zone, then she can at *least* bring it to those poor, hapless soldiers who hadn't already gotten their eviction notices.

"Glimmer? Do you have a moment?"

Angella standing in Glimmer's bedroom door is alarming, to say the least. Did Bow sell her out already? "Yeah," she says uncertainly, sitting up and teleporting down to sit with her mother. "Am I in trouble?"

That gets her a raised eyebrow. "Should you be?"

"No," Glimmer says quickly. Maybe a little too quickly. Angella gave her a long, calculating look before moving on.

"I would like to discuss...different tactics with you, if you have the time. Different ways to approach this fight."

Glimmer's eyes widened, nearly lighting up. "You want… *my advice*?"

input," Angella corrects gently, but firmly. "I believe between the two of us, we may be able to come up with a way of pushing forward that will make everyone happy."

Glimmer grimaces, remembering the last meeting. "You can just say Catra."

Angella sighs. "Admittedly, I would like to take action before she decides to take matters into her own hands."

"I mean... I think she has a good point about just taking the fight to them," Glimmer says, curling her legs under herself. "But I... I know that's not the right way to go."

Not after her last two missions into the Fright Zone. She had learned her lesson. Angella nods. "I understand the impulse. They've certainly been lacking in structure since..."

Since the portal. Since they lost Adora. "Taking back surrounding areas might be a good first step," Glimmer suggests after a moment. "Even if we can't get into the Fright Zone, we can get close. Maybe use one of the less populated places as an outpost. I'm sure some of the villages cleared out when the Horde took over."

Angella nodded. "That might be a good start. Get us closer without going in. And if we can establish a good foothold in the area..."

"Maybe we can get allies," Glimmer finishes, bouncing slightly. And Angella sees that spark again—that determination to fight, to win. The conviction that she was right.

The same look in Adora's eyes before she had pushed Catra away and taken things into her own hands to protect her friend.

That girl haunts Angella's dreams, on the rare occasions she slept. She wonders if she could have stopped her. If she could have kept Catra *and* Adora back. They were both young. They both deserved to live. She wonders if Adora had thought of the same thing, and that

was why she had pushed Catra away to distract Angella, to keep her from acting.

"*Why are children fighting this war, Angella?*

The question may never stop haunting her.

But there's nothing for it now. The time for wallowing in the past is gone. There would be no more sacrifices. No more Adoras. They were going to end this.

And she would give everything she had to make that happen.

Scorpia is *not* having a good day.

She's trying to be optimistic about it – being upset won't help, after all. But all of the force captains have decided that *she* can be the go-between with Hordak, which is already challenging enough, and the Rebellion isn't *exactly* making her life easy. Hearing about a raid on a village they captured *months* ago is almost enough to put her day over the edge.

The good news – it's only one person. The bad news – that one person is *She-Ra*.

"Aw, c'mon," she mumbles as she watches Catra slice through a bot. She's not sure if this is better or worse than an entire group.

Catra's ears twitch when she hears the approaching skiff; she turns, smirking when she sees the force captain approaching on a skiff with three soldiers. She can *only imagine* who's hiding under those helmets.

"Aw, sending out the big guns for little old me?" she teases with a smirk as she turns to face the oncoming skiff. One of the soldiers behind Scorpia was already aiming their gun. Catra quickly changes the sword to a shield to deflect the shot, then launches herself at the

skiff as she changes the sword back and runs it through the motor. Scorpia yelps, and they all bail before the skiff explodes.

"Come on," Scorpia says, straightening up. "Can't we just"—

She's forced to cut off as Catra swings the sword, catching the blade in her pincers. "How the *fuck* did you become a force captain?" Catra scoffed. "Do you even do anything?"

Scorpia's expression hardens; she swings the sword with surprising strength, throwing it and Catra into the air. Catra yelps, twisting to right herself. She lands, and changes the sword back to a shield to block Scorpia, who runs at her and swings one pincer. It clangs loudly as it hits the metal.

"Hey, did you ever ask Force Captain Octavia how she lost an eye?"

"What"—

Catra jumps, claws readied, and swipes them across Scorpia's face. She doesn't hit her eye ~~-~~too bad ~~-~~but she definitely leaves a mark. One foot comes to a momentary rest on Scorpia's head before she jumps into the air, eying the three soldiers below her. Nope, not dealing with that. She turns the sword as she lands right in front of them, slamming the tip of the blade through the ground. The shockwaves send all three tumbling back with familiar yells.

"We have *got* to stop meeting like this," she said with a smirk as she straightened up, turning to find Scorpia. The woman is trying to nurse her wounded cheek with a pincer. She readies the sword again and runs at Scorpia, who barely has time to raise her pincers in self defense. Catra swings again, trying to find an opening, but the pincers are large. She can't get a sword through.

Is there exoskeleton under the shirt?

Only one way to find out. She clenches her fist and ducks under Scorpia, hitting her right in the stomach. There is *not* exoskeleton, it

turns out, but there *is* muscle. Catra can *feel* the individual bones in her fingers cracking while Scorpia doubles over, groaning. She hears movement behind her and whirls just in time to block a green blast of energy withthe flat of the blade.

"Cheap shot, Bonnie," she calls. "What kind of coward fires at an opponent with their back turned?"

Bonnie undoes the latches on her helmet, tossing it away , glaring at Catra. "No worse than the coward who hides behind a sword."

Catra scoffs. "Who' s hiding? I dont need this thing to take *you*."

"Easy , Catra." Bonnie' s tone is almost condescending. "Adora' s not here to protect you anymore."

Something dark flashes in Catra's expression, the fury momentarily robbing the air from her lungs. She changes the sword into a bracer, letting it latch around her arm, then leaps forward. She's always been too fast for Bonnie – too fast for any normal person to really keep up with. There's a satisfying *crack* under her knuckles as she slugs Bonnie' s cheek. Rogelio dives to keep her upright as she stumbles.

"Like I was saying," Catra growls. "I *don't* need the sword, and I *don't* need Adora."

"W ait!"

Catra jerks around to look at Kyle, who' s hurriedly taken his own helmet off. "I know it' s a war, I get it, but we used to be a team," he says desperately. "Doesnt that mean anything?"

Seriously Kyle? Stupid, sentimental…

"Unbelievable," Catra mutters, backing up. She' s done enough damage, she supposes. The Horde wont be able to reclaim this

place now. She takes to the roofs, then the trees, and disappears into the woods.

The adrenaline fades quickly. Catra wavers when she lands, nearly falling off the branch. She knows she'll heal when she changes back. But she also knows the full-on exhaustion will hit her like a fucking tank. And she's too far from Bright Moon to risk passing out.

Her body has other plans, unfortunately. She makes it a few miles before she tumbles to the ground, groaning, and feels She-Ra slip away. Black spots were blooming in her gaze. She lets out a shaky breath, rolling onto her back. Fine. Whatever.

The world goes black.

A pleasant, tuneless humming beckons Catra back to consciousness. She lifts her head, blinking blearily, trying to bring the world back into focus. "Ah, kitty!" Razz says happily. "You're awake!"

"Fuck," Catra mumbles, pushing herself up on her elbows and rubbing her head. "What. How did you get me back here?"

"I may be old, but I'm not weak, dearie!" the old woman half sings. Catra stares at her, flexing her fingers unconsciously. They're stiff, and they hurt, but it's better than them being broken.

"Sure. Okay." She hauls her legs over the edge of the bed, standing slowly. Wobbly, but she'll make it back to Bright Moon. "Thanks for the help."

"Are you not staying for pie?"

"Not really in the mood," Catra mutters, walking toward the door. "Maybe some other time."

She's almost out the door when the reedy voice stops her. "Catra."

She turns, mostly in surprise. Razz almost never uses her actual name. She's not expecting the broom that comes down on her head.

"Ow! What the hell—"

"You need to get out of your head, kitty." Razz's voice is serious in a way Catra's not used to hearing. "Before you make mistakes you'll regret."

Catra clenches her fist, biting the inside of her cheek. "It's a little late for *that*, isn't it?" She barely restrains herself from snarling. "Where were you four months ago?"

"And how much longer are you going to live in the past?"

That's rich, coming from someone who literally lives in the past sometimes. And the future. Anywhere but the present, it seems. Lucky her.

"What are you, Angella?" Catra snaps, stepping away. "Just…leave me alone."

"If I left you alone, you'd still be unconscious in the woods."

That does it. Catra hates when Razz makes sense. She storms out without another word, smoothing her hair back and letting out a frustrated growl. Why does *everyone* have to tell her what to fucking do? *Go back to Mystacor to see the healer, stop putting yourself in danger, move on*…

She makes it back to Bright Moon fairly fast, and is just inside the entrance hall when she hears a shimmer of sparkles and Glimmer saying, "Catra!"

At least she doesn't teleport them, Catra thinks as Glimmer and Bow both hug her tight.

"Where've you been?"

“We were worried!”

She doesn't answer – can't answer , because she knows they'll both be upset and Angella will be pissed off if they find out what she was doing. So she just relaxes into their arms, sighing, and letting go of the anger for just a little while.

“Out for a walk.”

Chapter End Notes

Reviews are natural nutrition for wild writers and a good way to support a writer's environment

Consequences

Chapter Summary

I don’t need the Rebellion. I can do this on my own.

The sword transforms into a staff;she uses it to knock out a few dumbasses who try to attack her, then runs it through another bot before turning it back to a sword to ward off a couple more soldiers. She can do this on her own. She doesnt need the Rebellion.

She doesnt need *anyone*.

The sound of another machine whirring to life draws her attention;she whips around to see a cannon pointing right at her, just a few feet away . Where did *that* come from?

There’s no time to dodge. Catra quickly changes the sword into a shield, using it block the bright blast of green energy. The force of it throws her back, right through a house, and *fuck* that hurts. Bits of wood and glass slice through her skin, tangling in her hair. She shakes it off as she pushes herself onto her knees, finding the shield just in time to see another blast of energy barreling down on her.

This time there’s no hope of blocking.

Chapter Notes

Yes the chapter count keeps changing. So does my outline. The entire story will be somewhere between 18 and 20 chapters. I'm figuring it out

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Everything *hurts*. But it feels good.

Catra hasn't been sleeping well, and it turns out ambushing Horde-controlled village in the dead of night is a great way to catch them off guard and drive them off. There's still resistance, of course, but no one is really a match for She-Ra.

She falls into bed as the sky begins to lighten, signaling the start of a new day. Maybe she can get a couple hours of sleep before someone comes looking for her. There aren't any missions planned, as far as she knows, and she really does need to try and get a little sleep. Even she can acknowledge when something is starting to get unhealthy.

A knock at her door shatters all thoughts of sleep. "Are you fucking kidding," Catra growls as she sits up, storming to the door and flinging it open. The poor guard is startled by the death glare he gets. "What?"

"The...Then queen wishes to speak with you."

Well fuck. There's no way that's going to end well. Catra slips passed the guard, closing her door and making her way to the war room. Angella is sitting over the table, examining the map.

"Catra," she greets the young woman quietly. "Please, sit."

Catra takes her usual seat, arms resting on the edge of the table. "We've received word of several Horde-occupied villages recently being liberated. Oddly, they all seem to think She-Ra was there."

She has no reason to hide, she decides, straightening up. "And? It's a war. I'm trying to win it."

"By sneaking off alone to fight?" Angella counters. "What if you were hurt, or captured?"

"I'm sure Glimmer would love to organize a *third* rescue mission to the Fright Zone."

"I'm being serious, Catra."

"So am I." Catra stands, annoyed. She's missing sleep for *this*? "I'm doing *fine* on my own, aren't I? I've driven the Horde out of like, four villages. Last time I checked, that was the *point* of all this. I'm not going to apologize for doing what I'm supposed to do."

She turns on her heels and starts to walk out.

"I didn't say you could leave."

Catra freezes in the door, whirling to look at Angella, who's regarding her with a stern but neutral expression. "Do I need your permission to *move* now?" she asks bitterly.

Angella's expression doesn't change. "Catra, I'm trying to be understanding—"

"I don't need your pity," she snaps, recoiling slightly at the thought.

"I'm not *pitying* you," Angella corrects in the same voice she uses right before she and Glimmer start yelling at each other. Catra knows that tone well. "I know that you are hurting—"

"Then why can't you just let me do what I'm supposed to do?"

"Because what you're *doing* now is endangering everyone around you," the queen responds. "You're running into fights without plans, running into fights you know you can't win—"

"I'm *trying* to win this war!" Catra shoots back icily. "You know, that thing you *haven't* been doing for years!"

Angella stands abruptly, and Catra notes that she should feel afraid, and certainly be sorry for saying that. But she's already looked death in its masked face as it played with her the way a cat played with a mouse. Nothing is scarier than that.

"I've been giving you space because I know you handle things differently. But I will *not* tolerate this behavior from a Rebellion soldier." Her voice is cold, absolutely unlike her . And Catra remembers that she *has* been the queen of Bright Moon for so long for a reason. "If you're compromised, then you have no place on the battlefield."

"Then maybe I don't have to be your fucking soldier anymore!" Catra snarls. "I can fight the Horde without your help. I'd probably be better off without having to worry about protecting any of you!"

She whirls on her heel, storming to the door. "Where do you think you're going?" Angella demands.

"Literally anywhere else. Unless you have to authorize *that*, too?"

It doesn't actually matter , since she continues walking, slamming through the doors and nearly knocking over Bow and Glimmer. She shaking, her fingers twitching, curling and uncurling, breathing carefully controlled despite the anger threatening to take hold and drown her. She thinks she hears Glimmer calling after her, and Bow telling her to let Catra go. Good. Catra isn't in the mood.

Who does she think she is? Ordering me around like I'm nothing, like she's… Shadow Weaver or something! I don't need her, or Glimmer , or Bow, or anyone!

Maybe she can tell herself that enough to start believing it.

The Crystal Palace is creepy and dark, and Glimmer does *not* like it. Part of her knows trying to talk to Light Hope is questionable at best. But things are getting worse. *Catra* is getting worse. And Light Hope was around for the first portal. Maybe she can help.

Glimmer hopes she can help.

She steps into a large atrium, looking around. "Um...hello?" she calls uncertainly. "Light Hope?"

Nothing. Glimmer frowns, thinking about the elemental they had fought at the library. Catra said it had been activated by a password. "Eternia?" she tries. Nothing. "She-Ra?" "For the honor of Grayskull?"

Nothing.

"Come on, I know you can hear me!" She summons her staff, frustrated. "Just listen!"

A voice echoes through the room. "Unauthorized presence detected. Security protocol activated."

The room turns red, spiders descending up on her. Glimmer grimaces, taking a step back, gathering magic in her hand. "Fine. You're not getting rid of me that easily."

Catra's not sure how far she's walked before the anger finally starts to drain. Her ears droop, her entire body going slack. *Fuck*. She had said terrible things to Angella, and then just *walked out*. What the hell is wrong with her?

She stops, running a hand through her hair and sighing. She should go back. She should apologize. She should—

Screams echo through the air. Her ears twitch, head swiveling around. Mechanical sounds join the screams—bots. Guns being fired. Soldiers shouting.

Great. Fucking great.

She summons the sword, raising it over her head as she shouts, "For the honor of Grayskull!"

Smoke is rising into the air by the time she closes in on the village. Both hands close around the hilt of the sword as she launches herself into the village, slicing cleanly through the closest bot. She rebounds off that bot, landing on a tank and running it through, driving the soldiers out right before it explodes. A few villagers are yelling her praises while soldiers call to each other, trying to form a new plan. Catra smiles grimly.

I don't need the Rebellion. I can do this on my own.

The sword transforms into a staff;she uses it to knock out a few dumbasses who try to attack her, then runs it through another bot before turning it back to a sword to ward off a couple more soldiers. She can do this on her own. She doesnt need the Rebellion.

She doesnt need *anyone*.

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This time there's no hope of blocking.

It feels like fire burning through her body, consuming her blood and igniting every nerve ending. It's worse than any of the times Shadow Weaver had hurt her, and that's saying a *lot*. She swears she can feel it cracking her bones, and for a moment she blacks out.

She comes to again a moment later, vision wavering. The sounds around her are dulled, like someone has stuffed cotton in her ears.

She's transformed back, she realizes blearily, the sword discarded a few feet away. Soldiers are closing in around her.

"Not so threatening now, is she?" one says with a chuckle. A boot comes down on her tail; she screams in pain, trying to recoil, but her tail is pinned to the ground.

"Get *off*," she snarls, whipping her claws to slice at the ankle of the foot holding her down. The soldier howls, stumbling back, but Catra only gets a moment of satisfaction before a foot connects with her chest, knocking the air out of her lungs. She collapses, coughing, vision flickering. *Fuck*. She blinks heavily, seeing a gun leveled with her face…

And then it's gone, the soldier shouting as something knocks him away. Catra turns her head sluggishly, just in time to see two more nets take down the other soldiers around her, and a gust of wind wiping out the cannon and remaining bots.

"Yikes, kitty. Having a bad day?" Netossa is kneeling over her, trying to look gentle and placating without worrying Catra. Catra grimaces, staring up at her without quite *seeing* her. Everything feels slow and out of sync.

"She okay?" Spinnerella calls from the air, waving a hand to take out another tank and send the rest of the soldiers running.

"Not sure," Netossa calls back, gently tapping Catra's cheek to get her attention. "Here, try and follow my finger without moving your head."

Catra groans, shoving Netossa's hand away and pushing herself up unsteadily. "I'm *fine*"—

She almost immediately pitches forward again, head pounding. *Fuck*. Usually she heals before she transforms back, but apparently getting blasted by a cannon isn't something she could easily heal from. *Figures*.

Netossa catches her before she falls over. "Yeah, so back to my thing. Finger. Follow."

Catra hisses weakly, but does as she's told. Spinnerella lands next to them, kneeling on Catra's other side. "How'd you end up here alone? Where are Bow and Glimmer?"

"I have a life outside of them," Catra grumbles, trying to push herself up. She's surprised when she staggers, tripping into Netossa's waiting arms.

"Hey, be *careful*. You don't know if anything is broken."

"I'm fine." Catra shakes her head slowly. "One of the bastards stepped on my tail."

Netossa and Spinnerella exchange wide-eyed looks. "Is that bad?" Spinerella asks, concerned.

"It's like... I dunno, having a broken toe." Catra pulls away from Netossa, testing her balance. "It's happened before, it'll be fine. Need someone to check it out and set it, though."

"Let's get you back to Bright Moon, then. I'm sure someone can help there." Netossa takes Catra by the arm, ready to drag her off back toward Bright Moon. She plants her feet into the ground, though, refusing to move. Netossa raises an eyebrow, folding her arms. "Okay, you're being weirder than usual. What's wrong?"

"Nothing." The wives give her unimpressed looks. "I... got into a fight with Queen Angella. It got nasty. I said some pretty terrible things."

"And what, you think she's going to be mad at you?"

"No, I think I don't deserve to go back there. Or be She-Ra. Haven't I fucked everything up enough?"

Netossa sighs, leaning Catra against a tree while Spinnerella steps aside. "Look, Catra. I'm gonna level with you. Almost no one thinks they *deserve* the power they have. I mean, *I* know I'm pretty bad ass, and Spinny's comfortable with herself. But like, Perfuma? She's terrified of her own powers. Glimmer? Constantly feels pressured and insecure and stuck in her mother's shadow and like she'll never be good enough. Even Queen Angella worries she's not good enough for her position sometimes. Everyone is scared of their power at some point or another. But you gotta learn to move passed it, or you really are going to be stuck in the same spot forever."

Spinerella returns, smiling, and holds out the sword for Catra. She stares at it for a long moment before nodding and taking it. "Wait. How do you know all of that?"

"Oh, I've made it my life's mission to catalog each and every weakness of the Alliance members, just in case we ever turn on each other." Catra is pretty sure she isn't kidding. "Now, can we *please* take you back to the castle so someone can take care of your tail before they have to like, chop it off or something?"

"Chop my — *no one is chopping my tail off!*"

Glimmer blasts down another spider, breathing heavily. "Are you gonna send more spiders for me to destroy, or are you gonna talk to me? I'm not your enemy. I just want... I want to know more about Mara. About the portal. I know you know *something*. You're the one who told Catra about everything. I... I want to open a portal. I want to stop the war. There *has* to be something that can help."

There was a long pause. "Temporary administrator access granted to Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon." A door slides open nearby. Glimmer stares at it, surprised. "Princess Glimmer, proceed."

Okay, then. She smiles, walking through the door. This isn't the best idea, she knows. But it's the only idea she has. Light Hope *must*

know something. There's a room at the end of the hall; she steps into it, taking a deep breath. "Light Hope?"

An angry voice speaks from behind her. "The Crystal Castle is intended only for She-Ra and her steed. You are trespassing."

Glimmer jumps, stumbling back; she pauses to try and collect herself, staring at the hologram. "I—wait, *steed*? Catra is supposed to have a *steed*?" They had all dodged a bullet with that one, she thinks. "I...I know I'm not supposed to be here, but this is *for* She-Ra. She needs help. That has to count for something."

There's a moment of silence as Light Hope considers her, then glitches slightly before speaking again. "Despite my best efforts, Catra has been compromised," she says finally.

"She's hurting," Glimmer insists.

"Her feelings have no place in She-Ra's mission."

"She'll be able to focus again if we help her," Glimmer says. "And the best way to help her is to bring Adora back. All of this started after the portal." Well, that's not entirely true, she thinks. Catra's always been hovering an invisible edge. Losing Adora sent her over the edge. "There has to be *something* we can do. Something you know that can help."

Another long pause follows as Light Hope considers. "You are willing to do whatever it takes?" she finally asks. Glimmer blows out a long breath, gnawing her lip for a moment. She hadn't been completely on-board with trusting Light Hope before, and she had told Catra as much, but they had similar goals at the moment—get Catra's head back on straight.

Glimmer holds herself tall, shoulders squared. "Yes."

The AI nods. "Are you familiar with the Heart of Etheria?"

"I don't think so, no," Glimmer says slowly.

"The Heart was created by the First Ones, meant to be a weapon. It contains enough power to safely open a portal and end this war once and for all."

Glimmer lights up. "*Really?* Why haven't you told Catra about it?"

"As I said before, Catra is compromised. Mara similarly allowed herself to be overcome by such emotions and fears, and the result was Etheria being trapped in the dimension. I could not risk Catra making a drastic decision as well." It's a little late for that, Glimmer thinks, remembering the portal. "She has made much progress with bringing order back to the planet." Light Hope holds out a hand, projecting an image of the planet and the moons. A light is shining in the center. "But she still has not succeeded in balancing Etheria. If the planet is not balanced, the Heart of Etheria can not be accessed."

The light grows brightly, then dies. It's similar to what Entrapta said, Glimmer thinks. She must be on the right track. "How do I balance the planet, then?"

"There is only one piece still missing." Lights begin to appear one after the other on the planet. "The princesses are conduits for the Heart's power." Lights begin to feed toward the center, bringing back the ball of energy. "They must all be connected to their Runestones for the Heart of Etheria to function."

"How does this help with opening a portal?"

"Part of the failure of the most recent portal attempt was Etheria's imbalance," Light Hope says. "I imagine the portal as a door that is crooked in its frame. Balancing the planet will correct the problem."

Glimmer blows out a long breath, nodding slowly. "And that will make us stronger?"

"It will give you power like you've never known." The idea makes Glimmer smile. They can open a portal. They can rescue Adora. And they can wipe out the Horde once and for all. Two birds, one stone. "The final piece is a princess who has not yet accepted her destiny. A princess robbed of her power by the Horde's meddling."

Scorpia," Glimmer guesses. Light Hope nods.

"She will need to bond with her Runestone in order to make all of this work."

"I can do that," Glimmer says after a moment. Light Hope's smile is almost kind. Almost.

"Good."

Tail chopping is, thankfully, not required, although she does end up with a thick and heavy bandage that makes her tail feel like it weighs an extra few pounds. She also ends up with various other bandages along her body from the scrapes and bruises that hadn't healed when she changed back.

"Thank you for helping her," Glimmer is saying outside the infirmary while Bow tries to peek in and see how Catra is doing. The princess had returned just in time to see Netossa and Spinnerella half carrying Catra through the front gate.

"Nothing to thank us for," Netossa assures her. "That's what we're for, right? We help each other."

"It sounds like things have been a bit rough around here," Spinnerella adds quietly. Glimmer sighs, rubbing the back of her neck.

"She hasn't been doing well since Adora... you know. But she won't *talk* to us about it, either. She's just getting really stupidly self-destructive."

"Noticed that," Netossa says dryly. "She shouldn't have gone into that village without at least calling for backup. She was completely outnumbered. Does she need some sense knocked into her?"

"Maybe," Glimmer admits. "Not today, though. I think she's taken enough of a beating for the lesson to at least make some impression."

"Also beating her up probably isn't the *best* way to handle a delicate situation," Spinnerella reminds Netossa with a small smile. Netossa groans.

"I *know*, I know. I wouldn't *really* beat her up."

They mostly believe that.

She's avoiding Micah's mural. That's probably for the best, really, considering what she'd said to Angella. She knows she was out of line, and she *does* regret the words. Apologizing has never come easy to her, though.

Still, sitting around her room and thinking about her damaged tail is driving her nuts. So she wanders out of her room, finding a nice balcony in the halls to sit on and watch the sky.

"Catra."

The voice is neutral, but not flat. Catra's tail twitches as she looks up, meeting Angella's gaze. "Your majesty," she mumbles respectfully, looking back at the sky.

"I like to think we haven't rewound that far," Angella says dryly, standing beside the rail and following Catra's gaze. "Something interesting?"

Catra shakes her head. "Did you ever see the stars?"

"I'm not quite that old. I've heard they were beautiful, though."

"That's what Razz says." It's probably about the *only* coherent thing Razz has ever said, Catra thinks. "And Bow's dads showed us a projection of them once."

"I would like to meet them some time," Angella says slowly. "But I'm guessing you don't want to talk about stars or Bow's fathers."

"No," Catra admits. "But it's easier to talk about."

Angella doesn't respond. Catra knows it's on her to keep going, to fix this. She's been struggling with trying to figure out the words all day. "I shouldn't have said what I said," she finally murmurs, eyes falling to stare at the forest below them. "It was out of line."

"Did you mean it?"

That catches Catra by surprise. She looks up, blinking a few times, frowning. "What?"

"Did you mean it?" Angella repeats patiently, as if Catra doesn't sound like a complete moron.

"Which part?"

"That you'd be better off fighting without the Rebellion."

Catra curls in on herself, closing her eyes and sighing inwardly. "Maybe the Rebellion is better off without *me*."

"That's not what I'm asking." Angella's voice is firm, but not cold or angry. "I told you when you first came here that you would not be punished for speaking your mind, even if I don't like what you have to say. That freedom comes with consequences on your part, however. You still have to take responsibility for your words."

Honestly, it would be easier if Angella would just smack her and get it over with. Catra winces even as she has the thought. She really is

completely and utterly fucked up, isn't she? Maybe I meant it at the time," she mutters finally , wincing as her tails tries to shift. "But I know I'm wrong. I'd be dead if Netossa and Spinnerella hadn't shown up."

"I'm glad you still have enough common sense to recognize that."

"Ow blow . But Catra deserves it. "I didn't mean what I said about you," she continues after a moment. "You've still been fighting the Horde this entire time, even if it's just been holding the ground you had. It's better than nothing."

Angella lets out a low, humorless laugh. "I wouldn't go that far . I've shirked by responsibilities as the Rebellion leader for too long. It took seeing you hurt and Adora sacrificing herself to make me realize how far I had fallen. And I apologize for that."

"It's not"—

"I must take responsibility for my words and actions as well. Being queen does not exempt me from basic decency ."A gentle hand rests on Catra's shoulder. She looks up, surprised to find Angella watching her with sad, tear-filled eyes even as a gentle smile graces her lips. A lump rises in Catra's throat, forcing her to look away before she starts crying as well.

"It's. It's fine."

They sit in silence for a moment, recovering from the emotionally charged conversation. Angella finally let's Catra's shoulder go, saying, "I have something for you, if you'd like. But I'm afraid you'll have to tolerate my company for a few minutes longer."

Catra looks up, surprised. "Huh?" She blinks rapidly , catching up with what Angella said. "I mean, I. Yeah. Sure."

She slides off the railing, following Angella through the halls. They don't talk—it's a surprisingly comfortable silence, all things

considered. Catra tries to focus on where they're going;she has a feeling she's being led to a part of the castle that doesn't get much use.

"This isn't one of those they'll never hear you scream' things, is it?"

Angella rolls her eyes, smiling fondly. "No, Catra."

"Y ou sure? Because I definitely feel like I'm walking into that territory."…

They stop outside a door;Angella produces a key from her robes, opening the door, and stepping aside to allow Catra in first.

The room is surprisingly dark, compared to the rest of the Bright Moon, which is always lit by the Runestone. She assumes the lack of windows has something to do with that. The walls are lit by small balls of magic, which brighten when Catra steps inside, illuminating a golden-lined mural on the wall opposite the door.

It's Adora. Catra's mind takes a frustratingly long moment to put the pieces together, to figure out the outline etched into the wall before her. It's the stupid, stupid ponytail that finally puts it in perspective.

"I've always found comfort in having a piece of Micah with me, small as it may be,"Angella explains as Catra steps closer , reaching a shaking hand out. "No one knows this is here aside from myself and the people who made it, and they've been sworn to secrecy ."

"Why?"…

"Because she deserves to be remembered. And you deserve somewhere private to remember her."

Catra stares at the mural for a long moment before slowly backing up and leaning against the opposite wall, sliding to the floor. Angella kneels to leave the key beside her, resting a hand on her head for a moment.

“You don’t have to suffer alone, Catra. Please remember that.”

She steps out, closing the door behind her. Catra looks at the door, then back up at the mural…and smiles faintly despite herself.

“Hey, Adora.”

Chapter End Notes

> I know a few people want a public mural for Adora, but this felt more appropriate - Catra doesn't want to openly grieve, and Adora never wanted to be a hero or be remembered as one. The room is a place for them, and anyone Catra is okay bringing there and sharing it with.

Interlude III

Chapter Summary

In a simpler world where things are less complicated...

Chapter Notes

Updating today because I've got a lot to do tomorrow (one dog has grooming, another has surgery (he should be fine)), so have some cute, totally uncomplicated fluff a day early.

"*Their ears*."

Adora is almost afraid to touch the little bundle of fur in her arms. They're so *small*, with a tiny, twitching nose and a puff of blonde hair hiding the smallest ears Adora has ever seen.

"You're crying," Catra teases. She's lying beside Adora, watching her wife and newborn through heavily lidded eyes. Finn had, of course, chosen the day the *entire* Alliance was visiting to be born, after a very hard eight and a half months of pregnancy and nearly thirty-five hours of labor. It's extremely likely they'll be an only child, unless Adora changes her mind about carrying, because Catra had declared several times in the last day alone that she would *never* do this again.

"Everything is just so small!"

"They did *not* feel small twelve hours ago." Catra scoots closer, partially to rest her head in Adora's lap and partially to be within touching distance of Finn. She hasn't been awake much since the midwife had left them, but every second she was conscious *had* to be spent in contact with Finn. Cyra assures her that it's normal, and Lyra had been the same way. It's an instinct.

"Do you want to hold them?" Adora asks. Catra takes a moment to assess herself before slowly sitting up, wincing. Yeah, none of this has done anything to endear Adora to the idea of pregnancy.

"Please."

Finn whimpers, clearly unhappy, in the brief moment it takes to be transferred from one set of arms to the other, but they settle the moment Catra's familiar scent wraps around them. She kisses their little forehead, and laughs when a set of claws reach up to brush her face. "Excuse me. That's rude." Not that she's *hurt* – the claws are more like pine needles. "Put those away, thank you very much."

She taps the little paw for emphasis. Adora does the same, grinning when the claws try to latch onto her. "They know me," she says, looking up at Catra and grinning. "Look, they know me!"

"Of course they know you, dummy," Catra says with fond exasperation. "You've been talking to them for nine months. And singing. *Badly*."

"I have a great voice, thank you very much," Adora said.

"Is this one of those supportive wife things where I should just nod and say of course you do?"

Adora would have shoved Catra, if she hadn't been holding their newborn. Instead she scoffs, rolling her eyes and turning away. "*Rude*."

"I swore I would never lie to you, Adora." There was a fake solemness in Catra's voice that almost made Adora laugh. "Even if it means hurting your feelings sometimes."

"Yeah, I'm sure you're completely broken up about telling me I have a terrible singing voice."

"I am, actually. It brings me no joy to hurt your feelings."

Adora rolls her eyes, nudging Catra gently. She knows her wife is still hurting. Not to mention not wanting to jostle Finn. "Somehow, I don't believe you."

"Really? But I'm such a great liar."

Finn yawns, distracting them both. It's such a big yawn for such a *tiny* little thing. Adora bites down a loud coo. "We made that," she whispers.

"Pretty sure I did most of the work."

She ignores that. "That's. That's ours. *They're* ours. Nine months ago they weren't even here and now…"

"Yes, Adora, that's how children work." Catra yawns, a thumb smoothing against Finn's forehead. She rests her head on Adora's shoulder, eyelids fluttering. "Take them?"

She's afraid of dropping them when she falls asleep. And it is definitely a *when*, not an if. Finn whimpers sharply, not enjoying being moved *again*, but they bury their nose in Adora's shirt and relax. Mother and child fall asleep, leaving Adora surrounded by small, rumbling purrs. She carefully slides to lie down, making sure everyone is covered and comfortable, before closing her eyes for a moment.

Everything is white and blank. The ground is rocky beneath her. She stares at the sky, and hears approaching footsteps. Footsteps? Here? That's impossible. She's alone. She's supposed to be alone here. How—?

A figure leans over to stare down at her. The face is familiar, but not — white hair instead of blue, green eyes instead of red, draped in white cloth instead of gray armor.

It blinks, and white pupils fill the green void, a cruel smile pulling at its lips.

“*Now what is this?*

Adora yelps, jerking upright, disturbing her wife and child in one go. Catra makes a confused, high-pitched *merrrrp* noise while Finn goes the simpler route and screams.

“Adora?” Catra’s voice is heavy with exhaustion, and Adora feels terrible. The last two days have been draining for her, and now Adora’s interrupting the precious rest she needs. “S’wrong?”

Finn is still shrieking. Adora tries to comfort them, but she’s still rattled, panic and adrenaline still running through her blood, and Finn can clearly feel it.

“Here, let me,” Catra says with a yawn, reaching out to take the unsettled infant. Adora relents despite her need to *fix this*, and lets Catra have them. She collapses against the headboard, still half asleep, and begins trilling and chirping, offering comfort in the way only a magicat could, ignoring the little claws that hit her face. Finn calms after a few minutes, purring slightly, and nuzzles into Catra, eyes fluttering as they fight sleep, but ultimately give in. Catra adjusts herself to reach over and brush a hand against Adora’s arm.

“What’s wrong?”

Adora shakes her head, leaning back to look to rest against the headboard with Catra. “Nothing. I had a bad dream. Im so sorry I woke you both.”

“S’okay.” Catra’s head slid to rest against Adora’s shoulder, fighting sleep just as Finn had moments before. “Tell me what happened.”

“I..I’m not sure,” she admits. “I was..somewhere. Trapped. And there was something standing over me. I dont know. It’s all a blur now. It’s stupid.”

“Not stupid,” Catra mumbles. “Just a bad dream. You’re okay.”

Adora sighs, relieved now, and kisses the top of Catra’s head.

“Yeah. Im okay.”

Secrets in the Shadows

Chapter Summary

Catra learns some unpleasant truths.

Glimmer makes some bad choices.

No one is okay.

Chapter Notes

Final stretch! Who's ready?

Everything is loud. People are yelling, screaming in pain. Someone is trying to sweep her away, but they're knocked back, and she falls to the ground, tears filling her eyes. What's going on?

"You're *the one the mask has chosen?*"

She looks up at the figure hovering over her. Dark hair spills down over red robes; a mask blocks the woman's face. She's scary. Catra whimpers, her tail puffing up, her fur standing on end.

"*Shush, child," the woman says, clearly irritated, as she easily picks her up. "If you're useful, I might keep you."*

Catra's eyes snap open, a gasp escaping in a forced huff. She's had random dreams about Half Moon ever since finding the underground kingdom. This is the first time she's dreamed of Shadow Weaver finding her, though. Somehow, the witch is even more terrifying in *that* memory than she is any of the other ones from Catra's childhood.

And that's saying a lot.

"*I can go anywhere*!"

Catra startles and falls out of bed, landing in an ungraceful heap and groaning. "What?" She looks up to see Glimmer standing over her, practically bouncing for joy.

"So I've been working on my magic, right? And Mom's given me more access to the Moonstone. And I can — *look*!"

"Wait, Sparkles, nononononono—"

Too late. Glimmer grabs Catra's arm and they appear in a large, *cold* dining room. Catra groans. "Sparkles—"

"Glimmer?" Frosta is understandably confused about why they've appeared in the middle of breakfast. "Catra? What's going on? Why are you in your pajamas?"

"I can teleport!" Glimmer says happily, squeezing Catra's arms. And they're back in Catra's bedroom. At least it's warm.

"*Glimmer*." Catra slumps over onto the floor, closing her eyes. "What've I told you about early-morning teleporting?"

"Make sure you don't eat breakfast first."

Okay, that's fair. Catra still glares at her. "So what happened?"

"Oh, right, so Mom kind of... I'm not sure how it works, but basically she shared more of the Moonstone's power with me, and I'm *so* much stronger now! It's amazing! Wanna see where else I can go?"

"No!" Catra says loudly, rearing back. "I believe you, you can teleport to the moons and back." Glimmer's eyes light up. "Do *not* teleport to the moons. And don't take me with you if you try."

Glimmer looks disappointed. Catra does *not* care. She crawls back into bed, yanking the covers over her head. She's not going back to sleep, she's just hoping Glimmer will get the hint and leave. She does, thankfully. Catra takes a deep breath — then frowns, sitting up. Something feels wrong. Like something's changed about

Glimmer's magic. The familiar, almost fluffy sensation of the energy feels as if it's been pierced by something sharp.

She shakes her head and climbs out of bed, setting about to get ready for the day. She's over-thinking. Being paranoid. It's nothing, she's sure.

Silence fills the room. Catra looks at the chairs beside her. The empty chairs. The weirdly empty chairs. "Has anyone seen my daughter?" Angella asks patiently.

"Not since she teleported me out of bed this morning," Catra mutters, looking at Frosta for a second.

"Is that what that was?" Frosta asks, tilting her head.

"Yeah. Great, right?"

Bow slips into the room, coughing when all eyes turn to him. "Uh, hey. Glimmer's busy. Prior commitment. She said start without her, and she'll be here in a few."

Prior commitment? Catra isn't the only one who's skeptical about that; she looks around the room to see eyebrows raising and looks being exchanged. But Angella simply nods and begins the meeting. Bow takes his usual seat, determinedly looking at the ceiling and *not* at anyone else. Especially not Catra.

He's really bad at this.

Glimmer misses the meeting, which is *weird*. It's even weirder when Bow won't look Catra in the eye and help her figure out where Glimmer *is*.

"Maybe she's just taking a nap?" he suggests weakly as he follows Catra down the hall. The weirder he acts, the more determined she is to find Glimmer and figure out what the hell is going on.

"How are *you* of all people not worried? This is *Glimmer*. She wouldn't miss a meeting even if she was half dead."

Bow hesitates, rubbing the back of his neck. "I know, but... look, we've all been working hard lately. Maybe she just needs a break. Maybe you should take one too."

"Pass." She's picked up Glimmer's scent, but it's mixed with something else. Something... wrong. Something Catra can't quite put her finger on. "Why won't you tell me what's going on?"

"I... um"...

They stop outside a door. If Catra had been paying attention, she would have already known what's on the other side, and she would be far, far away from here in the time it took Bow to blink. But she's too caught up in Bow's stuttering and her own curiosity to notice her surroundings. She opens the door.

"Hey, Sparkles, why'd you"—

She stops dead. Glimmer is staring at her, wide-eyed... standing beside Shadow Weaver. "Didn't anyone ever teach you how to knock?" the sorceress asks carelessly, as if she's not aware of the sudden tension in the room. Catra clenches her fists for a moment before uncurling her fingers and unsheathing her claws.

"Wait!"

Glimmer quickly teleports across the room, both hands landing on Catra's shoulders. Her eyes are wide. Desperate. "Just... just let me explain, please"—

"Explain *what*?" How can she possibly explain this? What justification can there *be*?

She finally places the smell that had put her off that morning. It's magic. Not just Glimmer's magic. There's a faint hint of something

else in the air. Something dark that doesn't belong. Something that's haunted Catra from the shadows for her entire life. Something she knows *very* well.

She shoves Glimmer away and turns, sprinting down the hall. "You'd think she'd get tired of running away," Shadow Weaver says, shaking her head. Glimmer glares at her, then steps out into the hall and slams the door shut, re-locking it.

Glimmer and Bow appear right in front of Catra, who barely manages to stop before running into them.

"Please," Glimmer says desperately. "Please just listen to me, it's not what you think"—

"You have no idea what I'm thinking," Catra snarls, recoiling from Glimmer. She already knows the answer to her next question, but she needs to say the words, to hear the answer. Needs to hear Glimmer say it. "What the hell are you doing with *her*?"

"She's. She's been teaching me magic," Glimmer admits, shoulders hunched. The furious fire in Catra's chest is replaced with a ball of freezing ice.

"She's been *what*?"

Catra's voice is lower now. Calmer. Glimmer swallows, readying herself for the inevitable. "I needed to learn faster than Aunt Casta was willing to teach me, and"—

"And you decided to make a deal with an actual monster?" Still low. Still calm. Still dangerous.

"She hasn't taught me anything *bad*."

"Oh, I feel *so* much better then!" That had probably been the wrong way to go about it, Glimmer has to admit. "As long as she's not teaching you anything *bad*"—

"I don't like it, either!" Glimmer insists. "But she's the best resource we have—"

"Shadow Weaver doesn't do anything for nothing," Catra snaps. "She's going to hold this over you, she's going to ask for things in return, and you're going to be too fucking weak to say no to her—"

"Excuse me?"

Bow holds up his hands, trying to get between the girls. "Okay, let's maybe step back and—"

"*No*," Glimmer half growls, shoving him out of the way. "I want to hear what Catra has to say."

"I *said* you're too weak to say no to her," Catra repeats icily. "You can barely argue with your *mother*, but you think you can handle Shadow Weaver? Give me a break."

"How—You—What do you know?!" Glimmer yells, voice bouncing off the walls. "All you've done for months is sulk about your own bad choices! *I'm* doing what I have to do to end this war! Maybe I wouldn't need to learn fast if you were just better at being She-Ra!"

Catra visibly reels back, her entire body seeming to fold in on itself. She can vaguely hear Bow yelling at Glimmer, can see the look of horror on Glimmer's face, as if her own words have surprised her, but it doesn't matter. None of it matters.

"*I wouldn't be here at all if you could manage to be a more competent hero.*"

"*And yet, Adora's made more progress as a force captain than you can with magic on your side*."

She straightens up, uncurling her fingers, and meets Glimmer's gaze. "Good to know how you really feel." Her voice is flat, devoid of

any emotion. "You should get back to your magic lesson. Gotta learn everything you can, right? To make up for me being a *bad She-Ra*."

"N-No, I—Catra—"

Bow rests a hand on Glimmer's shoulder, watching Catra walk away. "Maybe give her some time to cool off," he suggests, frowning. "That got...bad."

"I didn't mean it." Glimmer's voice is small, shaking. "You know I didn't mean it...right?"

The slight hesitation before Bow speaks says everything Glimmer needs to know. "I...I don't know," he admits. "You've been different since Shadow Weaver started training you. Getting kind of obsessed with more power, and you're keeping secrets. And why would you even be thinking something like that if you didn't believe it? Or were you just trying to hurt her?"

"No!" Glimmer shakes her head furiously. "No, that's not it at all, I wouldn't...I love Catra, she's my best friend. Of course I don't want to hurt her."

"Then what just happened?" Bow asked softly. "Because I really don't know, Glimmer."

Glimmer's first reaction is annoyance—is Bow seriously *doubting her*? How could he? After everything they've been through?

Then she remembers the look at Catra's face, and the annoyance deflates a little. Of course he's doubting her. She'd just said possibly the meanest thing she could ever say to Catra. And *sorry* is definitely not going to cut it this time, Glimmer thinks gloomily, staring at the wall.

But it's for the best. Catra will understand. Will even be *happy* if it helps get Adora back and ends the war. All of this will pay off when everything works out. When they're all able to live in peace and be

happy. Shadow Weaver's crimes won't just be forgotten or forgiven. She's not going to be allowed to walk free. No one would allow it. And Glimmer is *not* going to give in to whatever Shadow Weaver thinks she can demand. She's not weak.

No matter what Catra says.

Berry picking sounds like a nice, chill activity. Spending a few hours finding berries with Razz seems like the perfect way to get her mind off things. Things like Glimmer and Shadow Weaver. Shadow Weaver *teaching Glimmer magic*. What the fuck?

"Mara!"

Get her mind off most things, at least.

"Sure." Catra sighs, brushing her hand through her hair. She doesn't even *look* like Mara. She'd thought maybe there would be some passing resemblance, but now she's seen the woman, and they definitely look nothing alike. How does Razz keep getting them mixed up? "We going berry picking?"

Razz practically lights up at the thought. "Absolutely! Get your basket!"

Catra picks up the basket, following the eager old lady out of the hut. "Hey, Razz?"

"Yes dearie?"

"Were you close to Mara?"

Silence. It's long enough that Catra starts to worry she offended the old lady. "I'm sorry, I didn't mean to—"

"She was so young." Razz's voice is wistful. "So full of hope. So patient with an old lady stealing sugar off her ship." Catra starts to

question that, then stops. It's not often Razz is this coherent about something. She needs to take advantage of it, which in this case means shutting up and letting Razz talk. "She was just like you. So unsure of herself, of her power. The First Ones were arrogant. They thought they could control She-Ra with the sword. But She-Ra is so much more than that."Catra raises a hand to her mask. "And more than that as well,"Razz adds, catching the gesture. "She-Ra is part of Etheria. All the First Ones and Magicats did was create a way to channel her powers."

"So they didn't create She-Ra?"Catra summarizes. She stops when she sees the First Ones' rune in front of them. Razz keeps walking, going straight inside. Catra starts to follow, then stops when something catches her eye from beneath an overgrown bush. She frowns, walking over, examining the cuts in the side of the building. "What the hell,"she mutters, tracing them. "Did Mara do this?"

She's not sure who she's asking, since Razz is out of earshot. Great, now she's talking to herself. She's about to back away when she notices a box, purposefully tucked away in the back of the bush. That's definitely something interesting.

"Oh good, you found it!"Razz says cheerfully , startling Catra.

"Found what? The box?"She picks it up, finding a place to dig her claws in and pry it open. "Was this left for me?"

"Yes, by Mara. She wants to talk to you."

That is somehow the most nonsensical thing Razz has ever said. "Mara wants to what?"Catra sputters, raising an eyebrow . She had been hoping for *simple*. Not this nonsense. "How —she's been dead for a thousand years!"

Razz isn't paying attention. Which is honestly no surprise, but Catra is still baffled by the entire exchange. She pries the box open and finds a large data chip inside. *She wants to talk to you*.

"I don't understand," she calls as she catches up to Razz.

"It *is* all rather complicated. And it depends on so many things happening just right." She chuckles. "So many things that could go *wrong*!"

"That isn't an answer," Catra says with a sigh. What is she, Entrapta? "I don't know why I expect anything from you."

"Oh hush now, dearie." Razz waves her off. "It'll all make sense when you talk to Mara."

"I *very* highly doubt that," Catra mutters. "Do you know anything about Light Hope?"

Razz scoffs. "Bah. Mara's unfriendly ghost. She's a tricky one. Mara always swore there was good in her, but I never saw it."

Catra narrows her eyes, filing that away for later. Razz may be a crazy old bat, but she doesn't trust Light Hope. And Razz, for all her faults, isn't usually wrong. "How can I talk to Mara?"

"With the pieces!"

Great. That definitely makes a ton of sense. "Razz, I don't understand *any* of this." Catra's ears droop as she speaks. She hates admitting the weakness, but Razz will likely forget in five minutes anyway. "Did Mara do the right thing? Who was she trying to protect Etheria from?"

"You've got it all wrong, dearie," Razz says in a sing-song voice. "It wasn't about protecting Etheria. She was protecting the rest of the universe *from* Etheria."

"What do you"—

They wanted to lure the great evil to Etheria, and use the planet as a weapon to destroy it. The sword, the mask, and the person who wielded them would be the key to that weapon.

Catra stops dead, eyes wide. Of course. *Of course*. How had she missed that? How caught up in her own head had she been to miss that detail? Fuck. *Fuck*, I'm an *idiot*!" She isn't really speaking to anyone in particular. Just yelling at the sky.

"What was that?" Razz calls over her shoulder. Catra covers her face, groaning.

"She brought the planet here so the First Ones couldn't use it to hurt anyone." Catra looks up, darting forward to grab Razz's arm. "I need to talk to Mara. Now."

Razz looks bewildered. "But we haven't finished the pie yet."

"Forget the stupid pie!" Catra cuts herself off, closing her eyes and taking a deep breath. She can't just keep yelling at Razz. It's never done her any good. "You're right," she says, slightly calmer. "Will you take me to see Mara after you finish the pie?"

"Absolutely. It's for her, after all!"

Nothing she says makes sense, ever. Catra isn't sure why she expected otherwise. "Sure. Okay."

It's been a long, weird few months, and Bow is happy to retreat to the underside of the console on Mara's old ship and just tinker. Catra's run off, and Glimmer is...well, Bow's not sure what Glimmer is doing. It's part of why he just needs to work on the ship. It's nice, mindless work. He's enjoying himself.

Until he looks out from under the console and sees a pair of wide eyes staring at him.

"You're not Mara!" a reedy voice screams.

He screams, jolting upright, and slams his head. "Ow!"

"For fuck's sake, old woman," a familiar voice gasps. Bow rolls out from under the console and sees Catra standing in the door of the room, leaning over, hands resting on her knees. "How do you even move that fast?"

"Catra, help me find Mara!" Razz demanded. "You know where she is!"

Bow slinks over to half hide behind Catra, blinking rapidly. "Who is that?" he whispers.

"Madame Razz," Catra replies without looking back at him. His eyes widen in wonder.

"*Oh*."

"Catra!" Razz grabs Catra's arm. "You need to talk to Mara! You have everything you need."

"Razz, I have no idea what you"—

Catra stops mid sentence, eyes going wide. She slides the disk she had found out of her pocket, then looks to the console. *Oh*. Of course this ship has more secrets. Doesn't everything? All the secrets, waiting for someone to unlock them.

"What are you doing?" Bow asks warily as Catra runs to the console and begins brushing her fingers against it, look for the slot.

"I know this, hang on." *There*. She slides the disk in, murmuring, "*She-Ra,*" and the console glows. She did it. *She did it*.

"*Catra?*"

Catra whirls, stunned, to see the hologram of Mara standing in front of the captain's chair. "How…does she"…

"*I know you're there. Razz said you would be there.*"

Catra looks at Razz, who is staring sadly at the hologram. This is… bizarre. She takes a few steps closer as Mara holds a hand out, and begins to return the gesture, but Mara falls back into the chair, holding her side and letting out a pained noise. Catra stops, surprised.

"*I don't have much time. I barely made it out. If you are seeing this, it means you are the new She-Ra. It means I failed.*" She smiles sadly . "*I tried so hard to stop it. The magicats tried so hard. I hope they're okay.*" She takes a deep breath. " *I don't know what they told you, but it wasn't all bad at first. We were the first ones to settle Etheria, to really study this planet's magic. How could it go so wrong?* A pause as she collects herself. "*You can't trust Light Hope. She's been reprogrammed to set off the weapon at any cost.*"

Catra's ears perk up, eyes wide. "*I didn't know what they were doing until too late. I knew they were rerouting Etheria's magic for their own purposes... siphoning it, collecting it in the planet's core…*"

"Rerouting the magic?" Bow repeats, frowning.

"For the weapon." Catra' s voice is flat. Bow doesnt dare try to interrupt again.

"*The Heart of Etheria Project. It was supposed to be an energy source, capable of so much good...but that's not what they made. My people turned our planet, all of Etheria, into a weapon. And She-Ra is the key.*"

After everything else, Catra cant say that really surprises her . She feels a stir of *something* in her chest – sadness, maybe? Regret? She's supposed to be a hero. That's what everyone keeps telling. And all along she's just been meant to destroy the planet. Chaos follows her wherever she goes.

"*The magicats tried to stop it by hiding the mask. They thought — they hoped it would make it too hard for She-Ra to channel the magic. But the Heart of Etheria belonged largely to the First Ones.*

They worked around it." Mara ducks her head, grunting in pain. Catra almost reaches out to her, until she remembers it's just a hologram. This has happened. Mara's already gone. "*I opened a portal to a completely empty dimension and pulled Etheria in. I hid us from the rest of the universe, to keep everyone safe. This is the one place they'll never find us. The weapon can't hurt anyone else here. I saw what they would do... the deaths that would follow... I couldn't stop them before, but I can now. Hiding is our only option. But*"—

The hologram shakes, momentarily distracting Mara. "*Catra… this isn't over. The Heart of Etheria is* still *siphoning magic, storing it. It's unstable. It will tear Etheria apart if it goes off again.*" She jumps, looking up for a moment, still holding her side. "*So it's up to you now. I couldn't stop it. In the end, I wasn't strong enough. But you have something I didn't. You'll be more powerful than they ever planned.*" Catra raises a hand slowly to the mask. Tears fill Mara's eyes. "*I believe in you, Catra. Even if you don't believe in yourself. You can do this. You can save the planet we love*."

The hologram blinks out of existence, leaving Catra and Bow to stare, stunned, at where it had been. Razz steps up to the chair, leaving the pie where the hologram had been. Catra turns away, staring out the window.

The entire planet was a mega weapon capable of something terrible enough that Mara had risked everything to drag it through to another dimension and keep it hidden from the rest of the universe. She had almost certainly died in the process. She *was* a hero.

How is Catra supposed to live up to that?

"Catra?"

She looks back to see Bow watching her, clearly worried. That's probably smart. She'd be worried too if she thought too much about the weight of the world resting on *her* shoulders.

"It's fine," she says, fingers curling into fists, tail lashing slightly. "I'll figure this out."

Somehow. She isn't sure how exactly, but somehow, she would figure this out. She would protect them, and Etheria. That's her job, after all.

"Have you spoken with the scorpion princess?"

Glimmer shakes her head, feeling weirdly like she's about to be scolded by her mother. If her mother were a large hologram created by an ancient race of people. "It's hard to get her alone at the Fright Zone. Besides, Entrapta isn't ready yet."

Light Hope doesn't look particularly impressed with her excuses. "We mustn't waste any time—"

"I *know*. I know, okay? But we can't… *I* can't rush." Bad things happen when Glimmer runs in without a plan. She needs to do better. She needs to be better. She needs to be someone who can't be pushed around or threatened. A leader, like her mother. Like Catra. "I'll talk to Scorpia. And as soon as Entrapta is ready…we'll be ready."

All of this depends so much on timing. She hasn't told Bow about going to see Light Hope—somehow *that* seems to cross a line even beyond Shadow Weaver. But she promised she wouldn't go to the Fright Zone alone, which means she hasn't had a chance to speak to Scorpia one on one.

"You can't hesitate."

"I'm not," Glimmer insists, crossing her arms, then realizing she looks like a petulant child. She drops her arms to her side, trying to relax. She *will* make everything right. She's determined. And nothing is going to stop her when she's already come this far.

Absolutely nothing.

Beast Island

Chapter Summary

Bow and Glimmer make some questionable choices.

Catra visits the library.

Entrapta has the time of her god damn life.

Chapter Notes

FINAL CHAPTER COUNT IS 20 it will not change again after this I promise. 20 chapters. Two more to go!

Who's ready for a nice little vacation?

"There's a *huge* concentration of First Ones' tech riiiiiiiiiiiiiight… here."

Entrapta zeroes in on the location…in the middle of the ocean. "Is it all under water?" Glimmer asks doubtfully. Scorpia leans in to read the coordinates, then gasps.

"That's Beast Island," she whispers.

"Beast what now?"

"Oh, I've heard people talking about that place," Entrapta pipes up. "It's full of monsters and things that try to kill you. The Horde sends you there to die if you really, really mess up. Adora was *supposed* to send Shadow Weaver there, but Shadow Weaver escaped, and then then Adora was supposed to go because she lost Shadow Weaver and lied to Hordak, but I convinced him she'd be more useful looking for First One tech in the Crimson Waste. If I'd known about these energy signals then, I might've just let her go."

"Let her go. T o a place called Beast Island."

"T o a place apparently *teeming* with First One tech!" The ends of Entrapta's hair clap together. "How do we get there?"

"Um." Glimmer , Scorpia, and Bow exchange looks. "What?"

"If the Horde sends people there as punishment, then it can't be that far, right? Do you think we could borrow a skiff?"

"Okay , hang on," Glimmer says, holding her hands up. "W e are *not* going to a place named *Beast Island*."

"Not *all* of us, no. Scorpia is clearly terrified, and it'll be suspicious if you and Bow both disappear," Entrapta says simply . "Bow should come with me. It'd be more noticeable if a princess disappeared."

Glimmer stares, blinking. "*No one* is going to a place named *Beast Island*. This is dangerous, Entrapta. We're in way over our heads."

"It' s important, though!"

"It doesn't matter! Nothing is going to matter if you *die* trying to get what you need!"

"Hang on," Bow says, stepping between the princesses. "Are you going to go no matter what we say?" Entrapta nods. "At least you're honest." Bow sighs. "Okay . I'll go with Entrapta. At least she'll have someone there to drag her out if things get bad."

"Bow!" Glimmer 's eyes are wide, expression stricken. "Y ou can't—"

"Entrapta is going. Y ou *know* none of us are going to be able to stop her." It' s true. Entrapta is somehow already standing next to the door . "*But* we aren't just going to run in blind. W e'll take time to plan it, I'll make sure I have enough good arrows, and we'll get in and out as quick as we can."

"Aaawww ," Entrapta mumbles, clearly disappointed. "I mean, of course, that all sounds very wise and logical."

Glimmer presses her lips thin. "*Fine* ," she says reluctantly . "If anyone asks, Ill tell them you're visiting your dads."

"Perfect." Bow grins. "Dont worry . Well be okay ."

Don't worry . Glimmer scoffs silently. They're going to a place called *Beast Island*, but dont worry . Sure.

But...this might be good. She can get Scorpia bonded to the Black Garnet while Bow and Entrapta are gone, and theyll be ready as soon as they get back to align the Runestones. And theyll be able to open the portal. And get Adora back.

Entrapta reluctantly agrees to wait a bit, so they can prepare properly, before Glimmer and Bow leave, reappearing in her room in Bright Moon.

"Have you tried talking to Catra?" Bow asks uncertainly . Glimmer grumbles, crossing her arms.

"She wont sit still long enough to listen to me."

It doesnt sound like Glimmer is trying too hard, either . Bow knows better than to point that out.

Castaspella is waiting for Glimmer, so Bow leaves. He knows Catra's been spending a lot of time alone since...everything. And that' s not good for her. But she's had almost three years to find all the best hiding places in the castle, and Bow is no good at finding those. He asks a few passing guards, but no one's seen her all day. *Great* . She's probably run off to liberate another village.

He tries knocking on her door before giving up, and is surprised when she calls, "No."

"No what?" Bow asks as he opens the door . Catra is lying on her stomach on the bed,arms tucked under her head, staring out the window.

"No everything. No talking. No apologizing to Glimmer , or whatever you're here for . Just *no*."

Bow crosses the room, sitting beside her. He hesitates for a moment before reaching out and carefully scratching her head. She doesn't twitch or try to pull away, which is surprising. She hasn't been big on touch lately. "Is that why you're in your here? No everything?"

"No, I'm *here* because Angella said, and I quote," she lifted her head and put on a not terrible impression of Angella's regal voice, "take some time to relax or I will lock you in a room and put a guard on your door." Bow's eyes flicker to the balcony. "There's a guard outside to make sure I don't jump out."

Well, at least Angella's thorough. "It probably won't kill you to take a nap," Bow points out. "Isn't napping like, a big thing with cats?" Catra raises her head to hiss at him slightly, but there's no heat behind it. "Okay , point taken."

They sit in a surprisingly comfortable silence for a long time. "You know Glimmer didn't mean what she said, right?" Bow finally asks.

Catra groans, burying her face in her pillow. "I knew you were going to ruin it. I don't want to talk about it right now , okay?"

"She really didn't mean"—

"Then she wouldn't have *said it*," Catra snapped, pushing herself up and away from Bow's hand. "People don't just *say things* that they don't mean, Bow! Not things like that." Her voice wavers slightly;she forces herself to look away so Bow can't see her face. "No one ever means anything nice."

"That's not true," Bow protests. "I mean everything I say ."

"You're the exception that proves the rule." Catra curls up, further away from him. "And the universe is just gonna fuck you up eventually too."

The words makes the earlier decision to go to Beast Island decidedly more ominous. "No, it won't," Bow says confidently, leaning back on the bed to try and catch Catra's eye. "I've got your back, Catra. No matter what happens. I promise."

Catra's gaze flicks to him for just a second before she quickly looks away again. "The last person who said that is gone."

Not if this works, Bow thinks. But he's treading on thin ice now, and he knows it. So he doesn't speak; he just lies back on the bed and stays there, determined to keep Catra company until she kicks him out.

There'll be time to get ready later.

Bow's never been one to get motion sickness. But this skiff might be the death of him. Part of him wonders if he should have argued with Entrapta to let *him* be the one to drive. But that might have just made it worse.

Entrapta seems completely unshaken. She's practically *glowing*, the idea of going to an island full of First One tech keeping her going. "*Full of monsters and other deadly things*" doesn't seem to bother as much.

Part of Bow wishes someone else could have come with them. Glimmer or Scorpia or any of the princesses, or Catra — *someone else* with the fighting skills Entrapta lacked. But no one else knows, and Glimmer can't just disappear, especially not now that Catra knows about her training with Shadow Weaver. She's already suspicious, her trust already fragile; it's going to fall apart if they're not careful.

So Bow just clings to the steering column, eyes closed, listening to Entrapta laugh maniacally and wishing he hadn't eaten breakfast that morning.

He doesn't feel better when they land.

"This doesn't seem too bad," Entrapta says cheerily as she hops down onto the beach, strolling toward the forest of trees. She has no sense of self preservation, Bow thinks as he warily follows, knocking an arrow into place. He can hear small chittering and scurrying noises ~~is~~land inhabitants, he assumes. Hopefully *not* getting ready to make the visitors their next meal.

"Oooooooh." Entrapta drops to her knees to examine a twisted piece of metal. "Look at this!"

"Do you think it's strong enough to get the portal working?" Bow asks hopefully. Maybe they won't even need to venture that far in to find what they want. Entrapta looks at him like he's sprouted another head.

"We're trying to build an inter-dimensional portal. You think a few scraps on the beach will be enough for that?"

"Of course. What was I thinking."

Bow follows behind Entrapta, who's completely glued to her tablet. Bow has an arrow knocked into place, looking warily around the woods they're walking deeper into. Everything about this just *screams* bad idea. It's too quiet. Except for the random sound of chattering in the trees. What *is* that? It doesn't sound like any animal he's ever heard.

"Entrapta?"

"Hmn?"

"Did you...really stay with the Horde because you thought we left you?"

Entrapta shrugs without looking up. "I stayed because they offered the best opportunity for scientific advancements. And I was right! Look at all I've accomplished! The portal was, admittedly , a setback, but once I figure out how to fix that..."

"But you're helping the *Horde*," Bow insists. "They're evil."

"Science isn't good or evil, though. It just *is*. It's so much less complicated."

Bow sighs, rubbing the back of his neck. "So are you going to stay with the Horde after this?"

"Dunno. Haven't really thought about it. Hordak might be a bit mad that I went behind his back to rebuild the portal." Entrapta tilts her head, thinking. "It would be a shame to lose all that data, though." Something beeps on the tracker pad. "Oooooh! This way!"

She darts off deeper into the woods. Bow yelps, running after her. "Hang on, we need to stick together!"

Catra doesn't usually feel the need to slink around the castle like a criminal. But she's very interested in avoiding basically everyone, and there's *still* a guard outside her a balcony.

So, she slinks. She slides around corners and jumps to the rafters and expertly avoids everyone…

Until Glimmer appears *right* where Catra is about to land.

They fall to the ground in a tangle of limbs, both shouting in surprise. "What are you *doing*?" Glimmer groans as she tries to free herself. Catra succeeds first, shoving her away.

"What am *I* doing? What are *you* doing?" she asked bitterly. "Oh, wait—training session with Shadow Weaver?"

Glimmer scowls back at Catra. "Going for a walk. Why are *you* sneaking around like you're trying to bust out?"

"Training session with Light Hope. Where's Bow?"

His absence is a little too noticeable. "Spending the day with his dads. You're still training with Light Hope? I thought you didn't trust her?"

"I *don't*, but she seems to be the only person who doesn't get mad when I want to fight." Catra pushes herself up, dusting herself off and straightening her headpiece. "I mean, I know it's just because she wants to use me as a weapon but at least she's *honest* with me about that."

"I've never lied to you about *anything*," Glimmer snaps, pushing herself up. "I didn't *tell you* because I knew you'd react like this—"

"And because you know it's wrong!" Catra whirls back to glare at Glimmer. "You *know* she's dangerous, and I'm willing to bet I'm not the only one you conveniently *forgot* to tell. Or did Angella approve this?"

Glimmer pales. "You can *not* tell her." Catra scoffs. "I'm serious, Catra, she'll—"

"Stop you? Like a *sane* person? Far be it from me to insert some logic into your world."

Catra storms out, ignoring the glare burning into her back. She really *had* been on her way to Light Hope, but Glimmer had reminded her of something—Bow's dads. Bow's dads, and their building full of First One stuff. They *must* have something about the Heart of Etheria, even if they don't realize it.

She changes direction when she hits the woods, heading off for the library.

"Look at this!"

Bow jumps, turning to Entrapta – then screams when he finds himself looking into a pair of giant bug eyes. Entrapta lifts the mask with her hair as Bow falls over. "Are you sure you're a good guard?" she asks, tilting her head. "I found a new mask! It fits me much better, don't you think?"

"Have you uh...had any luck with technology? Or finding things?"

"I've found *lots* of things! This island is full of technological monstrosities!"

Her hair is moving as she speaks, separating bits and pieces of machines. "Anything that can *help*?" Bow asks patiently. They should have brought a boat or something. He wonders if he can call Sea Hawk to help them transport stuff back.

"Yeah! I think I can—"

They stop when they hear a far off rustle. "That's...probably a native," Entrapta says, hair still moving. Bow looks around, grip on his bow tightening.

"Everything's quiet."

There had been a din of activity around them since they had first entered the woods. Now, everything is silent.

"It's probably fine." Entrapta sounds a little less certain. The faint rustling becomes crunches of branches, and a giant, metal bug comes barreling out from the trees.

"Not fine!" Bow yelps, grabbing one of Entrapta's overall straps and dragging her away. She yelps, quickly grabbing the pieces she had been inspecting before they run. He doesn't entirely trust that Entrapta will be able to keep up with him — why hadn't they brought Emily? They could've made room on the skiff — so he can't let go to fight, but they're not going to be able to outrun this thing, either.

"Uh, Bow? It's catching up to us."

"I know!" Bow's voice cracks. He doesn't know what to do. Why had they thought coming here alone was a good idea? They're going to die. This was a terrible idea, and now they're going to die—

The air around them changes.

Bow's spent enough time in Bright Moon, with Glimmer, and around Catra, to know what magic feels like, even if he has no inherent abilities himself. It's like the air is electrified, like physics itself is shifting to obey the magic.

This feels like a pull. Like they're being dragged with everything else. It's not real, but it still causes Bow to stop dead. He barely notices when Entrapta runs into him; he just turns, eyes seeking out the cause of the change.

It's a person. A man, he's fairly certain, with a hood pulled up over his head, purple magic crackling around his hands. *Familiar* magic. It's like…

Glimmer.

"Well this is certainly a twist," Entrapta says as they watch the man circle the beast, lassoing it with magic, warding off blows with his staff. A couple locks of hair lower down to let her investigate the pieces she had grabbed. "Fascinating"…

The beast is sent flying with one last blast of magic. The man watches for a moment before turning to Bow and Entrapta, walking

toward them. They should run, Bow thinks. The man saving them doesn't automatically make him friendly. But they won't be able to outrun him or his magic.

The man pulls the hood back, giving them a good look at his face for the first time. Bow wobbles slightly as the ground seems to move beneath his feet.

"*King Micah*?

"Catra!"

The magicat groans as Lance wraps her in a hug. "Hey, bud," she groaned, patting the man's back. George is watching, amused. "Bow run off to hide the photo album?"

George tilts his head. "What do you mean? Bow's not here."

Catra raises an eyebrow. "Really," she says flatly. Lance pulls away to look at her.

"Something wrong? Are you looking for him?"

Well, either Glimmer had lied to her, or Bow had lied to Glimmer, which seems fairly unlikely. But that's not something to deal with right now. "No, I must've heard wrong, I thought he was visiting. Actually, I was looking for some stuff on the First Ones."

The men light up. "We can help with that! Looking for anything in particular?"

"Have you ever heard of anything called the Heart of Etheria project?"

"Can't say that one's familiar, no," Lance says slowly. "We can show you everything we have, of course, but"…

"But some of those are scrolls are mislabeled and nothing is translated." Catra sighs. "Right. Ill take whatever I can get, though. And Id like to see what you have from the Magicats again, if you dont mind."

"Whatever we can do to help."

Catra finds a corner for herself and all the scrolls George and Lance pile into her arms, and begins quickly skimming. *Not* finding anything on the Heart is easy - one look tells her that something is about architecture, or some other technology, or analysis of something. Useless, useless, useless. Catra makes notes for Lance and George to organize things, but otherwise puts it all aside. Theyll be thrilled for the help.

Eventually she takes a break to go through the sparse collection of Magicat writings they have. A few of them are similar to the ones she saw the last time she was there - communications, probably. She wonders if the Magicats and First Ones could read each other's languages, or if she got some sort of special translation power with the stupid sword.

"Anything useful?" George asks as he delivers another batch of scrolls. Catra sighs, running her hands through her hair.

"No. You said you found the a lot of Magicat stuff at an old dig site that might've been a base of operations, right?" George nods. "Was there anything in particular there that seemed... I dunno, different?"

The Magicat letters *do* mention "the Heart Project" after all, and call it dangerous. And the Magicats went to ground to try and prevent the First Ones from using the Heart of Etheria. If the place was some kind of HQ, then maybe there'd been research there. George tilts his head, thinking.

"Our son Anthony was working there... hang on, let me see if I can find that pad thing Bow keeps trying to make us use. He might remember something."

Catra looks back at the Magicat letters as George leaves. Her eyes land on one of the names — *C'yra*. Maybe someday, when the world isn't constantly almost ending, she can go back to Half Moon and find out more about it. Angella had said the queen's name was C'yra, so Catra definitely hadn't randomly pulled that from somewhere. Unless it really was just a name that was passed down. But what about *Lyra*? Had her subconscious simply made up something that sounded like it fit a vague theme? Had their been some truth to that portal world?

How long would it take her to accept that there were no answers?

Bow blinks, and the man is standing in front of him — how did he move so fast? Can he teleport too? Glimmer's never known much about her father's magic.

"Who are you?" Micah demands, grabbing Bow's face and squeezing. "How did you get here? Are you real?"

"Uh. Bow. Skiff. And yes. Are. Are you King Micah? Of Bright Moon?"

Micah stares at him just long enough for it to be slightly off-putting, blinking several times. "You know me." It isn't a question. "Do you know my wife? My daughter? Are they okay?"

He still hasn't let go of Bow's face. "Y-Yeah, they're fine. I mean, the war is still going on so they're still fighting. But everyone's fine."

"The war! Wait, *Glimmer* is fighting? But she's so young, how"—

Oh boy. This is going to be something. "Um. your majesty?" Bow says weakly. "I'll be happy to answer all your questions, really, we just"—

"Oh!"

Bow jumps as Micah finally releases him, diving for the ground and coming back up with a bug in his fingers. "Ah, sorry , where are my manners?" He of fers the bug to Bow. "Bug?"

"Uuuuuuuh, no." He' s been alone here for *years*. Bow can barely imagine it. "No disrespect, but um..aren't you dead?"

Micah laughs. "If the Horde had their way , I would be. They exiled me here, but I survived!"

"Right," Bow says slowly . Not what they had come here for, but okay. This was good. Bringing Angella's husband and Glimmer's father back? That would be amazing. And if they could rescue Adora too—

Wait.

Bow snaps around, looking left and right, wide-eyed. "Entrapta?"

The princess is gone. Bow bites back a groan. "Wasn't there another person here?" Micah asks, looking around Bow . He doesn't sound too concerned that he could have completely made up a second person.

"Yeah." Bow sighs. "Listen, we're..we're here to collect technology for something, but as soon as we're done, we can bring you home. The Queen and Glimmer will be… *really* happy to see you. But can you help find her, first?"

Micah brightens up. "Of course! I know this island better than anyone! We'll find her in no time."

Bow *really* hopes he's right.

Scorpia paces around Entrapta's lab, tapping her pincers together. She's worried. She hates that she let Bow and Entrapta just *go* to Beast Island. Would they be okay? What if the razorfins got them? Or the giant spiders? Or the man-eating plants? Or—

"Scorpia!"

She jumps, surprised, when Glimmer appears next to her, wide-eyed and eager. "Huh? What? What's wrong? Did something happen?"

"No, no," Glimmer says quickly. "But I need your help with something."

"*My* help?" Scorpia repeats, bewildered. "What can I do?"

"Bond with the Black Garnet."

A long moment of silence follows as Scorpia waits for the punchline. But there doesn't seem to be one. "Um." She laughs nervously. "I don't think that's a good idea."

"Of course it is," Glimmer insists. "You're a princess, the Black Garnet is *yours*."

"Yeah, but Hordak gave it to Shadow Weaver, and"—

"Hordak had no right to do that, though. *You* are the princess, the Black Garnet belongs to you. It doesn't matter what happened before." Scorpia hunches her shoulders, looking away. "This will help us save Adora and end the war. Isn't that what you want?"

"Of course that's what I want," Scorpia says, eyes still on the opposite wall. "I just... what if it doesn't want me? I'm not really good at... I mean, I don't fit in, ya know? The other force captains don't like me much, and a lot of people don't take me seriously, and what if the Black Garnet doesn't like me?" She shuffles, lips twisting into a rueful frown. "I dunno. It all seems like a bad idea."

Glimmer reaches out, resting a hand on Scorpia's claw. "I get it. I've been the weakest princess for a long time, and feeling left out and like people don't take me seriously is the worst. But you're a good person, Scorpia. I know you are. You don't belong here. Neither

does Entrapta, or Adora. If you do this, we can save Adora, and get all three of you out of here. Isn't that what you want?"

Scorpia lets out a long breath, nodding slowly. "Yeah," she admits. "It is."

"Then come with me. Bond with the stone. We can end everything here and now, and you can go somewhere with people who understand you and make you happy."

It takes a long moment, but finally Scorpia nods. Glimmer grins, and teleports them away.

Anthony, it turns out, is nearby and more than happy to swing home and help with some of the stuff he found at that dig site. He's basically another Bow clone, and Catra does her best not to groan. Had they *all* inherited Glimmer's personality? She makes a mental note to never attend a family reunion.

"Can you really understand this?" the young man asks as he watches Catra skim through the scrolls. His glasses are nearly falling off his nose as he tries to contain his excitement.

"Yeah, it's weird," Catra mutters without looking up. "Magic sword thing, I think."

"Would you be interested in helping with translation?"

"Maybe after I'm done saving the world."

"Oh." Anthony sounds slightly chagrined; he pushes his glasses up his nose, and nods. "Right. Of course. That's probably more important."

Nerd. Catra almost smiles. She labels the scroll as another utilities request (something about a vent rattling) and sets it aside, grabbing

the next one. This one, she's surprised to see, is a mixture of Magicat and First One writing. It gives her a headache.

"Oh, that one's weird," Anthony says, noticing what Catra's grabbed. She looks at him, raising an eyebrow.

"Weird? Why?"

"Well, it's definitely two different languages"—

"Magicat and First One."

"And you can read both?" Catra nods. "Amazing. Anyway, two different languages, but it's written by the same person. It's hard to tell, but the are subtle similarities in the way the lines are written."

He's right, Catra realizes, scanning it. She goes back to the top, which is completely written in Magicat.

Mara,

I've provided the translations from the letters you sent, including the original texts. To summarize, it is a conversation between my mother and one of your ancestors regarding the Heart Project. I can't say I understand much of it — she took the secrets of the Heart Project to her grave — but I'm beginning to understand why we left the Sanctum the way we did.

If you truly believe Light Hope has been compromised, then you must consider that your superiors are suspicious. I stand by what I said — if you're in danger, Half Moon is open to you. We too only wish the best for Etheria, and we will accomplish more together than we will apart.

Please stay safe.

C'yra

Catra stares at the scroll, blinking a few times. Mara had been working with the Magicats. She had already suspected it, but having it confirmed feels…nice. Reassuring. They hadn't just hidden like cowards. They had continued to fight for this planet. For their home.

And it had all failed.

"This isn't good."

Bow stops to look at Micah, who is surprisingly stony faced. "What's wrong?" he asks nervously.

"We're getting close to the center of the island. That's where the signal is." The man blows out a long breath, rubbing the back of his head. "I try not to go there."

Of course that's the direction Entrapta would go. Bow takes a deep breath and presses forward. "Why are you here?" Micah asks after a moment. Bow looks around the trees, sighing.

"We're collecting technology for something Entrapta is building. It wasn't really our first choice to come here, but it was the best." And fate, apparently, is rewarding them for it. But Bow is definitely starting to feel the weirdness in the air. He just wants to find Entrapta, get back to the skiff, and get out of here.

"Bow!"

He nearly jumps out of his skin when Entrapta appears in front of him, excited. "Entrapta! Great, I found you—"

"You won't believe what I found!" She grabs his wrist with a lock of hair, dragging Bow forward. "It's amazing, it confirms so much I've always suspected!"

"Entrapta, wait," Bow protests as she pulls him closer to where he definitely wants to go. He can hear Micah hurrying to keep up. "We

cant go any further in, it' s"—

"My theories were correct!" Entrapta is babbling happily as she pulls him through a blanket of moss and down a passage. "I knew the First Ones had retrofitted the planet with tech, I just didn't know why. But it all makes sense now! They were mining the planet's magic, using it to power their weapon, the Heart of Etheria!"

She stops in front of a machine, powering it up. The screen comes to life with blueprints and info all in First One's writing. "We really need to go," Micah murmured to Bow. "We're too close to the signal."

Bow nods. "Entrapta, we"—

"The Heart draws its power from the magic of the princesses," Entrapta barrels on, switching to another screen that shows the Runestones surrounding Etheria. "It needs all their Runestones engaged to work. And She-Ra is the most important piece, the key! She channels the weapon's power and focuses it."

"We—Wait, what?" Bow is momentarily distracted. Mara had mentioned the Heart of Etheria in her message, but she hadn't really been generous with details. "That...That would turn Catra into a weapon."

"Exactly!" The screen changes again, this time to an old video of Mara being handed the sword, and then energy overwhelming Mara. "The First Ones made the sword to control She-Ra, but they couldn't control the Heart. It was too much energy. That's why they left!"

That's why Mara brought Etheria here. "Okay," Bow says slowly. "Okay, this is all really important and it's great you found it. We need to get back to finish the portal and warn Catra about this."

"Oh, okay," Entrapta says cheerfully, turning away. "Come visit soon."

The words catch Bow off guard. "Huh? No, you're coming back with us. We need *you* to finish the portal, remember?"

Entrapta shakes her head, still staring at the screen. "No, Im staying here. It's better."

"What. What do you mean?"

"I tried to be in the Alliance, and then in the Horde, and it just didnt work. I didnt fit in anywhere. But this place is amazing. It has everything I could ever want. Piles of old technology to examine, and no people who can get hurt by it." Entrapta turns to look at them again; her usually vibrant eyes are blank and gray. "It's better this way."

Bow gasps, and Micah sucks in a sharp breath. "The signal got to her." Concern is obvious in the king's voice. "That was fast. Too fast."

"Entrapta, that's not true," Bow insists. "We wanted you to join the Alliance because you could help us, remember? We would have gone back if we'd known you were alive."

"I know." She still sounds chipper. It's eerie. "But people keep getting hurt because of the things I build, no matter where I am. Even my own castle wasnt safe. I was never meant to have friends or be around people. This is where I belong."

Bow looks down to see vines creeping up Entrapta's legs. "No, it's not! You belong with us. You always have. You're the only person who can save Adora now."

"There's no guarantee this portal will work," Entrapta says, almost dreamily. "Everyone will be better off if I dont finish it."

Bow is lost. His heart is pounding in his chest, eyes wide. He cant do this. He cant say what Entrapta needs to hear. He doesnt *know* what she needs to hear. It's pointless. All of this is pointless. Why had they even tried? She's right—people just keep getting hurt. Why bother?

A strong hand clamps down on Bow's shoulder, shaking him out of the spiral. He blinks heavily, staring at Micah, who regards him with a sharp gaze. "Don't let it get you."

The signal. Right. Bow takes a deep breath, squaring his shoulders. "Entrapta, I don't know what to say," he starts.

"You don't have to say anything"—

"*But*," he pushes on, cutting her off, "I know what you just said isn't true. People aren't your thing, I get that. But that doesn't mean you should cut yourself off, and the fact that you *care* is enough to prove it. You care about trying to protect people from you, and that means a lot, even if you're not a threat to anybody. You're a good person, and we should have fought harder for you, and I'm sorry, I really am."

Entrapta's expression is blank now, staring at Bow without really seeing him. Even her hair is still. There's no way to know if she's hearing Bow. He keeps going anyway. "Give us another chance. Let us try to be the friends you deserve. Let's save Adora, and get you and Scorpia out of the Horde, and end this war. And if you want technology, we have a fully intact First One's ship that belonged to She-Ra herself. You can take a look at it and do whatever you want when we get back to Bright Moon."

Catra probably won't mind. It's not like they plan using the ship for anything.

Entrapta's face immediately changes; her eyes fade back to bright magenta, going wide, a grin splitting across her face. "Why didn't you say that sooner!"

Micah fires a blast of magic at the vines, causing them to wither. Bow grabs an arrow and slashes through them; Entrapta jumps, surprised. "Oh, wow, that's weird." She shakes one leg and then the other as if shaking off a fly. "Come on, let's get the pieces we need and get home!"

One lock of hair grabs Bow’s hand, another lock grabs Micah, and Entrapta hurries forward, heading back toward the beach.

Interlude IV

Chapter Summary

Sleep time is over. Welcome back to reality.

Chapter Notes

TW: Blood, character death

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra's purr is loud, her chest vibrating against Adora's. This is Adora's favorite way to wake up. Her wife tucked under arm, using her as a body pillow, purring loud enough to make them both vibrate. The village outside the castle walls is quiet — it's still early. Even ten years later, she hasn't quite shaken the habit of waking up early for morning drills and training. And she's almost always trapped by Catra when she wakes up. But she doesn't mind. She enjoys these quiet moments, before they have to wake up and be the royalty everyone expects them to be. Glyra and Light had been not-so-subtly hinting that they were getting on in age, and that Catra would soon be old enough to take over. She'd been busy a lot lately.

So Adora will take these quiet moments, with Catra relaxed and peaceful at her side. She makes a small noise and burrow a little closer to Adora, cheek nuzzling her shoulder. It was scent marking, Catra had explained once, when they were teenagers, through stutters and blushes. It was a way of signaling that Adora had been "claimed," so to speak. She was *Catra's*. Adora had loved the idea then, and she loves it now. The pin she wears on her jacket is already a symbol of their marriage, but that's tangible, removable. *Nothing* can remove the scent marking, however. Not when Catra nuzzles her every single time they go to bed, and every time they wake up, and usually several times while they slept.

It makes Adora a *little* jealous that there's nothing she can do in return, but it's not like all of Etheria isn't *well* aware of their marriage.

The bedroom crashes open, hitting the wall so hard it splinters. Catra immediately shoots up, wide-eyed, and Adora follows, grabbing her without thinking. There are three people in uniforms, helmets hiding their faces, entering the room, weapons trained on them. Catra growls, jumping to take down one of them, and Adora quickly follows. She has no weapons, but she doesn't need one. The soldiers clearly aren't expecting a fight, especially not from the princess.

There are echoes of yells and crashing throughout the castle. Catra straightens up, wide-eyed, casting a terrified look at the door. "My moms," she gasps before running out. Adora grabs a stun baton from one of the prone soldiers before she follows. There's no one between them and the queens' room. Adora tries not to let that worry her too much.

It turns out she's right to worry, however. Cyra's and Lyra's door has been kicked in as well. Catra gets there just a few steps ahead of Adora...and screams. It's a sound full of pain and anguish, a sound no living being should be capable of making. Adora freezes beside Catra; she feels the ground spin out from beneath her at sight before her.

The queens hadn't gone down without a fight. There are four dead soldiers around their bodies, and blood paints the room. Catra starts to step forward, but Adora grabs her arm, holding her back, shaking her head.

"Don't." They're gone. Catra doesn't need to confirm that. It won't do any good.

Catra turns back to her to argue, then freezes, wide-eyed, gaze fixing on a spot over Adora's shoulder. Then she pushes Adora out of the way with a strangled growl, leaping forward.

Adora sees the blast of green light, then red, then two bodies collapsing. One is a soldier, whose armor had been no match for the raw strength of magicat claws.

The other is Catra. The green blast from the soldier's gun had riped through the left side of her chest, leaving a burned, charred hole in its wake. The smell of burned fur and skin and blood fill the air, and Adora nearly gags. But her attention is consumed by something else.

"*Catra*!"

Adora crashes to her knees, scooping her wife up. Catra is breathing shakily, face pulled tight with pain. "Catra." Adora's voice is barely a whimper. "Catra, *please*. Wake up. Wake up."

A choked groan forces its way up Catra's throat, but it's over taken by a weak cough. Blood bubbles up over her lips. Adora wipes it away, tears filling her eyes. "H-Hey , MDora," she croaked, eyes cracking open. "Okay?"

No. Her entire world is dying in her arms. Of course she isn't okay . "Sssshhh," she says instead, kissing Catra's forehead. She wants to scream, to get help, but she knows there's no help for *this*. She dips her head to press their foreheads together, swallowing a sob. "Don't worry about it."

Catra tries to argue, but her breathing hitches, and she squeezes her eyes shut again. Adora holds her until she feels her last, weak breaths wash over her skin.

"*No*!"

Her eyes fly open, taking in everything around her in her a brief moment. The air feels different ~~-cr~~isp. The surface beneath her is steel. She can hear voices.

Bright. It's too bright. She immediately squeezes her eyes shut again, whimpering. The words stop. The air around her shifts. She

can feel someone looking at her.

"My lord, the prisoner has awoken."

The voice sounds familiar? Hordak? But... no, definitely not Hordak. It's too flat. Too clean. Like someone doing a bad impression of Hordak.

"Fascinating." It's a new voice, but also not new. Another Hordak impersonation. But different again. Ringing with a certainty – an authority – that Hordak had never been able to even fake. "Relax, child. I mean you no harm."

Adora isn't completely sure about that. But she opens one eye to look at the figure leaning over her.

He's *tall*, with two regular, vibrantly green eyes and two extra eyes on his cheek. Long cables masquerading as hair run down his back. He is *terrifying*, and Adora's first reaction is to *run*, but she feels stuck to the table she's lying on. "What..." Her voice breaks as she tries to speak. He smiles – a cold, empty smile that sends a shiver through Adora's spine.

"Do not fret, my child. We will show you to the light."

Chapter End Notes

Finale next week! Who's excited?

In the End, In the Beginning

Chapter Summary

Everything comes to a head, for better or worse. Where will things be when the dust settles?

Chapter Notes

let's go

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"I really think this might be a bad idea."

"It won't be," Glimmer insists, squeezing Scorpia's shoulder. "It'll be great."

Scorpia sighs, staring up at the Black Garnet. This feels like such a bad idea. But Glimmer is waiting, and Scorpia doesn't want to let her down. She has to at least try.

"All right. Uh, hey there." She waves awkwardly as she steps closer to the Black Garnet, like it can see the wave. "I'm uh. Princess Scorpia. Wow, that's weird, huh?" She chuckles, rubbing the back of her head. "So we're supposed to bond, right?"

She's not sure why she's expecting an answer, but there isn't one. She looks back at Glimmer, who smiles and gives her a thumbs up, then reaches out, carefully touching the tip of her pincer to the runestone. A shock runs up her arm; she yelps, jumping back.

"Whoa! That was"…

"Connection!" Glimmer says excitedly, practically bouncing. They're really going to do this. It's going to work. Scorpia smiles, opens her arms like she's about to embrace someone, and clasps both sides of

the Black Garnet. The runestone lights up, energy crackling in the air and surging down into Scorpia.

She screams.

"Just stay here," Catra tells George, Lance, and Anthony as she hurries to the door. Something feels wrong. She can't explain it, but she also knows that something is *not right*. She needs to find Glimmer and Bow. Whatever issues they have right now, she still needs to see them.

She needs to know they're okay.

She makes record time getting back to Bright Moon, bounding on all fours the entire way. The woods are quiet; it sends a shiver up her spine. The woods are *never quiet*. Certainly not like this.

Her room is exactly as she left it that morning when she jumps up to the balcony—faster than taking the front door. She grabs her tracker pad off the bedside table and begins going through her contacts even as she walks to the door. Bow doesn't answer. Glimmer doesn't answer.

"*Damn it*," she hisses, shouldering through her door and starting down the hall. Her next call is Mermista. The princess picks up on the third ring; Sea Hawk is singing audibly in the background.

"*Please tell me the world is ending*," Mermista deadpans before she sees the look on Catra's face. "*Actually, don't*."

"Have you seen Glimmer or Bow?"

"*Not recently, no.*" Mermista's eyes narrow. "*Why*?"

"Because I'm trying to find them," Catra replies flatly. "Let me know if they happen to stop by."

She ends the call and finds Perfuma's name next. It takes Perfuma an extra couple rings to pick up.

"*Catra! How are you?*"

"Had better days. Have you seen Glimmer or Bow?"

"*No… Catra what's going on? Are you running? Can you stop for a minute?*"

"No, I really can't—"

"*Don't you dare touch the disconnect button*." The stern voice is enough to stop Catra dead. She's shaking, she realizes, her breath coming in short gasps. Her tail is lashing, ears back, fur on edge. Every single inch of her is *screaming* danger. "*Can you sit for a minute?*"

She wants to argue, but instead finds herself nodding numbly and going to collapse against the closest wall. Perfuma smiles approvingly. "*Good. Close your eyes for a minute and take a deep breath*." Catra does as she's told, taking a few trembling breaths. "*What's wrong?*"

"I'm not sure," Catra admits, opening her eyes again. "Do you ever just… *feel* like something is wrong? Nothing has actually happened, but there's just something not *right*?"

Perfuma nods. "*Usually that happens when something is wrong with the Heart Blossom. Like when the Horde was poisoning it*."

"You. You don't feel anything *now*, do you?"

"*No?*" Perfuma tilts her head, thinking for a minute. "*But that doesn't mean anything. Trust your instincts*."

Trust her instincts. Right. Catra takes another breath. "Can you do me a favor?"

"*Of course*."

"Reach out to Frosta and Spinerella and Netossa. I doubt any of them have noticed anything either, but I just want to be sure. I'm going to talk to the Queen."

She hangs up, runs a hand through her hair, and stands to resume her sprint through the castle.

Angella is, blessedly, in her office, reading guard reports. At least *someone* is easy to find. She starts a bit when her door crashes open. "Catra! What"—

"I'm not crazy."

Catra's voice is flat and leaves no room for argument. Angella raises an eyebrow. "I don't recall questioning your sanity recently."

"Something is wrong. Really, really, *really* wrong. I don't know how I know, I just *do*. And I can't find Bow or Glimmer. Glimmer said Bow was going to see his dads but I was just there and they hadn't seen him, and Glimmer is." She stops for a moment, considering her next words, then throws caution to the winds. "Glimmer's been training with Shadow Weaver."

Angella's eyes flare, bright with fury. "She's been *what*?"

"She said she needed to learn faster, and Casta wasn't teaching her enough, but she. Shadow Weaver changes people." "That's an understatement. I *know* what she can do. And I'm not sure Glimmer is making the best choices right now."

"I believe we can agree on that," Angella says, her voice barely restrained. There will be *words* with Shadow Weaver after this. And with Glimmer, when they track her down. "What do you mean something is wrong?"

"I'm not sure." Catra finally collapses into a seat, setting her tracker pad aside and leaning forward to rest her elbows on her knees. "It's. It's like when a storm is coming, you know? You can feel it in the air before the rain starts."

Angella is quiet for a long moment, thinking. "Could it be something wrong with the planet?" she finally asks. Catra looks up, surprised.

"What do you mean?"

"You have a connection with Etheria. The First Ones created the sword to channel She-Ra's power, and the Magicats made the mask to allow the wielder to become more in-tune with the planet and its magic." Catra reaches up, slowly pulling her mask off to stare at it. Perfuma had said she felt the same way when the Heart Blossom was poisoned. And what is Etheria if not one giant Runestone for She-Ra?

"Oh." Her breathe leave she in one small gasp. That makes sense. Too much sense. She settles the mask back on her head and pushes the tracker pad to Angella before she stands. "Perfuma should be calling back any minute. I doubt she'll have any news. Let her know I think I figured it out, though."

"Where are you going?" Angella asks, watching Catra summon the sword and make her way to the door.

"The Crystal Castle. It's about damn time Light Hope gave me some *real* answers." She raises the sword. "For the honor of Grayskull!"

Hordak is not a being known for a *patience*.

He's been sending messages for Force Captain Scorpia and Entrapta to meet with him immediately, and they're both ignoring him. And *now* something is happening with the Black Garnet – the energy reader he has on it is going wild. It hasn't reacted like that since Shadow Weaver had used it.

The thought spurs Hordak on as he makes his way to the Runestone's chamber.

Glimmer watches, amazed, as Scorpia stumbles back from the Black Garnet, gasping for breath. "Whoa. Okay . Wow. Uh. Did it work?"

The door slides open. Glimmer whips around to see Hordak storming in. "What is the meaning of this, *Force Captain* ?" he demands, practically snarling. Scorpia jumps, whirling around, pincers glowing with magic.

"Scorpia!" Glimmer yelps. "Point, *point*!"

Scorpia sees her pincers glowing and thrusts them out instinctively; energy crackles loudly for a moment before lashing out toward Hordak. It's wild, and the energy arcs around Hordak, missing him, but electrifying the air. Glimmer hurries to grab Scorpia, but is stopped by a vicious red blast from a weapon on Hordak's arm. It splits the space between them, hitting the stone. Glimmer's first thought is that they need to get out, get back to Bright Moon—

But they cant, she realizes abruptly . Bow and Entrapta still arent back. If Hordak catches them…

They have to take him down.

Getting back from Beast Island with their bits and bobs of technology is made a lot easier with Micah's help, at least. Purple energy keeps the pieces firmly in place as Entrapta steers and speeds across the ocean, face hidden by her new mask. Bow isnt really sure what to say to her. There's clearly a lot they have to talk about.

His tracker pad beeps, distracting him;he accepts the call, angling it slightly so Glimmer doesnt see the man behind him when her face pops up on screen. There's a loud explosion on her end, and a yell. She yelps and ducks before refocusing on Bow.

"*How far are you guys?*

"About twenty miles!" Entrapta calls over the rush of wind.

"*Okay, good*." She sounds almost exhilarated. "*Hordak kind of caught us, but it's fine, we're dealing with him. But you need to get things finished as soon as you get back*."

"Wait, what do you mean *caught us*?" Bow demands. "What's going on?"

"*Don't worry about it, just get back as soon as you can!*" Glimmer hangs up without another word. Bow sighs, pinching the bridge of his nose. What has she *done*?

Micah makes a pained noise behind him. Shoot. "I'm sorry," Bow says quickly, meeting the king's sad eyes. "I just didn't think this would be the best way for her—for you guys to—"

"You're right," Micah says. "She just sounds so much older. How long was I gone?"

Bow tries to smile. "A while. You're going home now. Isn't that all that matters?"

That earns him a smile in return. "Yeah." He'd be reunited with his wife and his daughter. And everything would be okay.

Glimmer's never seen the Horde leader face to face. It was always force captains and soldiers, and even Catra had said that Shadow Weaver, then Adora, had been running the show. Hordak rarely, if ever, came out his sanctum. Catra said she could count the number of times she had seen him in her entire life on one hand.

And Glimmer is starting to understand why.

He’s *strong*, certainly. And that cannon on his arm has put holes in several metal walls. But even Glimmer knows a poor fight form when she sees one.

Scorpia isnt doing much better with her *very* newfound powers, but she knows how to dodge, at least. Glimmer appears behind Hordak, hitting him with a blast of magic, then quickly teleports away before he can reorient himself and hit her. She grabs Scorpia and teleports her around a corner to hide.

“Whew!” Scorpia rubs the back of her neck, taking a deep breath. “That uh...that cannon thing is new.”

“Entrapta and Bow will be back soon,” Glimmer says hurriedly. “We need to take make sure he doesnt interrupt them.”

Scorpia frowns, thinking for a minute. “What if we take him out of the Fright Zone? You can teleport to the Whispering Woods, right?”

Glimmer grins. “Scorpia, I like the way you think.”

“Light Hope!”

The AI doesnt turn away from the large display in front of her, even as Catra shouts her name down the platform. The planets are moving, aligning, with sword hovering right above them. “Good, you are here. Now we can begin. After a thousand years, my programming will be fulfilled. The Heart of Etheria will be unleashed against the First Ones' enemies.”

“There are no enemies left!” Catra insists, fingers tightening around the hilt of the sword. “The First Ones are *gone*. Whatever war they were fighting, whatever *greater evil* there was, it’s gone now.” Light Hope ignores her, swiping one of the glyphs in the air in front of her. Catra looks down, surprised, as she starts glowing. “What—

"The First Ones will rise again. You will bring them to glory." Light Hope's voice is flat. "It is what you were born to do."

Catra growls, a low, deep sound in her throat. "No. I'm not one of your precious First Ones. *I'll* people knew what the First Ones were doing was wrong. They tried to stop them."

"The Magicats betrayed the First Ones"—

"They didn't!" Catra cuts Light Hope off. "They were trying to protect the planet. They *cared* about Etheria!"

"Enough." Light Hope holds out a hand. "This is your intended function. The Heart of Etheria has been activated. You will be the one to fire it. There is no stopping it now."

Lines of energy crawl up Catra's skin; she gasps, caught off guard, as her arms move against her will, gripping the sword. She falls to her knees, pressing the tip to the ground.

"I *won't*"—

Energy surges through her. She screams.

If there's one thing Scorpia is known for in the Horde, for better or worse, it's her hugs. Her giant, bone-crushing hugs.

Hordak doesn't really stand a chance when Glimmer teleports Scorpia right behind him and she grabs him, both massive arms closing around his form. He has a one second to shout in surprise before Glimmer teleports them away. They appear over the trees of the Whispering Woods.

"Drop him!"

Scorpia lets go; they reappear on the ground a few feet away right before Hordak lands with a *thud*. "All right!" Glimmer cheers, nudging

Scorpia and grinning. Scorpia looks a little anxious.

"Do you think he's dead?"

Hordak groans, as if to reassure her. "He's fine. Let's—"

Glimmer stops dead when her vision flashes white. She looks at Scorpia, who's giving her a similarly stunned look. The air around them is...smoking?

"What—"

Heat burns through every inch of Glimmer's skin, to the tips of her fingers and toes. She can see weird lines crawling across Scorpia's arms and face, the same lines on her own arms when she looks. They both collapse to their knees, yelling in pain. Glimmer wraps her arms around herself, shaking. "What's going on?" Scorpia asks through gritted teeth. Glimmer can only think of one horrifying possibility.

The Heart.

They make it closer to the Fright Zone than Bow is expecting before Micah realizes what's going on. "Where are we going?" he demands, turning on Bow. The archer holds up his hands.

"Oh, we forgot to mention that, didn't we?" Entrapta asks, practically chirpy. "We need to stop in the Fright Zone first to finish the portal."

"It's not what you think!" Bow says quickly as Micah's gaze narrows. "We mentioned a portal, remember? That's where Entrapta's been building it. It was the best place to get technology. And it's almost done, right Entrapta?"

"Right!" Entrapta confirms. "We'll know soon if it's going to work or not."

Micah is still glaring at Bow, who is suddenly very aware of how strong the king is. But the expression relaxes slightly after a moment. "Okay," he says finally. He had heard Bow talking to Glimmer earlier. They know each other. He has to trust them.

The tracker pad in Bow's hands rings again. He looks down, wide-eyed, and accepts the call. "Catra, are you—" It's not Catra, he realizes abruptly. "Your Majesty!" He turns on his heel to keep the camera away from Micah. Angella and Glimmer have the worst timing. "What're—what's going on?"

She doesn't look well. Her expression is pained and crumpled, her wings closed around her as if to block anyone from getting access, and there are weird lines of energy etched into her skin. "*Something is wrong with the Moonstone*," she informs Bow through gritted teeth. "*Where's Glimmer?*"

"I—I don't know. I talked to her earlier but I'm not sure what she was—"

"*Is she with Shadow Weaver?*"

Bow stops, mouth hanging open, suddenly feeling very cold. "How do you—?"

"*Catra*." Oh. Yeah, that makes sense. The fact that she's kept it a secret for this long is kind of amazing. "*She was looking for you both earlier*."

Oh. Bow's heart drops to his toes. "Where is she?"

"*She left to speak with Light Hope. That was an hour ago, and then this…*" Angella waves a hand at herself. "*Started*."

Catra went Light Hope. One of the only remaining things from Mara's time—from the original portal. A sentient piece of First One's tech.

"*You can't trust Light Hope. She's been reprogrammed to set off the weapon at any cost.*"

Mara's words ring in his head. Bow feels as if he's been kicked in the chest.

"Bow?"

He looks up to see Entrapta watching him uncertainly. "We're almost there." Her voice is quiet. Bow nods, looking back at Angella. Maybe Glimmer is in the Fright Zone with Scorpia. He *hopes* she's in the Fright Zone with Scorpia.

"I'll find Glimmer."

He ends the call before Angella can protest.

Catra feels like she's trapped in quicksand, with each of her limbs weighed down by boulders. The hilt of the sword is burning in her hands. "It won't work," she grits out. "Mara hid us in Despondos so you couldn't hurt anyone else."

She swears Light Hope glitches for a moment. "Mara." Another glitch. This time, Catra definitely doesn't imagine it. "Mara's interference caused a significant delay. But no longer. With the planet balanced, portal capability is restored. Initiate planetary move, out of the dimension of Despondos."

A burning wave lurches through Catra even as she struggles to hold the power back, but it's useless. She's not strong enough.

She's never been strong enough.

"That's *fascinating*."

Bow is pacing the length of Entrapta's lab, trying to call Glimmer over and over and over. Nothing. He *had* gotten in touch with his fathers, who said Catra had been there earlier but had run out, demanding they stay where they were. They're safe, at least. Entrapta had sent Emily to try and find Scorpia when they returned, but the robot had rolled back in a few moments ago, whirring sadly. Bow doesn't need a translation to understand that. Scorpia isn't here. Which means Glimmer isn't, either.

Which means he's at the end of his rope as he turns to look at Entrapta, who's staring at one of her computer screens. "What's fascinating?"

"It's a portal."

"What? Yeah, that's the whole point of this, remember?"

"No, no." A lock of hair waves him off. "It's a different portal. A *bigger* one. It looks as if the planet's been balanced, and the portal capabilities are back online. Which means—" Her expression lights up. "The odds of *our* portal working have gone up by ninety percent!"

Those are good odds. In the face of everything else, Bow really likes those odds.

The only thing keeping Catra upright is whatever force Light Hope is using to lock her in place. The world is flashing different colors around her, different dots appearing the air as Light Hope pulls them into the wider universe. Stars. Planets.

"Mara wouldn't want you to do this!" she yells, trying to ignore the pain. "You're going to destroy *everything*. Mara sacrificed herself to stop that!"

Light Hope glitches again, her voice warping as she says, "Mara. Mara would not want me to—" Glitch. "Mara was a traitor." Her voice is cold again. "She turned against her people."

"She was your friend, wasn't she?" Catra pushes. "She knew you were more than program."

"*Mara's unfriendly ghost. She's a tricky one. Mara always swore there was good in her, but I never saw it.*"

"She believed in you." Catra's wasting precious energy on speaking. But she has to *try*. "And if she did, then I do too. I know you can stop this."

Silence falls as Light Hope's form glitches again. "I am not as strong as Mara." She sounds *defeated*. Catra swallows hard, shaking. "I can not change my programming. This is our destiny."

Catra hisses through her teeth. "*No*. This is *not* my destiny." Her arms start to move against her will, raising the sword inch by inch. "This isn't what the Magicats wanted. Not for Etheria, and not for the universe."

She tried to fight back against the force, grunting. "You will comply," Light Hope informs her. She narrows her eyes.

"I don't fight for the First Ones." Tears fill Catra's eyes as she struggles. She can't lose. She *won't lose*. "I'm not their weapon. I'm not part of their machine. And I *won't* let this happen!"

She's not sure where the power comes from, but suddenly she's in control of her arms again, just a little. Just *enough*. Enough for her to struggle, to pull back more control. "No. Stop." She hears Light Hope's voice glitch again. "Don't. Do it. Do it." For a heart-stopping moment, she actually has control back. She grips sword tighter, gathering all her strength.

"Don't." Light Hope's voice breaks. "Don't." A long moment of silence. "Do it."

There.

Catra squeezes her eyes shut and, in one burst of energy, slams the tip of the sword into the floor, shouting in exertion. She hears the satisfying crack and feels it give way as it breaks.

The world goes silent.

"I'll go," Entrapta says, surprising Bow. He starts to argue, but she cuts him off. "We don't have much time." Her hair reaches for rope, and she begins tying it around her waist. "Hold this. If I tug it twice, pull me back."

"Are... Are you sure this is a good idea?" Bow asks uncertainly. Entrapta smiles despite herself.

"It's the best plan I can think of, so it must be a good idea. Wish me luck!"

She runs in before Bow can protest. He quickly tightens his grip on the rope, shooting a frightened look at Micah. The poor man still looks baffled.

"We're going to Bright Moon after this, right?"

"Yeah. Sorry about this. It's a long story."

Light blinds Entrapta for a moment. She looks around, eyes wide, as the area around her fades into a desolate wasteland. Everything is gray, piles of rubble debris spread around the area. Entrapta looks around uncertainly, then pulls her new mask down to protect herself.

"Adora?" she calls as she walks. "Adoooooooooora?"

Her voice echoes back to her, but she receives no other answer. Entrapta taps her chin with a strand of hair. How would anyone else handle this? Scorpia would just run in recklessly. Glimmer would probably teleport around. Bow would search and use arrows somehow. Catra would probably tease her to try and get a reaction.

Entrapta isn't any of them, though. She can't do any of those things. She's herself, and she has to figure out her own way. "Adora?" she calls again, inching her mask up. "I'm sorry . I know it's my fault you're stuck here. I made the portal machine, and it almost destroyed everything, and you sacrificed yourself to save everyone. Or maybe just to save Catra, I don't know . You two still really confuse me. But she misses you. A lot. So does Scorpia. So...So do I. This might be our only chance to find you. Help us find you."

Silence follows...and then a low groan. Entrapta snaps around, eyes wide. "Adora? Adora!"

She runs to a nearby pile and finds the blonde, propped up against some rocks, pale and skinny, her hair loose around her shoulders. She blinks a few times, raising her head to look blearily at Entrapta.

"Y ou're...are you...real?" Her voice shakes as she speaks.

Entrapta grins. Still asking ridiculous questions. That' s good. "Y up, I'm real. And we're getting you out of here. Come on." She wraps her hair around Adora's waist and hauls her up. She's heavy, but not as heavy as she should be, and that's concerning. She balances uncertainly against Entrapta's shoulder, wavering against her. "Don't worry, we're not that far from the exit. It' s okay."

They shuffle forward, staggering slightly, until the blinding white light of the portal appears before them. "Ready?"

Adora nods weakly. Entrapta takes a deep breath and surges forward, throwing herself through the portal. Bow is waiting on the other side, arms out to catch the girls, while Micah watches in surprise. Entrapta quickly whirls to turn of f the machine, then hit another button.

"W ait, what as that?"

"A self-destruct button. So no one is tempted to try and open another portal."

"And how long do we have to run?"

"Sixty seconds." Entrapta pauses, realizing her mistake. "Um… oops."

Bow scoops Adora up and shouts, "Back to the skiff!"

They make it all the way to the skiff when the distant explosion echoes through the forge.

"To Bright Moon?" Entrapta confirms. Bow grins, nodding.

"To Bright Moon."

The princesses had been on edge after being called by Catra and Perfuma, and had already been on their way to Bright Moon when everything went sideways. Spinerella and Netossa arrive first, and are greeted by an exhausted Angella outside the door.

"What's going?"

Angella shakes her head, looking up at the star-filled sky. She has no idea how to answer that.

"Mom!"

Glimmer appears in front of Angella, throwing herself at her mother and hugging her tight. Angella holds her close, looking over the top of her head to see, of all people, Force Captain Scorpia standing there, pincers fiddling together.

"Um, your majesty?" She bows clumsily. Netossa and Spinerella look at her, then at Angella, then at Glimmer. Angella follows their gaze.

"Glimmer, what is going on?"

"I was just trying to fix things," she whispers, voice muffled. "I'm so sorry."

Perfuma, Mermista, Sea Hawk, and Frosta arrive, all looking a little worse for wear. Clearly Angella isn't the only one who experienced… whatever just happened.

"Horde," Netossa calls. Everyone immediately goes stiff, turning to the approaching skiff. Glimmer relaxes slightly when she sees Entrapta and Bow.

"It's okay. They're good."

"They *are*?"

Angella's focus is drawn away from the two figures upfront, falling on a man standing in the back. A man with long, scraggly, graying hair, a beard that is, quite honestly, out of control, familiar eyes, and an expression Angella has only seen in one other face – her daughter's.

"*Micah*?"

Angella's awed whisper draws Glimmer's attention. There's indeed another man with them. But that's not… he isn't… he can't be…

The skiff stops, and the man immediately jumps off, taking a few steps forward. "Angie?" he says uncertainly. Tears fill Angella's eyes in a rare show of emotion. She closes the space between them, hugging him tight. He looks like he's coming home as he slides his arms around her. Glimmer steps closer, watching, eyes wide. She looks at Bow for a moment. He shrugs as if to say, *long story*, and she turns back to the man.

"Dad?" Her voice is small. Micah looks down at her, blowing out a long, deep breath.

"Glimmer. My little… you're so big"—

Glimmer throws her arms around him, holding him tight. She's not really sure what to say. If there are even words for the way she feels. Her father is *alive*. It feels like so much more than a miracle.

Scorpia approaches the skiff. Entrapta meets her gaze for a moment, smiling, before they both look at Adora. She's unconscious, and has definitely seen better days, but she's… *there*. She's alive. Her chest is moving, rising and falling, steady and easy. She's really alive.

"You did it," Scorpia whispers, awed. "You saved her."

"Someone wanna explain what's going on?" Mermista asks flatly. She definitely remembers stopping Catra from murdering Shadow Weaver after Adora sacrificed herself. Glimmer starts to speak, then stops, looking around.

"Wait, where's Catra?"

"She said she was going to get answers from Light Hope," Angella says quietly. Bow and Glimmer exchange looks, and Glimmer grabs Bow's hand, teleporting them away.

They find Catra on the ground in front of the Crystal Castle, curled up with her knees to her chest, the hilt of the broken sword in her hand.

"Catra?" Glimmer calls quietly. She shakes her head, hiding her face in her knees.

"I ruined everything." Her voice is barely audible. "I'm so sorry."

"No." Glimmer and Bow kneel on either side of her, hugging her tight. "It's not your fault, Catra, you didn't. There's so much we have to talk about," Glimmer says quietly. "Come back to Bright Moon with us. There's something there for you."

Catra looks up, miserable, meeting first her gaze, then Bow's. He nods, and she relents, letting Glimmer take her back.

It takes Catra a moment to figure out what she's supposed to be looking for. The princesses are all there, there's a man ~~is~~ is that King Micah? Scorpia and Entrapta are here, well that's weird, and…

Her heart stutters for a moment, the hilt slipping from her hand and dropping to the ground with a dull *thud*. No. It cant be.

Ocean blue eyes meet the stunned, bi-colored gaze. An eternity seems to pass between them as they stare, trying to reconcile with reality. Catra finally manages to get her voice to work, trying to ignore the way her voice cracks as she says the two, familiar words. "H-Hey Adora."

Adora looks exhausted, her eyes slightly sunken and sporting heavy, bruise-like bags which stand out against her too pale skin. Her hair is loose, hanging around her shoulders in a way Catra knows she hates. She hasnt demanded a hair tie yet, which is amazing. But she still smiles, sliding off the skiff. Her movements are stiff and uncertain, her legs shaking. But she's there. She's *there*. She's there, and Catra has no idea what she's supposed to make of that.

The space between them is closed by Catra sprinting forward and barreling into her, holding her tight. Adora all but collapses into the hug, clinging to Catra for all she's worth.

"This isnt because I like you," Catra whispers hoarsely. Adora laughs.

"Of course it's not. No one would ever think that for even a minute. Dont worry."

Chapter End Notes

Oh boy. Wow. Here we are. This has been a *wild ride*, I swear, like. I honestly wanted to give up a few times because I was just stuck and couldn't deal with it. But y'all kept me going and got me to the end, and I am ridiculously grateful to everyone who's taken the time to read, review, kudos, bookmark, and tolerate all of these idiots (someone get them all to therapy).

"But Sam, where's season five?"

It's coming! I'll get into the nitty gritty details soon, but basically ~~be~~tween work, life, personal drama, the pandemic, pet drama (one of my doggos needed surgery and he's okay now, but the tumor they took out is reoccurring, so we've got to deal with that), mental health drama, and honestly just being alive, I am completely wiped out, and I really need a break from the pressure of weekly updates, which means I need to get a good chunk of season five written before I can start posting it. And I've already started it! I've got like a chapter written lol. But I'm not letting things go now. How ridiculous would that be now that I've gotten this far? I'm getting this monster through season five, which is more of a reason to take a break before I really do crash and burn.

SO. I'm taking the rest of April off (all 1.5 weeks of it) to relax, then getting straight back into things for May. I will also hopefully have energy to write other things (I have thoughts for a little side-series to Always A Heartbeat From Me that I think would be fun to work on, and other shorter stories that I'd like to share at some point), so I'm not just completely going off the map. As for when season five will come along... I'm aiming for the last Friday of July – 7/30. That seems realistic enough for me to get a good amount of work done while also not being *f o r e v e r*. And no, I will not forget. There's so much to look forward to! I mean, they're back in the wider universe now. Mayhaps they'll make a trip to Kytis to find a certain alien cat? Also literally nothing is fixed between Glimmer and Catra. That friendship is in pieces. And what of Adora? Oh she's fine, don't worry :) Also

I've already got a really cool title for season five so how could I just ditch it now?

Title: Smoke and Mirrors
Summary: ~~M~~agicatra Season 5—
Nothing is okay.

The sword is broken, Horde Prime is invading, and Etheria is falling apart. Catra would've thought having her best friend at her side again would make things better, but something is wrong. Something she can't quite put her finger on.

The stakes are higher than ever, and Catra can't afford to be distracted. The world still needs She-Ra.

She has to be ready to fight. No matter what.
In the meantime if you're feeling a need for a Magicatra fix, you can follow me on tumblr, catrasredemption, I've started posting small bits of meta about the au, and it has an entire page dedicated to it! I'm so far from done with this universe. I promise.

ANYWAY. Thank you so much for reading to this point, if you made it this far. I know I babbled a bit. Thank you for reading, and don't worry - Magicatra WILL be back.

End Notes

Find me at https://catrasredemption.tumblr.com/ to yell at me or ask me questions (I might answer!)

I've added a new page to my tumblr all about the magicatra au: https://catrasredemption.tumblr.com/magicat I'll be expanding more on things as I go, but if you're curious, check it out!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!